

# The Sermon on the Mount as Politics

*Reading the Kingdom's Constitution Without the  
Spiritualizing*

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JAMES BELL

## The Sermon on the Mount as Politics

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Unless otherwise noted, Scripture quotations are from the English Standard Version (ESV).

*The Sermon on the Mount is the most complete  
delineation anywhere in the New Testament of the  
Christian counter-culture.*

JOHN STOTT, 1978

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## INTRODUCTION

# The Most Political Sermon Ever Preached

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**I SPENT YEARS PREACHING** the Sermon on the Mount as if it were about my inner life, and I want to tell you why that was a mistake, because it was the same mistake almost everyone makes, and it is the mistake this whole book exists to undo.

I would take the Beatitudes and turn them into a mood. Blessed are the poor in spirit became a feeling I was supposed to have about myself, a kind of recommended humility, a posture for my private devotions. Blessed are the peacemakers became a word about not holding grudges. Turn the other cheek became a lesson in personal patience, something to apply when a coworker annoyed me. I took the most public address Jesus ever gave, a sermon delivered on a hillside to crowds who were living under military occupation, and I shrank it down until it fit inside my own chest, and I called that faithfulness. It was not faithfulness. It was a way of keeping the sermon from doing what it was sent to do.

Here is what I missed for too long. When Jesus climbed that hill and sat down and began to teach, he was not offering

tips for a calmer interior life. He was announcing a government. He was describing, in concrete and unmistakable terms, what life looks like when God is actually king, and he was doing it in a world that already had a king, a Caesar, a temple establishment, a whole arrangement of power that ran on violence and money and fear. Every line of the sermon lands differently the moment you remember that. Blessed are the meek, for they shall inherit the earth, is not a private sentiment. It is a claim about who ends up owning the world, and it is a direct contradiction of how the world believed ownership worked, which was that the earth belongs to the people with the chariots. Jesus stood in an occupied territory and told a crowd of nobodies that the future belonged to them and not to Rome, and we have managed to turn it into a verse for refrigerator magnets.

The Sermon on the Mount is political. I do not mean it is partisan, and I am going to spend a good deal of this book making sure you do not hear me saying that, because the first thing the modern church does with the word political is sort it into left and right, and the sermon will not be sorted that way. It indicts both sides of every argument we are currently having. What I mean by political is older and larger than our elections. I mean that the sermon is about how a community orders its common life, how power is held and used, how the poor are treated, how enemies are dealt with, how money is regarded, how truth is told, how justice is done. Those are political questions in the deepest sense, the sense the ancient world understood, and Jesus answers every one of them, and his answers are so far outside the range of what any nation has ever attempted that we have mostly decided he could not have meant them and have quietly filed them under spirituality instead.

I am writing this book because I think the spiritualizing has cost us almost everything. We took a sermon that was meant to create a visible, peculiar, public people, a city on a hill that the watching world could not help but see, and we used it to manage our private feelings, and the result is a church that looks, in its actual political behavior, exactly like the nation around it. We fight the way our neighbors fight. We hoard the way our neighbors hoard. We fear the way our neighbors fear. We hate our enemies with the same fluency as everyone else and quote a different book while we do it. And the world looks at us and sees nothing it could not get anywhere else, no alternative, no contrast, no city on a hill, just one more interest group scrambling for the same power by the same means. The sermon was supposed to make us unmistakable. We have made it invisible.

So this book is an attempt to read the Sermon on the Mount the way I now believe it was meant to be read, as the founding document of a new kind of community, a constitution for a different kingdom, and to refuse the long habit of shrinking it down until it stops being dangerous. I am going to walk through it slowly, Matthew chapter five through chapter seven, and at every point I am going to ask the question we have trained ourselves not to ask, which is not what does this mean for my private spiritual life but what does this mean for how we actually live together, with each other and with our enemies and with our money and with the people the world has thrown away. That is the question the sermon answers. It is a more demanding question than the one I used to ask. It is also the only one that does the text justice.

I should say plainly where I am writing from, because it shapes everything. I came to faith out of atheism as a grown

man, and one of the things that broke through my unbelief was the Sermon on the Mount, read for the first time without anyone telling me what it was supposed to mean. I read it cold, and I remember thinking that no one actually lived like this, that if anyone did the world would be unable to ignore them, and that the very fact that I had never met such a community was itself a kind of argument against the church. I was right about the first part and wrong about the conclusion. The sermon really does describe a life almost no one is living. But that is not because it cannot be lived. It is because we decided, somewhere along the way, that it was not really meant to be. This book is my attempt to take it back, to read it as the marching orders it is, and to count the cost of actually obeying it, which is high, and which is the point.

Come up the mountain with me. Sit down where the crowd sat. And hear the sermon as the people who first heard it heard it, not as a guide to feeling better, but as the announcement that everything they thought they knew about power was about to be turned upside down by a carpenter with no army, who was, it would turn out, the King.

## CHAPTER ONE

# Up the Mountain

---

**BEFORE JESUS SAYS** A single word, Matthew tells us where he is standing, and the location is the first thing the crowd would have understood and the first thing we miss.

He went up on the mountain. That is the whole sentence, and to us it is scenery, a detail about geography, the kind of thing we read past on the way to the important material. To a Jewish audience in the first century it was a thunderclap. There was one mountain that mattered in the memory of that people, one mountain where a man had gone up to receive the law that made a wandering crowd of former slaves into a nation, and that was Sinai, where Moses climbed into the cloud and came down with the commandments that would order the common life of Israel for the next fifteen hundred years. Matthew has spent his first four chapters quietly painting Jesus as a new Moses, brought out of Egypt, passing through the waters, tested in the wilderness for a symbolic forty, and now, deliberately, unmistakably, he sends him up a mountain to deliver a law to a people. No one in that crowd would have missed it. The man on the hill is doing again the thing that founded the nation. He is giving a constitution.

But notice what is different, because the differences are the message. Moses went up the mountain alone and the people were warned to stay back, not to touch the holy mountain on pain of death, kept at a trembling distance from a God too dangerous to approach. Jesus goes up the mountain and the people come with him. He sits down, which is what a teacher did, what a king did, what someone with settled authority did, and the crowd gathers close enough to hear an ordinary speaking voice. The new lawgiver does not thunder from a cloud behind a barricade. He sits on the grass and lets the nobodies come near. The form of the thing already tells you the content. The kingdom Jesus is about to describe is one in which the distance between God and the people has collapsed, in which the law is not handed down from a terrifying height but spoken at eye level by one who has come to live among them. That is not a small adjustment. That is the gospel built into the staging.

And who is in the crowd. Matthew has just told us, at the end of chapter four. They came from Galilee and the Decapolis and Jerusalem and Judea and beyond the Jordan, and they brought the sick, the demon-possessed, the epileptics, the paralyzed. This is not an audience of the settled and the comfortable. This is a crowd of the desperate, the occupied, the poor, the people for whom the existing arrangement of power had produced mostly suffering. They live under Rome, which taxes them into poverty and crucifies their troublemakers along the roads as a warning. They live under a temple aristocracy that has largely made its peace with Rome. They are, most of them, one bad harvest from ruin. And it is to exactly these people that Jesus is about to say, blessed are you, the kingdom is yours. The sermon is addressed, from its first word, to the bottom of the social

order, and any reading of it that forgets who is sitting on that hillside will go wrong on the very first line.

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from a cloud behind a barricade. He  
sits down on the grass and lets the  
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---

**I LABOR THIS BECAUSE** the setting controls the meaning, and we have been trained to ignore the setting. We come to the Sermon on the Mount as comfortable people in a comfortable church looking for personal enrichment, and we read words that were spoken to occupied peasants by a man announcing the overthrow of everything that was crushing them, and we wonder why it feels a little flat. It feels flat because we have removed it from the only place it makes sense. Put it back. Imagine the chariots on the roads and the crosses on the hills and the tax collectors at their tables and the desperate sick laid out on the grass, and then hear a poor man with no army and no office sit down on a mountain and begin to describe a kingdom in which all of that is reversed. That is the sermon. It was never calm. It was an act of breathtaking nerve, an announcement of regime change delivered to the regime's victims, and the only reason it sounds tame to us is that we have spent centuries sanding off everything sharp about it.

There is one more thing about the mountain. Jesus goes

up, but the whole arc of the gospel is that he is going to come down, all the way down, lower than the crowd, lower than anyone, down to a different hill outside the city where the empire will nail him up as one more troublemaker. The lawgiver who climbs this mountain to describe the kingdom will descend to a cross to establish it, and that order matters. He does not impose the kingdom from the height. He inaugurates it from the bottom, by dying, which is itself the deepest political statement in the sermon, made not in words but in his own body. Keep that ending in view as we climb. The man describing this kingdom is going to prove he means it by refusing every shortcut to power and letting the powers kill him instead. That is the only reason we can trust a word he says about meekness and enemies and the cross we are each told to take up. He went first.

## CHAPTER TWO

# Blessed Are the Wrong People

---

**THE SERMON OPENS WITH** a list of blessings, and every one of them is aimed at the wrong people, and that is not an accident, that is the entire strategy.

We call them the Beatitudes, from the Latin word for blessed, and familiarity has worn them smooth, but try to hear them as a first-time listener on that hill. Blessed are the poor in spirit. Blessed are those who mourn. Blessed are the meek. Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for justice. Blessed are the merciful, the pure in heart, the peacemakers, the persecuted. Now line that up against every other definition of the blessed life that the ancient world, or our world, has ever produced, and feel the collision. The world blesses the powerful, the secure, the winners, the people with full barns and strong armies and good fortune. Every culture in history has agreed on roughly who the blessed are, and they are never the people on this list. Jesus opens his constitution by walking straight up to the universal human consensus about the good life and declaring it wrong, naming

as blessed exactly the people every society has agreed are cursed.

This is not encouragement. We read the Beatitudes as gentle comfort, a soft word for sad people, and they are comforting, but underneath the comfort is a detonation. Jesus is announcing that the kingdom of God runs on an inverted economy, that the things the world counts as loss are the things the kingdom counts as wealth, and that when God is finally and fully king, the entire ranking of human beings is going to be turned over. The first will be last. The last will be first. The people the world stepped on are going to inherit the earth, and the people who did the stepping are going to find they built their lives on the losing side of history. That is a political claim. It is a claim about who is going up and who is going down when the real government arrives, and it is addressed, pointedly, to a crowd that the existing government had placed firmly at the bottom.

Notice the verbs and their timing, because they hold the whole thing together. Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs IS the kingdom of heaven. Present tense. It is already theirs. But blessed are those who mourn, for they SHALL be comforted. Future tense. The Beatitudes live in the gap between the already and the not yet, between a kingdom that has genuinely arrived in the person of Jesus and a kingdom that has not yet been consummated, and that gap is the exact space the church is called to live in. We are people who can say the kingdom is already ours while we are still mourning, still hungering, still being persecuted, because the King has come but the kingdom is not yet complete. To live as a Christian is to stand in that gap, claiming a reign that is real but not yet visible, and refusing to live as though the world's present arrangement is the final word. The Beatitudes are the

posture of people who know the ending and are willing to live by it now, before it arrives, at cost.

---

*Jesus opens his constitution by walking  
up to the universal human consensus  
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---

**AND HERE IS THE** part that should stop us. These are not eight different groups of people, eight personality types, as though some Christians are the meek ones and others are the merciful ones and you should find your category. They are a single portrait. They describe one kind of person, the citizen of the kingdom, seen from eight angles. The same person is poor in spirit and mourning and meek and hungry for justice and merciful and pure in heart and a peacemaker and, as a result of all of it, persecuted. It is a composite picture of what a human being looks like when the reign of God has actually taken hold of them, and it is a picture so unlike the strong, secure, self-sufficient ideal our culture sells that to become this person is to become visibly strange. That is the goal. The Beatitudes are not a mood. They are a description of the citizens of a new nation, and the nation is meant to be so different from every other nation that the world cannot help but notice it. We will take them one at a time, because each one is a small revolution, and together they are the overthrow of everything we thought we knew about who is winning.

## CHAPTER THREE

# The Poor and the Politics of Need

---

**BLESSED ARE THE POOR** in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven. It is the first beatitude, the doorway to all the others, and we have spent centuries making sure it cannot embarrass us.

The spiritualizing instinct goes to work on this verse faster than anywhere else in the sermon. Poor in spirit, we say, with relief, means humble, means aware of your spiritual need, means recognizing that you are a sinner before God, and all of that is true, and none of it is wrong, and it is also a way of making very sure that we never have to think about actual poverty. Because Matthew says poor in spirit, but Luke, recording the same sermon or one like it, simply says blessed are you who are poor, with no qualifier at all, and the early church held both of those together without our anxiety. The first people to hear this were literally poor, materially poor, poor in the way that means hungry, and Jesus was telling them that the kingdom belonged to them. The phrase poor in spirit does not erase that. It deepens it. It points to the inner

reality that material poverty often produces and that material comfort almost always destroys, which is the knowledge that you have nothing to bring, that you cannot save yourself, that you are dependent, that you stand before God with empty hands.

This is the doorway because it is the one posture in which the kingdom can be received. The kingdom of God cannot be bought, earned, achieved, or deserved. It can only be received as a gift by people who know they have nothing to pay with, and that knowledge comes hard to the rich and comparatively easy to the poor, which is why Jesus said elsewhere that it is harder for a rich man to enter the kingdom than for a camel to go through a needle's eye. He was not being poetic. He was naming a spiritual mechanism. Wealth, security, and self-sufficiency build in us the precise illusion that makes the kingdom impossible to receive, the illusion that we are fine, that we have what we need, that we are the kind of people things work out for. The poor in spirit have had that illusion stripped away, whether by circumstance or by grace, and they stand before God in the one condition he can actually fill, which is empty.

I have to be careful here, because there is a way of saying this that romanticizes poverty, that turns the suffering of actual poor people into a spiritual advantage we comfortable Christians can admire from a distance, and that is its own obscenity. Jesus is not saying poverty is good. He spent his ministry feeding the hungry and healing the sick, treating their poverty and pain as evils to be relieved, not blessings to be preserved. What he is saying is that the kingdom comes to people from below, that it enters the world at the bottom of the social order and works its way up, and that the rich and secure, if they want in, are going to have to come down to

where the poor already are, to the place of empty hands, of admitted need, of dependence on a grace they did not earn. The poor are already there. The rich have to be brought there, usually by losing something, which is why our losses are so often the only doorways grace can find.

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*The kingdom enters the world at the  
bottom and works its way up. The rich,  
if they want in, will have to come  
down to where the poor already are, to  
the place of empty hands.*

---

**SO WHAT DOES THIS** do to our politics, in the larger sense I have been pressing. It means a community formed by this beatitude can never adopt the world's contempt for the poor, can never treat need as failure and security as virtue, can never build a church that is comfortable for the comfortable and alien to the desperate. A church living out the first beatitude will be a place where the poor in spirit, in both senses, are at home, where need is not hidden but admitted, where no one has to perform self-sufficiency to belong. And it will be deeply suspicious of its own wealth, aware that the very things the world calls blessings are the things most likely to keep it from the kingdom. That is a political stance. It puts a community at odds with a culture organized around the accumulation and display of exactly the security Jesus says is so spiritually dangerous. The first beatitude is not a recommendation to feel humble. It is the foundation of a

community that has made its peace with need, its own and its neighbors', and has stopped pretending that the people with full barns are the ones God is blessing.

## CHAPTER FOUR

# Those Who Mourn, and the Refusal to Pretend

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**BLESSED ARE THOSE WHO** mourn, for they shall be comforted. Of all the Beatitudes this is the one we most want to rush past, because it sits on something we organize our entire lives to avoid, which is grief, and the willingness to feel it.

We live in a culture that has declared mourning a problem to be managed and ideally skipped. We medicate it, distract it, hurry it, and above all we hide it, because sadness reads as failure in a society built on the relentless performance of being fine. And the church has too often baptized this, turning faith into a mandatory cheerfulness, a smiling competence, a refusal to admit that anything is wrong, as though grief were a sign of weak belief and the truly faithful float above it. Into all of that Jesus says, blessed are those who mourn, and he means it as a frontal assault on the whole arrangement. He is blessing the people who have refused to pretend. He is blessing the ones who are willing to look at the world as it actually is, broken, violent, full of loss, and to feel

the appropriate grief about it instead of numbing themselves into a comfortable blindness.

Because mourning, in the sermon, is not just private bereavement, though it includes that. It is the grief of people who see what is wrong and refuse to make peace with it. The prophets mourned. They wept over a nation that had abandoned justice, over a temple that had become a den of robbers, over the suffering of the poor that everyone else had learned to walk past. Jesus himself wept over Jerusalem, mourned at the tomb of his friend, was a man of sorrows acquainted with grief. To mourn, in this sense, is to keep your heart soft enough to be broken by the things that break the heart of God, and that is a far more demanding and a far more political posture than the private management of personal sadness. It means looking at the violence and the poverty and the injustice and the sheer wrongness of the world and refusing the anesthesia that everyone around you is taking. It means staying awake to pain in a culture committed to sleep.

This is costly, and it is supposed to be. The people who mourn in the deep sense are not comfortable people, and they are not comforting to be around, because their grief is a standing accusation against everyone who has decided not to feel it. The prophets were hated for it. They came mourning into rooms full of people celebrating, and they named the thing no one wanted named, and they were expelled for it, sometimes killed for it. To be a person who mourns the right things is to be permanently a little out of step with a world that has agreed to look away, and the church, when it is faithful, is a community of such people, a gathered congregation of the unnumbed, who will not pretend the world is fine and will not let the suffering of their neighbors

disappear behind a wall of programmed positivity.

---

*To mourn is to keep your heart soft  
enough to be broken by the things that  
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to sleep.*

---

**AND TO THEM, AND** only to them, comes the promise. They shall be comforted. Not the people who avoided the grief, who stayed safe behind their distractions, but the ones who let themselves feel it. There is a comfort that is only available on the far side of mourning, that cannot reach the people who refused to grieve, because they sealed themselves off from the very wound the comfort would have entered. The gospel does not offer to help us skip the sorrow. It offers to meet us in it, and the meeting is the comfort, the presence of the God who is himself a mourner, who has wept the tears we are afraid to weep. A church that has the courage to mourn is a church that knows this comfort, and a church committed to relentless cheerfulness has locked itself out of it. The second beatitude blesses the broken-hearted and promises them the one thing the unbroken can never have, which is the comfort that only comes to those honest enough to need it.

## CHAPTER FIVE

# The Meek Shall Inherit the Earth

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**BLESSED ARE THE MEEK**, for they shall inherit the earth. Here is the beatitude that should end the argument about whether the sermon is political, because it makes a flatly political claim, a claim about who ends up owning the world, and it gives the world to exactly the people the world is certain will never have it.

First we have to rescue the word meek, because we hear it as weak, as timid, as a doormat quality, a spinelessness that lets everyone walk over you, and that is the opposite of what it meant. The Greek word was used for a powerful animal that had been brought under control, a war horse trained to obey, strength that has been disciplined and placed under authority. Meekness is not the absence of power. It is power that has refused to grasp, strength that will not dominate, force held deliberately in check and bent toward the service of others instead of the seizure of advantage. Moses was called the meekest man on the earth, and Moses confronted Pharaoh and led a nation. Jesus called himself meek and

lowly, and Jesus drove the money changers out of the temple with a whip. Meekness is the strong man's refusal to use his strength to take, and it is one of the rarest and most costly things a human being can practice, because everything in us, and everything in our culture, says that strength exists to be used for ourselves.

Now hear the promise attached to it, and hear it in the world it was spoken into. They shall inherit the earth. In a land occupied by the most powerful military the world had ever seen, where everyone knew that the earth belonged to those with the chariots and the legions and the will to use them, Jesus told a crowd of the conquered that the meek would inherit it. This is a direct contradiction of the entire logic of empire. Rome's whole claim was that the strong take and hold the earth, that power is for conquest, that the meek are precisely the ones who get plowed under. And Jesus says no. He says the world's arrangement is temporary and false, that in the end the earth will not belong to the people who seized it but to the people who refused to seize it, and that the long arc of God's kingdom runs directly opposite to the short, brutal logic of domination. The meek will inherit the earth, which means the violent will not get to keep it.

This is the political heart of the sermon in a single line, and you can see why it had to be spiritualized into harmlessness, because taken literally it is one of the most subversive sentences ever spoken. It tells the powerful that their power is a borrowed thing on a short lease. It tells the conquered that their patience is not foolishness but faith, that the refusal to take up the sword is not surrender but a wager on a different ending. And it tells the church that our hope is not in seizing power, not in becoming strong enough to impose our will, not in winning the game of domination on

the world's terms, but in a coming kingdom where domination itself is overthrown and the earth is handed to those who would not grab it. Every time the church has reached for the sword, for the throne, for the levers of coercive power, it has betrayed this beatitude. It has decided that meekness is a fine private virtue but that out in the real world you have to play to win, and in deciding that, it has stopped believing the sermon.

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*Meekness is the strong man's refusal to  
use his strength to take. And Jesus told  
the conquered that this, not the  
chariot, is what finally inherits the  
earth.*

---

**I FELT THE FORCE** of this beatitude as an unbeliever, before I knew what to do with it. I had assumed Christianity was, like every other religion and ideology, a strategy for the people holding it to gain power, and then I read that the meek would inherit the earth and could not square it with anything I had seen the church actually doing. The gap between the sermon and the church was, for me, an obstacle to faith, and I think it is an obstacle to faith for a great many people who are watching us reach for exactly the kind of power Jesus told us to lay down. The meek inherit the earth. Not the strong. Not the loud. Not the ones who win the culture war by the culture's own weapons. If we believed that, we would live in a way that the watching world could not explain, and that

## THE SERMON ON THE MOUNT AS POLITICS

inexplicable life would be a more powerful argument than all our reaching for control has ever been. The beatitude is a promise, but it is also a test, and the church has mostly been failing it for seventeen centuries, ever since the day we decided that inheriting the earth could not wait and that we would take it ourselves.

## CHAPTER SIX

# Hunger and Thirst for Justice

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**BLESSED ARE THOSE WHO** hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they shall be satisfied. I have to stop on the word righteousness, because the way we hear it has quietly cut this beatitude in half, and the missing half is the political one.

When we read righteousness, we hear personal morality, private holiness, the state of an individual soul that has gotten its behavior in order before God. That is part of it. But the Greek word, and the Hebrew concept underneath it, is far wider than personal virtue. The word is *dikaiosyne*, and it carries the freight of the Hebrew *tsedaqah*, which means right relationship, things set right, the world put back into the order God intended, and it stands in the Old Testament shoulder to shoulder with *mishpat*, justice, the two of them appearing together again and again as the pair of things God most requires. To hunger and thirst for righteousness is to ache for the world to be made right, not just for your own soul to be clean but for justice to roll down like waters, for the

hungry to be fed and the oppressed to be freed and the crooked things to be made straight. It is a hunger for the kingdom to come in full, and the kingdom, when it comes, is a just kingdom, a place where the wrongs are righted and the victims are vindicated and the predators are stopped.

So this beatitude blesses the people who cannot make peace with injustice, who feel the wrongness of the world as a physical craving, a hunger, a thirst, the most insistent appetites the body has. Jesus did not say blessed are those who have a mild preference for fairness. He said hunger and thirst, the language of desperate need, the appetite of the starving and the parched, and he attached it to righteousness understood as the setting right of all things. The citizens of the kingdom are people who want justice the way a starving man wants bread, who are not satisfied by their own private piety while the world remains full of oppression, who carry in their bodies a longing for the day when God will finally judge the earth in righteousness and every wrong will be answered. That is a political hunger. It puts a person at odds with every arrangement that profits from injustice, and it refuses the comfortable religion that cares for the soul and ignores the suffering body of the neighbor.

I want to name how easily the church loses this, because I have lost it myself. It is entirely possible to be passionate about personal righteousness, about clean living and right doctrine and individual holiness, and to feel nothing at all about injustice, to walk past the oppression of the poor with a clear conscience because your own behavior is in order. That is a religion the prophets despised. Isaiah's God says he hates the religious festivals of people whose hands are full of injustice, that he will not listen to the prayers of those who trample the needy, that the worship he wants is to loose the

bonds of wickedness and let the oppressed go free. A hunger for personal righteousness that does not include a hunger for justice is not the righteousness of the kingdom. It is the very thing the prophets condemned, a private holiness used as a shield against the demands of love. Jesus puts the two back together. To hunger for righteousness is to hunger for both, for a clean heart and a just world, and to refuse to be satisfied with either one alone.

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*To hunger and thirst for righteousness  
is to ache for the world to be made  
right. It is to want justice the way a  
starving man wants bread.*

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**AND THE PROMISE IS** that this hunger, unlike every other hunger, will be satisfied. They shall be filled. There is no guarantee in the sermon that the meek will see their inheritance in their lifetime or that the mourners will be comforted on a schedule that suits them, and there is no guarantee that those who hunger for justice will see it done before they die. The satisfaction is eschatological. It belongs to the kingdom in its fullness, to the day when God sets the world right once and for all. But it is a guarantee. The hunger is not a cruel appetite for something that will never come. It is the appetite for the one thing that is certain, the coming reign of God, in which justice is not a fragile human achievement always slipping away but the settled and permanent state of a redeemed creation. To hunger and thirst for that is to want the surest thing in the universe, and to be promised, against

all present evidence, that you will be filled. That promise is what lets the church work for justice without despair, because we are not trying to build the just kingdom by our own strength. We are hungering for the one God has promised to bring, and laboring now as a sign of the satisfaction we have been guaranteed.

## CHAPTER SEVEN

# Mercy, Purity, and the Peacemakers

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**THE NEXT THREE BLESSINGS** move quickly, and they belong together, because they describe how the citizens of the kingdom treat the people around them, and they reach a climax in a word that the church has spent two thousand years trying to escape.

Blessed are the merciful, for they shall obtain mercy. Mercy is love directed at need and at fault, kindness extended to people who are suffering and to people who are guilty, and it is the opposite of the world's instinct, which is to help the deserving and punish the failing. The merciful are the ones who do not insist on the last ounce of what they are owed, who forgive debts, who treat the people who have wronged them with a gentleness those people have not earned. And the promise has a strange shape, almost a warning. They shall obtain mercy, which implies that the unmerciful will not, that there is a deep reciprocity built into the moral universe whereby the mercy you extend is the mercy you will receive. Jesus will say it more sharply later in the sermon,

that if you forgive others your Father will forgive you, and if you do not, he will not. The merciful are not earning forgiveness by their mercy. They are demonstrating that they have understood it, because no one who has truly received mercy can withhold it, and anyone who withholds it is showing that they never really grasped what they were given.

Blessed are the pure in heart, for they shall see God. Purity of heart is singleness, an undivided life, a heart that is not split between God and a hundred competing loyalties but is aimed, however imperfectly, at one thing. The pure in heart are not the sinless, who do not exist, but the integrated, the people whose interior life is not a tangle of hidden agendas and secret idolatries, who are, as far as a fallen person can be, what they appear to be. And only they shall see God, because a divided heart cannot perceive him, cannot recognize the holy when it appears, having spent so long looking at everything else. This is a quieter beatitude, more interior than the others, but it has its public edge too, because a community of the pure in heart is a community without the rot of hidden corruption, without the gap between the face shown to the world and the deals made in the dark, and such a community is rare enough to be a kind of miracle in a world where everyone is performing one thing and pursuing another.

And then the climax. Blessed are the peacemakers, for they shall be called sons of God. Of all the Beatitudes this is the one the church has most needed to evade, because we have spent most of our history making war and blessing it, and here is Jesus saying that the peacemakers, not the warriors, are the ones who will be called the children of God. Notice he does not say the peace-lovers, or the peaceful, or the people who avoid conflict. He says the peacemakers, the

ones who actively make peace, who go into situations of hostility and do the costly work of reconciliation, who stand between enemies and absorb the hostility instead of passing it on. That is not passivity. It is one of the most dangerous things a person can do, to step into the space between people who hate each other and try to make peace, because the peacemaker usually gets struck by both sides. Jesus would know. He is the peacemaker, the one who steps between God and a hostile humanity and makes peace by his own blood, and it costs him his life, and he is calling his followers to the same work and the same risk.

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*The peacemakers, not the warriors, are  
the ones who will be called the children  
of God. Jesus does not bless the peaceful.  
He blesses the ones who do the  
dangerous work of making peace.*

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**TO BE CALLED A** son of God, in that culture, meant to bear the family resemblance, to be recognizably your father's child, to do what your father does. So Jesus is saying that the people who make peace are the ones who look like God, who carry his likeness into the world, who are doing the family business. And the church, when it has taken up the sword, when it has blessed the armies and sanctified the wars and treated peacemaking as a naive irrelevance for people who do not understand how the real world works, has forfeited the family resemblance. It has stopped looking like its Father. I

am not going to pretend this is simple, that there are no hard questions about violence and defense and a world full of genuine evil, and we will come to the heart of those questions when we reach the command to love our enemies. But the beatitude stands over all of it as a verdict. The peacemakers are the sons of God. If we want to be recognized as his children, the family trade is peace, made at cost, in the dangerous space between enemies, the way our brother made it for us.

## CHAPTER EIGHT

# Blessed When They Persecute You

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**THE BEATITUDES END WHERE** the others have been pointing all along, with persecution, and the fact that the list arrives here is the most honest thing about it.

Blessed are those who are persecuted for righteousness' sake, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven. And then Jesus does something he has not done with any of the other blessings. He expands it, he repeats it, he shifts from the general third person to the direct second person and drives it straight at the people in front of him. Blessed are you when others revile you and persecute you and utter all kinds of evil against you falsely on my account. He doubles the length of this beatitude because he wants no one to miss it, and because he knows that this is the one that will tempt his followers to think they have taken a wrong turn. The other Beatitudes describe a beautiful, costly character. This one describes what the world does to people who have that character, and the answer is that it attacks them, and Jesus wants his people to understand, from the very beginning, that

the attack is not a sign that something has gone wrong. It is a sign that something has gone right.

This is the logical conclusion of everything that came before, and you can trace the line. A community that is poor in spirit and mourns the world's wrongs and refuses to dominate and hungers for justice and makes peace instead of war is a standing rebuke to a world organized around the opposite of all those things, and the world does not receive rebukes gladly. The powerful do not like being told their power is on a short lease. The violent do not like being told the meek will inherit what they seized. The comfortable do not like the mourners who refuse to pretend everything is fine. A church that actually lived the Beatitudes would be intolerable to the principalities and powers, a permanent irritant, an alternative that exposes the lie of the dominant order simply by existing, and such a church would be persecuted, not because it went looking for a fight but because its very life is a threat to everything the world has built. Jesus is telling his people that faithfulness and opposition are linked, that to live the sermon is to invite the hostility of the systems the sermon judges, and that this is normal, expected, even a kind of confirmation.

This is where I have to be careful, because there is a counterfeit of this beatitude that has become epidemic, especially among comfortable Christians in powerful nations, and it is the persecution complex. It is the habit of interpreting every loss of cultural privilege, every criticism, every moment of not getting our way, as persecution for righteousness' sake, as though being made slightly less dominant were the same as being reviled for the kingdom. Jesus is precise here. He says persecuted for righteousness' sake, reviled falsely on my account, and that precision rules

out most of what we call persecution. Being criticized because you were cruel is not persecution. Losing an argument is not persecution. Having to share power you were used to monopolizing is not persecution. The blessing is for those who suffer because they were righteous, because they hungered for justice and made peace and refused to dominate, and were attacked precisely for those things. That is a narrow gate, and most of our grievances do not fit through it.

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*Faithfulness and opposition are linked. A church that actually lived the Beatitudes would be intolerable to the powers, and the attack would be a sign that something had gone right.*

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**REJOICE AND BE GLAD**, Jesus says, for your reward is great in heaven, for so they persecuted the prophets who were before you. He places his persecuted followers in a lineage, the line of the prophets, the people who told the truth to power and paid for it, who mourned over the nation and were expelled from the sanctuary, who hungered for justice and were killed for it. To be persecuted for righteousness is to join that company, to take your place in the long tradition of those who would not make peace with the world's injustice and bore the cost. And the reward is great, not as a wage earned but as the certain future of those who belong to a kingdom the world is currently rejecting. The Beatitudes end here because

this is where the costly, beautiful life of the kingdom leads in a world that is not yet the kingdom, and Jesus will not pretend otherwise. He blesses his people and then tells them the truth, that the blessing and the suffering come together, that the city on the hill is also the target on the hill, and that they should rejoice anyway, because the persecution is the proof that they are finally, dangerously, telling the truth.

## CHAPTER NINE

# Salt, Light, and a Visible People

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**HAVING DESCRIBED THE CITIZENS** of the kingdom, Jesus turns to describe their public function, and he does it with two images so familiar that we have stopped feeling how strange and demanding they are. You are the salt of the earth. You are the light of the world. Both of them say the same thing, and it is a thing the church has spent centuries trying to avoid. The kingdom is meant to be visible.

You are the salt of the earth. Salt in the ancient world was a preservative, the thing that kept meat from rotting, and it was a seasoning, the thing that gave food its savor, and either way it works by contact, by being rubbed into the thing it preserves, by being distributed through the thing it flavors. Salt sealed in a container does nothing. Its entire purpose requires it to be in contact with what it is meant to affect. So when Jesus calls his people the salt of the earth, he is saying that they exist for the sake of the world, that their function is to preserve it from the full rot of its own injustice and to give it a savor it would not otherwise have, and that this function

only works on contact, only works when the church is rubbed into the life of the world rather than sealed away from it. And then the warning. If the salt loses its saltiness, it is good for nothing, thrown out and trampled. A church that has become indistinguishable from the world around it, that has lost the very quality that made it salt, is not just ineffective. It is useless, fit only to be discarded. The danger Jesus names is not that the church will be too different from the world. It is that it will not be different enough.

You are the light of the world. A city on a hill cannot be hidden, and no one lights a lamp and puts it under a basket. Light exists to be seen, and a light that is hidden has contradicted its own nature. Jesus is telling his people that they are meant to be seen, that the kingdom is not a private interior arrangement but a public reality, a city set on a hill, a community whose common life is visible to everyone and cannot be hidden even if it wanted to. This is the death of all merely private Christianity, the faith that lives entirely in the heart and the home and never takes public, visible, communal shape. There is no such thing in the sermon. The kingdom is a city, a polis, a public community with a public life, and that public life is the light, the thing the world sees and is drawn to or repelled by. Hidden faith is a contradiction in terms, a lit lamp under a basket, a city somehow concealed. The whole point is to be seen.

But seen as what, and this is where Jesus controls the meaning so we cannot turn it into mere self-display. Let your light shine before others, he says, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father in heaven. The visibility is not for the church's glory but for God's. The world is meant to see the good works, the just and merciful and peacemaking life of the community, and to be drawn through

that visible goodness to the God who is its source. This rules out both errors at once. It rules out the hidden faith that refuses to be seen, and it rules out the performed faith that wants to be seen for its own sake, the public religiosity Jesus will attack a few verses later. The church is to be visible, unmistakably, a city that cannot be hidden, but the visibility points beyond itself to God, so that what the world finally sees is not how impressive the Christians are but how good their Father is.

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*The danger Jesus names is not that the church will be too different from the world. It is that it will not be different enough. Salt that has lost its savor is fit only to be thrown out.*

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**I FIND THIS PAIR** of images to be a standing judgment on the way the modern church has tried to have it both ways. We have wanted the security of being hidden, of a private faith that costs us nothing in public and asks nothing of our common life, and we have wanted the influence of being seen, of a Christianity that shapes the culture and wins the arguments and holds the power. The sermon allows neither. It says be visible, but be visible as salt and light, as a community so just and merciful and peaceable that the world is forced to notice and is drawn through you to God. The visibility Jesus commands is not the visibility of a voting bloc or a culture-war combatant or a brand. It is the visibility of

goodness, of a city whose shared life is so unlike the surrounding darkness that it cannot help but shine. We have wanted to be seen for our power. He tells us to be seen for our works, so that the glory goes to God and not to us. Most of what the church now does to make itself visible would, by this standard, count as the salt losing its savor, and the only cure is to become again the kind of community whose visible goodness points past itself to the Father, which is the only kind of visibility the sermon blesses.

## CHAPTER TEN

# Not to Abolish, but to Fulfill

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**BEFORE JESUS GIVES A** single specific command, he stops to say what he is doing with the law, and the statement is so strong that we have spent two thousand years figuring out how to live up to it. Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets. I have not come to abolish them but to fulfill them.

This matters for the politics of the sermon because it tells us that what follows is not a softer, gentler, more relaxed standard than the old law. It is the old law brought to its full intended depth. There was a charge in the air, then as now, that Jesus was a religious revolutionary come to throw out the tradition, to relax the rules, to give people a more comfortable faith. He answers it directly and says the opposite. Not one stroke of a letter will pass from the law until all is accomplished. He has come not to lower the bar but to reveal how high it always was, to take commandments that people had learned to keep on the surface and to drive them down into the heart, where they were always aimed. The fulfillment

is not relaxation. It is intensification. And anyone who thought following Jesus would be easier than following Moses is about to be disabused over the next two chapters, where the standard goes not down but up, into territory no external law could ever reach.

Then comes a sentence that should unsettle every comfortable Christian. Unless your righteousness exceeds that of the scribes and Pharisees, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven. We have a cartoon of the Pharisees as obvious hypocrites, lazy religious frauds, and so we read this as a low bar, as if Jesus were saying be slightly better than those obvious phonies. But the Pharisees were the most rigorously observant people in the entire society. They tithed their spices. They kept rules most people did not even know existed. They were, by every external measure, the spiritual elite, the ones who took the law most seriously. And Jesus says your righteousness has to exceed theirs. He is not asking for more rule-keeping than the champion rule-keepers managed. He is asking for a different kind of righteousness altogether, one that goes deeper than behavior into the heart, one that cannot be achieved by the careful management of external conduct because it lives in the interior places no external law can govern. The Pharisees had perfected the outside. Jesus is after the inside, and the inside is where the real revolution has to happen.

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*The fulfillment is not relaxation. It is intensification. Jesus has come not to lower the bar but to reveal how high it*

*always was.*

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**THIS IS THE HINGE** on which the rest of chapter five turns, and it is also where the gospel hides inside the law. Because the moment you understand that the righteousness Jesus requires is a matter of the heart and not just the hands, you understand that no one can produce it by trying harder. You cannot will yourself into not being angry, not lusting, not loving your money, not hating your enemies, by sheer external effort, the way you might will yourself into keeping a rule about handwashing. The standard Jesus is about to set is so high, so interior, so far beyond the reach of behavior management, that it drives the honest person to despair of self-improvement and toward the only thing that can actually change a heart, which is grace, the transforming work of God from the inside out. The sermon is not a ladder of self-help. It is a portrait of the life the kingdom produces in people God is remaking, and the very impossibility of it, met head-on, is meant to send us not to greater effort but to the King who can do in us what we cannot do in ourselves. Keep that in mind as the demands mount, because they are about to become impossible, and the impossibility is part of the point.

## CHAPTER ELEVEN

# Anger, and the Murder That Starts Earlier

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**YOU HAVE HEARD THAT** it was said to those of old, you shall not murder. But I say to you that everyone who is angry with his brother will be liable to judgment. Here begins the pattern that will run through the rest of the chapter, the you-have-heard-but-I-say-to-you pattern, and the first one goes straight for something we are all sure we are innocent of, until Jesus redefines the crime.

Most of us have not committed murder, and we are quietly proud of it, and Jesus takes that quiet pride apart in a sentence. He traces the act of murder back to its root, and the root is anger, the contempt that reduces another human being to an obstacle or an enemy, the rage that, given enough power and opportunity, becomes violence. He is saying that the commandment against murder was never really about the rare final act. It was about the whole continuum of contempt that leads there, the seething, the insult, the word that treats a brother as worthless. You fool, he says, naming the casual verbal violence we commit constantly and excuse

completely. The law said do not murder, and we kept it on the surface while nursing in our hearts the exact contempt that murder is made of, and Jesus says that contempt itself is already liable to judgment, that the killing begins long before the body falls, in the heart that has written another person off.

This is intensely political once you stop reading it as private anger management, because contempt is the engine of every social evil. Genocides do not begin with killing. They begin with contempt, with the slow work of teaching a population to see another group as less than human, as vermin, as a problem, as the fool. By the time the violence comes, the real crime has already been committed in a million hearts and words, the crime of reducing human beings made in the image of God to something disposable. Jesus is naming that interior and verbal violence as the seedbed of murder and declaring it already guilty, and a community that took this seriously would be a community at war with contempt itself, with the dehumanizing speech and the writing-off of enemies that the surrounding culture treats as normal and even entertaining. We live in a moment that runs on contempt, that has made the reduction of opponents to fools and vermin into a sport, and the church, instead of resisting it, has too often become fluent in it, hating the right enemies with the right slogans, keeping the letter of the law against murder while marinating in the contempt that is its root.

*The killing begins long before the body  
falls, in the heart that has written  
another person off. The  
commandment was never about the  
rare final act. It was about the whole  
continuum of contempt.*

---

**AND THEN JESUS DOES** something that shows how seriously he means it. He interrupts worship. If you are offering your gift at the altar and there remember that your brother has something against you, leave your gift there, go, be reconciled, and then come and offer. Stop the worship. The act of devotion to God is to be suspended, left unfinished at the altar, until the broken relationship with the brother is addressed. There is no clearer statement anywhere that Jesus refuses to let us use vertical religion as an escape from horizontal responsibility, that he will not accept our worship while we are at war with each other, that reconciliation with the brother takes precedence even over the sacrifice to God. This is the death of all privatized piety that loves God in the abstract and despises the neighbor in the concrete. The kingdom Jesus describes is one in which you literally cannot worship rightly while holding contempt for your brother, in which the altar waits while you go and make peace, and a church that grasped this would treat its internal divisions and its cultivated hatreds not as side issues but as the very thing standing between it and God.

## CHAPTER TWELVE

# The Body Is Not a Battlefield Apart

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**YOU HAVE HEARD THAT** it was said, you shall not commit adultery. But I say to you that everyone who looks at a woman with lustful intent has already committed adultery with her in his heart. The second antithesis moves to the body and to desire, and again Jesus drives the commandment inward, from the act to the look, from the deed to the desire that fathers it.

We are tempted to treat this one as a purely private matter, a question of individual purity, and it is that, but it is not only that, and the political dimension is hidden in the word he uses. Lust, in the sense Jesus means, is not the same as desire or attraction, which are part of being human. Lust is the act of reducing another person to an object for your consumption, of looking at a human being made in the image of God and seeing not a person but a thing to be used. That is why he connects it to adultery, to the betrayal of covenant, because lust is the interior posture that treats persons as commodities, and that posture does not stay private. It builds

cultures. It builds industries. It builds an entire economy organized around the reduction of human beings, especially women, to objects for consumption, and every man who looks with lustful intent is participating in and reinforcing that economy in his heart before he ever acts. Jesus is naming the inner root of a vast public evil, the commodification of persons, and declaring it guilty at the level of the look.

Then comes the violent language, and it is meant to be violent. If your right eye causes you to sin, tear it out and throw it away. If your right hand causes you to sin, cut it off. He does not mean this literally, and the church has known that from the beginning, because a blind man can lust as easily as a sighted one, the problem being in the heart and not the eye. But he means the violence of it, the seriousness, the refusal to treat the matter as minor. Better to lose a part than for your whole self to be lost. He is saying that the reduction of persons to objects is so corrosive, so destructive to the soul and to the community, that it is worth radical, even self-mutilating measures to be free of it, that we should treat it the way we would treat a gangrenous limb, with decisive amputation rather than careful management. The hyperbole is the point. He wants us to feel that this is not a small thing to be politely managed but a deadly thing to be violently resisted, and a culture that has made the lustful consumption of objectified bodies into ordinary entertainment is a culture Jesus would tell to start cutting.

*Lust is the act of reducing a person  
made in the image of God to a thing to  
be used. Jesus names the inner root of a  
vast public evil and declares it guilty  
at the level of the look.*

---

**I WANT TO SAY** a word to the people this teaching has been used to wound, because it has been weaponized, turned into a club against women, made the occasion for blaming the objectified rather than the objectifier. Read the text. Jesus puts the entire weight of responsibility on the one who looks, on the man with the lustful intent, on the eye and the hand that offend. He does not tell the woman to disappear so that men can be holy. He tells the man to deal violently with his own heart, to take ownership of his own gaze, to amputate whatever in himself reduces another person to an object. The command is addressed to the predator, not the prey, and every version of this teaching that reverses that, that makes women responsible for men's lust, has inverted the very point Jesus is making. The kingdom does not protect men's purity by hiding women. It demands that men stop looking at women as things, that they take the radical interior measures required to see persons as persons, and it places the full burden of that work on the one doing the looking. That is a far harder and far more just teaching than the one we have often substituted for it.

## CHAPTER THIRTEEN

# Divorce and the Protection of the Vulnerable

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**IT WAS ALSO SAID**, whoever divorces his wife, let him give her a certificate of divorce. But I say to you that everyone who divorces his wife, except on the ground of sexual immorality, makes her commit adultery. This is the antithesis we are most likely to misread as harsh, as Jesus tightening the rules and trapping people in broken marriages, when in its own context it was the opposite, a fierce act of protection for the most vulnerable party in the transaction.

You have to understand what divorce was in that world. It was a male privilege, exercised by men, often casually, sometimes for trivial reasons, and it left the woman in a desperate position. A divorced woman in the first century had almost no means of support, no way to provide for herself, little prospect of remarriage in many cases, and a real likelihood of falling into poverty or worse. The certificate of divorce that the men cited as their permission was, in

practice, a license for a husband to discard a wife when she ceased to please him, and to do it with religious cover, with a piece of paper that made it legal. Some rabbis taught that a man could divorce his wife for spoiling a meal or for finding someone he preferred. The system was rigged in favor of male convenience and against female survival, and the men had learned to quote scripture in defense of it.

Jesus blows up the religious cover. He refuses to let the certificate function as a permission slip for the casual destruction of women's lives. By naming what the discarding husband actually does to the wife, by insisting that the marriage covenant is not a convenience to be dissolved at male whim but a binding union that the powerful party does not get to break lightly, he is throwing the weight of his authority onto the side of the vulnerable woman against the system that disposed of her. This is not Jesus the rule-tightener trapping the unhappy. This is Jesus the protector of the discarded, refusing to bless a practice that used religious permission to ruin the powerless. The point of the teaching is the protection of the person who would otherwise be thrown away, and to read it as primarily a tool for trapping people in misery is to read it exactly backward, to side with the certificate-wielding husbands against the women Jesus was defending.

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*This is not Jesus the rule-tightener  
trapping the unhappy. This is Jesus  
throwing the weight of his authority  
onto the side of the discarded woman*

*against the system that disposed of her.*

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**I AM AWARE THAT** this teaching touches real pain, that there are people reading this whose marriages have ended, sometimes in ways they did not choose and could not prevent, and I am not going to use Jesus's words to lay a new weight on people the gospel means to carry. The exception he names, and the wider witness of scripture about abandonment and abuse, make clear that he is not chaining victims to their abusers, not forbidding the escape of the genuinely endangered. What he is forbidding is the casual, self-serving discarding of a spouse by the powerful party, the treatment of covenant as convenience, the use of religious permission to do violence to the vulnerable. The political principle underneath it is the one that runs through the whole sermon, that the kingdom takes the side of the weak against the strong, that it will not let the powerful use even sacred texts as instruments for disposing of people, and that the covenants we make are meant to be shelters for the vulnerable and not licenses for the strong. Read that way, this hard saying is of a piece with everything else on the mountain, one more instance of a King who consistently defends the ones the world throws away.

## CHAPTER FOURTEEN

# A People Who Do Not Need to Swear

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**AGAIN YOU HAVE HEARD** that it was said to those of old, you shall not swear falsely, but shall perform to the Lord what you have sworn. But I say to you, do not take an oath at all. Let what you say be simply yes or no. Anything more than this comes from evil. This antithesis looks minor, a technical point about oath-taking, and it contains a quiet revolution about truth and the kind of community that does not need to prop it up.

Oaths exist because people lie. The whole apparatus of swearing, of invoking heaven or the temple or your own life as a guarantee, exists for one reason, that ordinary human speech cannot be trusted, and so we developed a special category of extra-trustworthy speech, the oath, the vow, the sworn testimony, marked off from regular talk as the place where you really have to mean it. And the existence of that special category is itself an admission that regular talk is assumed to be unreliable, that we expect people to shade and spin and deceive in their everyday words and only tell the

truth when forced to swear. People in Jesus's day had developed an elaborate system of oaths with fine gradations, some binding and some not, so that you could swear by one thing and be held to it and swear by another and wriggle free, turning the whole machinery of truth-telling into a game of technical loopholes. It was a system for appearing to guarantee truth while preserving the option to deceive.

Jesus abolishes the entire apparatus with a stroke, and he does it by raising the standard of ordinary speech so high that the apparatus becomes unnecessary. Do not swear at all. Let your yes be yes and your no be no. He is describing a community whose plain, everyday speech is so reliable that it needs no reinforcement, where a simple yes carries the full weight that others can only achieve by swearing on their mother's grave, where the special category of extra-true speech has collapsed because all speech is true. That is a staggering social vision. It is a community in which the very concept of the oath has become pointless, not because no one cares about truth but because everyone tells it, all the time, in their ordinary words, so that there is no longer any need to mark off a special zone of guaranteed honesty. The kingdom does not need oaths because the kingdom does not have liars.

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*Oaths exist because people lie. Jesus describes a community whose plain everyday speech is so reliable that the entire apparatus of swearing becomes pointless.*

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**THIS IS MORE POLITICAL** than it looks, because every social order runs on some level of trust, and the level of trust determines almost everything about how a society functions. Where trust is low, everything is expensive, slow, defended, contractual, litigious, because no one's word can be relied on and every interaction has to be guarded against deceit. Where trust is high, life is lighter, freer, less defended, because people can take each other at their word. Jesus is calling his people to be a community of radical trustworthiness, an island of high trust in a sea of low-trust deception, a people whose simple word is good, and that is a powerful and visible thing in a world drowning in spin and partial truth and confident lying. We live in a moment when public truth has nearly collapsed, when lying has become a normal political tool, when no one expects powerful people to mean what they say. Into that, the church is called to be a community where yes means yes, where the plain word can be trusted, where the whole exhausting apparatus of guarding against deception is unnecessary because the people simply do not lie. That witness, in our moment, would be almost as startling as the miracles.

## CHAPTER FIFTEEN

# Turn the Other Cheek Is Not Surrender

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**YOU HAVE HEARD THAT** it was said, an eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth. But I say to you, do not resist the one who is evil. But if anyone slaps you on the right cheek, turn to him the other also. Here we arrive at the teaching that has done more than any other to convince people the sermon cannot be meant literally, the teaching that sounds like a command to be a doormat, and it is nothing of the kind. It is a manual for a third way between violence and passivity, and to see it you have to read the details Jesus chose, because he chose them with precision.

First, the law he is quoting was itself a limit on violence, not a license for it. An eye for an eye sounds barbaric to us, but in its original setting it was a restraint, a rule that the punishment could not exceed the crime, that you could take an eye for an eye but not a life for an eye, that vengeance had to be proportional and could not escalate. It was justice putting a ceiling on retaliation. But over time people had turned a limit on vengeance into a permission for it, reading

the rule as a guarantee of their right to strike back. Jesus addresses that, the human instinct to return harm for harm, and he says do not resist the evil one, which is better translated do not resist by the same evil means, do not answer violence with violence, do not get on the escalator of retaliation that has no top floor.

Then watch the example, because it is specific and it is brilliant. If anyone slaps you on the right cheek. Stop there. To slap someone on the right cheek, if you are right-handed, which most people are, you have to use the back of your hand, a backhand blow, and in that culture a backhand was not how you fought an equal. It was how a superior insulted an inferior, how a master struck a slave, a Roman struck a Jew, a man struck a woman. It was a blow of contempt, meant to put someone in their place, not to start a fight between equals. So when Jesus says turn to him the other cheek, he is not saying invite more abuse. He is describing a specific act of dignified defiance. If you turn the other cheek, the left one, the aggressor cannot backhand it. He would have to hit you with his fist or his open palm, the way you strike an equal, and in doing so he would be forced to treat you as a peer rather than an inferior. Turning the other cheek calls the bluff of the humiliation. It says, you may strike me, but you may not degrade me, you will have to acknowledge me as your equal or stop. It is not submission. It is a refusal to accept the inferior status the blow was meant to impose, executed without returning the violence.

*Turning the other cheek is not an invitation to more abuse. It is a refusal to accept the inferior status the blow was meant to impose, executed without returning the violence.*

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**THE OTHER EXAMPLES WORK** the same way, and once you see the pattern you cannot unsee it. If anyone would sue you for your tunic, give him your cloak as well. In a culture where the outer cloak was a person's most basic possession, legally protected, the thing a poor man slept in and could not be permanently taken from him, Jesus tells the person being sued for everything to hand over the cloak too, which would leave him naked, and in that culture the shame of nakedness fell not on the naked person but on the one who caused it. Strip in the courtroom, and you expose the injustice of a system that would take the last garment off a poor man's back. And if anyone forces you to go one mile, go with him two. Roman soldiers could legally compel a subject to carry their gear for one mile, a hated symbol of occupation, but only one mile, with penalties for the soldier who forced more. Carry it two, and you put the soldier in an awkward and even illegal position, you seize the initiative, you transform a humiliation into a free act, you confuse the entire power dynamic by doing more than was demanded, cheerfully, on your own terms.

What unites all three is that they are neither violence nor passivity. They are a creative, defiant, nonviolent third way,

ways of resisting evil and exposing injustice without picking up the weapons of the oppressor, ways of asserting your dignity and the wrongness of the system while refusing to answer it in kind. This is not the ethic of a doormat. It is the ethic of a person who has so completely refused both the sword and the surrender that they have found a third thing, a way to confront evil that does not become evil in the process. And it is deeply political, because it is exactly the strategy that, eighteen and nineteen centuries later, people like Gandhi and Martin Luther King Junior would take from this very text and use to shake empires, the strategy of nonviolent resistance, of confronting injustice in a way that exposes it without imitating it. King read the Sermon on the Mount and saw not passivity but the most powerful form of resistance available to the powerless, and he was right, and the movement he led was a more faithful reading of these verses than most of what the church has done with them. Turn the other cheek is not the white flag of the defeated. It is the battle plan of a different kind of war.

## CHAPTER SIXTEEN

# Love Your Enemies

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**YOU HAVE HEARD THAT** it was said, you shall love your neighbor and hate your enemy. But I say to you, love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you. Here is the center of the sermon, the hardest command, the one that gathers up everything before it and pushes it to the breaking point, the command that the church has spent most of its history finding ways around, and I want to give it the weight it deserves, because if we get this one right the rest follows and if we get it wrong nothing else can save us.

Notice first that no one had ever said hate your enemy as a command of God. It was not in the law. But it was in the human heart, and it had become the practical assumption of religious life, the unstated corollary that everyone supplied. Love your neighbor, yes, the law said that, and people had quietly defined neighbor narrowly, as those like us, our own, our people, and supplied the obvious other half, that those outside the circle, the enemies, the others, were fair game for hatred. Jesus names that unspoken assumption and detonates it. Love your enemies. Not tolerate them, not avoid them, not refrain from harming them, but love them, will their good, pray for them, treat them with the active goodwill

you would show your own. He takes the word love, the strongest word he has, and aims it at the people we are most certain we are entitled to hate, and he leaves us no room at all to escape.

And then he gives the reason, and the reason is the most important thing in the entire sermon, because it grounds the whole ethic in the character of God. Love your enemies so that you may be sons of your Father in heaven, for he makes his sun rise on the evil and on the good and sends rain on the just and on the unjust. There it is. We are to love our enemies because that is what God does, because God's love is not earned and not deserved and not restricted to the people who love him back, because the sun and the rain, the basic gifts of life, fall on the people who curse God as freely as on the people who praise him. God is kind to his enemies. God sends good gifts to the people who hate him. And we are his children, called to bear the family likeness, to do what our Father does, and our Father loves his enemies, which means that we, if we are really his, must love ours. The command to love enemies is not an arbitrary hard rule. It is the necessary consequence of who God is, and to refuse it is to refuse to be like our Father, to forfeit the family resemblance, to show that we do not really belong to him at all.

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*God is kind to his enemies. He sends rain on the people who hate him. We are his children, called to bear the family likeness, and our Father loves his enemies.*

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**THEN JESUS PRESSES THE** knife in. If you love those who love you, what reward do you have? Do not even the tax collectors do the same? And if you greet only your brothers, what more are you doing than others? Do not even the Gentiles do the same? He is saying that loving the people who love you is nothing, is the most ordinary thing in the world, is what everyone already does, including the people you despise, the collaborator tax collectors and the pagan Gentiles. Reciprocal love, loving your own, is not a Christian distinctive. It is the universal human default. The mob loves its own. The gang loves its own. Every tribe and faction and nation loves its own and hates its enemies, and there is nothing whatsoever in that to distinguish the people of God from anyone else. The only love that marks you as a child of the Father, the only love the world cannot produce on its own, is love for the enemy, and a church that loves only its own has nothing the world does not already have, has become, in the deepest sense, just another tribe, and has lost the one thing that was supposed to make it unmistakable.

This is where I have to turn the knife on myself and on the church I love, because we have failed this command spectacularly and we have failed it recently and we are failing it now. We have learned to hate our enemies with great fluency and to baptize the hatred, to treat the people on the other side of our political and cultural divides as objects of contempt rather than objects of love, to pray against them rather than for them, to want their defeat and even their destruction, and to do all of it while claiming the name of the One who told us to love them. We have become as tribal as anyone, loving our own and hating the other, indistinguishable in our actual political behavior from the godless factions we claim to be different from. And every

time we do it we forfeit the family resemblance, we prove we are not really our Father's children, we make the gospel unbelievable to a watching world that can see perfectly well that we hate exactly the people everyone else hates. The command to love our enemies is the test the modern church is most obviously failing, and there is no version of faithfulness to the Sermon on the Mount that does not begin with repenting of that failure and learning, painfully, against every instinct, to love the people we have been treating as enemies. Until we do, nothing else we say about the sermon will be believed, and it should not be, because we will not be living the one line that proves we mean it.

The chapter ends with a sentence that has frightened people for two thousand years. You therefore must be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect. It sounds impossible, and it is, if perfect means flawless. But the word means complete, whole, mature, brought to the intended end, and in context it means specifically this, that your love must be complete, undivided, extended even to enemies, the way your Father's love is complete and extended to all. Be perfect as he is perfect means love without the exception we all want to carve out, love that does not stop at the boundary of your own tribe, love that reaches the enemy because God's love reaches the enemy. It is the summary of the whole second half of chapter five. The kingdom is a community of people learning to love the way God loves, without limit, without tribe, without the comfortable exception for the people we are sure deserve our hatred. That is the politics of the sermon in a single command, and it is the hardest thing in the world, and it is the only thing that would make the church visibly, undeniably the children of God.

## CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

# The War on Performance

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**BEWARE OF PRACTICING YOUR** righteousness before other people in order to be seen by them. With the start of chapter six Jesus turns from the content of kingdom righteousness to the danger that shadows it, the danger of doing the right things for the wrong reason, of turning even righteousness into a performance, and he goes after it with a relentlessness that should make every public Christian nervous, myself first.

He takes the three great pillars of Jewish piety, giving to the needy, prayer, and fasting, the three most admired religious practices in the culture, and he says the same thing about each of them. When you give, do not sound a trumpet before you, as the hypocrites do, that they may be praised by others. When you pray, do not be like the hypocrites who love to stand and pray where they will be seen. When you fast, do not look gloomy like the hypocrites who disfigure their faces that their fasting may be seen. Three times the same warning, three times the same word, hypocrites, which originally meant actors, stage players, people performing a part for an

audience. Jesus is naming a specific and deadly corruption, the transformation of devotion into theater, the doing of holy things not for God but for the watching crowd, and he is saying that when you do that, you have already received your reward, the only reward such performance can earn, which is the applause you were fishing for. You wanted to be seen. You were seen. That is all you get.

The antidote he gives is secrecy, and it is a strange and bracing prescription. Give in secret, so that your left hand does not know what your right hand is doing. Pray in secret, go into your room and shut the door. Fast in secret, wash your face so no one knows. Do the holy things where only God can see, and your Father who sees in secret will reward you. Jesus is prescribing hiddenness as the cure for performance, a deliberate concealment of our righteousness from the human audience whose applause corrupts it. This does not contradict the earlier command to let your light shine before others, because the difference is the motive and the audience. The good works are to be visible so that God gets the glory, but the moment your aim shifts from God's glory to your own reputation, the same act curdles into performance, and the cure is to practice it in secret until your heart no longer needs the crowd. Hidden righteousness is righteousness being purified of its hunger for applause.

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*Jesus prescribes secrecy as the cure for performance. Do the holy things where only God can see, until your heart no longer needs the crowd.*

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**I CANNOT PRETEND THIS** does not indict me and indict the entire age the church now lives in, because we have built a whole religious economy on exactly the performance Jesus condemns. We document our generosity and our devotion and our fasting and broadcast them to an audience, we turn our faith into content, we perform our righteousness before a watching feed in order to be seen by it, and we have constructed elaborate justifications for why this is fine, why it is encouragement, why it is influence. Jesus would call it the trumpet before the giving and the street corner before the prayer, the ancient performance with new technology, and he would say what he said then, that we have received our reward, the little hit of applause, and that the Father who sees in secret has nothing to add to a transaction that was never aimed at him. The political dimension of this is real, because a church addicted to performance cannot be salt and light, can only be spectacle, and spectacle points to itself while light points beyond itself to God. The war on performance is a war for the soul of the church's witness, and in our moment it is a war we are mostly losing, one broadcast act of righteousness at a time.

## CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

# A Prayer That Topples Thrones

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**IN THE MIDDLE OF** his teaching on prayer, Jesus gives his disciples the words to use, and we have said them so many times that we no longer hear them, but the Lord's Prayer is one of the most quietly revolutionary texts in the New Testament, a prayer that, if it were ever truly meant, would topple every throne it touched, including the ones in our own hearts.

Pray then like this. Our Father in heaven. It begins with a word that levels everything, our, not my, a prayer that cannot be prayed alone, that binds the one praying to a whole family of others who share the same Father, that makes private religion impossible from the first syllable. There is no my Father in heaven in the prayer Jesus taught. There is only our, and the our includes the poor and the stranger and the enemy you were told to love, all of them children of the same Father, all of them your siblings whether you like it or not. To pray our Father is already to renounce the tribalism the sermon has been attacking, to confess that the people you

wanted to exclude belong to your family, that you cannot approach God as an individual but only as a member of a people that is far wider than your preferences.

Then the petitions, and the order of them is the whole politics of the prayer. Hallowed be your name. Your kingdom come. Your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven. Before a single word about our own needs, three petitions about God, and the heart of them is a request for regime change, your kingdom come, a prayer for the arrival of God's government and therefore for the displacement of every other. You cannot pray your kingdom come without praying, in the same breath, that the kingdoms of this world would yield, that the powers that currently rule would give way to the reign of God, that the whole arrangement of things on earth would be brought into line with the way things are in heaven. This is not a private spiritual request. It is a prayer for the transformation of the entire political order of creation, a daily petition that God would come and rule where Caesar and Mammon and every other power now rule, and to mean it is to set yourself against the present arrangement of the world and to ask God to overturn it. The most familiar prayer in the world is a prayer for the end of the world as it is.

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*You cannot pray your kingdom come  
without praying that the kingdoms of  
this world would yield. The most  
familiar prayer in the world is a  
prayer for the end of the world as it is.*

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**AND THEN, FINALLY, OUR** needs, and even these are political. Give us this day our daily bread, a prayer for enough and not for more, for daily provision and not for accumulation, modeled on the manna in the wilderness that could not be hoarded, that rotted if you tried to store up more than a day's worth. It is a prayer that quietly rejects the entire logic of accumulation that drives the economy of the world, asking only for today's bread and trusting tomorrow to the Father. Forgive us our debts as we forgive our debtors, a petition that ties the forgiveness we receive to the forgiveness we extend, that makes our own pardon conditional on our willingness to pardon others, and the word is debts, which is at once spiritual and economic, evoking the cancellation of literal debts that the Jubilee commanded. And lead us not into temptation but deliver us from evil, a plea for protection in the struggle against the powers, an admission that we are in a battle we cannot win on our own. The whole prayer is a manifesto. It renounces tribalism, prays for regime change, asks only for enough, ties mercy to mercy, and begs deliverance from evil, and we have turned it into a soothing recitation. Pray it again, slowly, and feel it for what it is, the daily sedition of people who serve a different King.

## CHAPTER NINETEEN

# You Cannot Serve God and Money

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**DO NOT LAY UP** for yourselves treasures on earth, where moth and rust destroy and where thieves break in and steal, but lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven. Jesus turns now to money, and he is not gentle, and the church in the wealthy world has spent enormous energy making sure he does not mean what he plainly says, because what he plainly says would cost us everything we have arranged our lives around.

He sets up a simple, brutal contrast. Two kinds of treasure, earthly and heavenly, and the earthly kind is fundamentally insecure, vulnerable to moth and rust and theft, certain to be lost, while the heavenly kind is safe. And then the line that explains why this matters so much, for where your treasure is, there your heart will be also. This is a statement about the human soul, that our hearts follow our money, that whatever we invest in becomes what we love, that the direction of our treasure determines the direction of our affections. It is not that we should not love money so we will use it rightly. It is

that our love follows our spending, that we become attached to whatever we accumulate, so that the question of where we put our treasure is finally the question of what will own our hearts. Jesus is not moralizing about greed as one sin among many. He is describing a law of the spiritual universe, that you will love what you store up, and therefore that the accumulation of earthly treasure will inevitably capture the heart that does it.

Then he says the thing we most want him not to have said. No one can serve two masters, for either he will hate the one and love the other, or he will be devoted to the one and despise the other. You cannot serve God and money. Not should not, cannot. He personifies money, calls it Mammon, treats it as a rival deity with its own claims and its own worship and its own demands, and he says flatly that it is one or the other, that money is not a neutral tool you can use for God but a competing master that wants your soul, and that you must choose. This is a declaration of war on the central faith of every wealthy society, the faith that says money is simply a means, that you can have as much of it as you want and still serve God, that accumulation and devotion can coexist if your heart is right. Jesus says no. He says money is a master that competes with God for the throne of the heart, that serving both is not difficult but impossible, and that the choice between them is the most fundamental choice a person makes. There is no neutral relationship with Mammon. You serve God or you serve money, and the way to tell which one you actually serve is not what you say but where your treasure goes.

*Jesus does not say you should not serve money. He says you cannot serve God and money. They are rival masters, and the heart follows the treasure.*

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**THE POLITICAL WEIGHT OF** this is enormous, and the church in the rich world has mostly defused it by spiritualizing it into a warning against the love of money, as though the problem were only an inner attitude that the wealthy could avoid while keeping all the wealth. But Jesus is more concrete than that. He is naming an economic order built on accumulation as a rival religion, a system that demands our service and captures our hearts and competes directly with the kingdom of God, and he is calling his people out of its worship. A community that took this seriously would hold its possessions loosely, would refuse the endless accumulation that the surrounding economy treats as the whole point of life, would store its treasure in the kingdom by giving it away to the poor, and would be, in its actual financial behavior, visibly different from a culture organized around getting and keeping. We are not that community, mostly. We have made our peace with Mammon and kept a corner of our hearts for God and called it stewardship, and Jesus stands over the arrangement and says it cannot be done, that we are fooling ourselves, that the treasure has the heart and the heart cannot be divided. It is one of the places the sermon is most plainly disobeyed by the people who most loudly claim it, and the disobedience is so normal among us that we no longer even feel it as disobedience. That numbness is itself

YOU CANNOT SERVE GOD AND MONEY

the evidence of which master we serve.

## CHAPTER TWENTY

# The Economics of Trust

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**THEREFORE I TELL YOU**, do not be anxious about your life, what you will eat or what you will drink, nor about your body, what you will put on. Having told his people they cannot serve both God and money, Jesus knows the immediate objection, the anxious question that rises in every heart that has just been asked to loosen its grip on its security, and he answers it with the longest sustained passage in the sermon about the inner life, a passage about worry, and it is more political than it looks, because anxiety is the engine that drives the worship of Mammon.

Look at the birds of the air, he says, they neither sow nor reap nor gather into barns, and your heavenly Father feeds them. Consider the lilies of the field, how they grow, they neither toil nor spin, yet Solomon in all his glory was not arrayed like one of these. He points to the natural world, to creatures that do not accumulate and are sustained anyway, and he draws the conclusion that if God so clothes the grass of the field, he will much more clothe his children. The argument is from the lesser to the greater. If God cares for the birds and the flowers, transient things, how much more will he care for you. And therefore, he says, do not be anxious, do

not let the fear of not having enough drive your life, do not organize your existence around the frantic management of a future only God controls. The anxiety that the wealthy world runs on, the gnawing fear of scarcity that drives the endless accumulation, the worry that there will not be enough, is precisely what Jesus is dismantling, because that anxiety is the fuel of Mammon's fire, the thing that makes us serve money instead of God.

Then he reframes the whole question. The Gentiles, he says, the nations that do not know God, seek after all these things, food and drink and clothing, the basic securities, and they organize their whole lives around the pursuit of them. But you, he says, are different, your heavenly Father knows that you need them all, and so you are freed from the anxious seeking that consumes everyone else. But seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all these things will be added to you. There is the reversal, the political heart of the passage. The world seeks first its security, food and clothing and the future, and lets the kingdom come later if at all. Jesus tells his people to invert the order, to seek first the kingdom and its justice, to make the reign of God and the setting right of the world their first pursuit, and to trust that the basic needs will be met by a Father who knows them. This is an economic teaching as much as a spiritual one. It frees a community from the anxiety that drives accumulation, and a community freed from that anxiety can do astonishing things, can give recklessly, can take risks for justice, can hold its possessions loosely, can refuse the scramble for security that enslaves everyone else, because it has placed its security in the Father and not in the barn.

*Anxiety is the fuel of Mammon's fire.  
The world seeks its security first. Jesus  
tells his people to seek the kingdom first  
and trust the Father for the rest.*

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**DO NOT BE ANXIOUS** about tomorrow, he concludes, for tomorrow will be anxious for itself, sufficient for the day is its own trouble. He is not promising an easy life, not saying there will be no trouble, in fact he assumes the trouble, sufficient for the day is its own trouble. He is saying only that the anxiety which tries to secure tomorrow by hoarding today is both faithless and futile, that the future belongs to God and cannot be bought with our worry, and that the people of the kingdom are called to a daily trust that frees them from the fear that rules the world. I find this the hardest teaching in the sermon to actually live, harder even than loving my enemies, because the anxiety runs so deep, because the fear of not having enough is wired into me by a culture that has taught me to measure my safety in dollars. But I have seen, in glimpses, what it looks like when a person or a community is genuinely freed from it, and it is one of the most powerful witnesses there is, a life that does not run on fear, that gives without calculating, that holds the future open-handed, and the watching world cannot account for it, because the world knows of no security but the barn, and here is a person whose security is somewhere the moth and rust cannot reach.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

# Judging, the Log and the Speck

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**JUDGE NOT, THAT YOU** be not judged. For with the judgment you pronounce you will be judged, and with the measure you use it will be measured to you. With these words Jesus opens the final chapter of the sermon, and we have managed to make this one verse do work it was never meant to do, twisting it into the single most quoted and least understood sentence in the whole address, a slogan for a culture that wants no one to tell it anything. So before we can hear what Jesus actually says, we have to clear away what we have made him say.

The world loves this verse, or rather it loves the first three words of it, and it loves them precisely because it has emptied them of meaning. Judge not has become the great commandment of a culture that wishes to be left alone, the verse people who have never opened a Bible can quote, the all-purpose shield against any moral claim anyone might make on them. You cannot tell me anything, the culture says, Jesus himself said judge not. But Jesus is not forbidding

moral discernment, and we know this because the very same sermon is one long act of moral discernment, a relentless naming of right and wrong, and a few verses later he will tell us to watch out for false prophets and to know them by their fruits, which requires the most careful judgment imaginable. He is not abolishing the human capacity to tell good from evil. He is going after something more specific and more deadly, the particular sin of the person who sets himself up as the judge of others while exempting himself, the self-righteous condemnation that looks down on the neighbor from a height it has not earned.

Read the whole passage and the target comes clear. Why do you see the speck that is in your brother's eye, but do not notice the log that is in your own eye. There is the picture, and it is a comic one, deliberately absurd, a man with a plank protruding from his own eye socket squinting at a speck of sawdust in someone else's, offering to perform delicate surgery while blinded by his own enormous beam. Jesus is mocking us. He is painting the self-appointed critic as a ridiculous figure, so consumed with the small faults of others that he cannot see the great fault that is his own, so eager to correct his brother that he has never turned the same scrutiny on himself. The sin Jesus condemns is not discernment. It is the hypocrisy of a discernment that runs only outward, that examines everyone but the self, that is endlessly perceptive about the failings of others and entirely blind about its own.

This is intensely political, and the politics of it begin, as the sermon always insists, with us. Because the self-righteous judgment Jesus condemns is the very air our public life now breathes. We have built an entire culture on the speck in the other's eye, a whole economy of outrage and accusation and

condemnation, in which the highest pleasure available is the pleasure of denouncing someone else, of finding the fault, of pronouncing the verdict, of standing on the height and looking down. Our politics runs on it. Our media runs on it. Our endless scrolling runs on it, the dopamine of the daily villain, the satisfaction of being right about how wrong they are. And the church, which should have been the one community on earth immune to this disease, having been told plainly by its Lord to deal with its own log first, has instead become as fluent in condemnation as anyone, perhaps more so, because we have learned to back our judgments with the authority of God. We have made denunciation a ministry. We have turned the speck-hunt into a calling.

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*We have built an entire culture on the  
speck in the other's eye, and the church,  
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**BUT NOTICE WHAT JESUS** does not say, because it matters. He does not say leave the speck alone. He does not say faults do not matter, or that we should never help a brother see what is wrong. The passage ends with the surgery actually happening. First take the log out of your own eye, and then you will see clearly to take the speck out of your brother's eye. The goal is still to remove the speck. The brother's fault is

real and worth addressing, and there is a kind of love that does help another person see what is harming them. What Jesus forbids is the order, the sequence, the spiritual posture. You do not get to operate on others until you have submitted to the operation yourself. You do not get to name your brother's sin until you have wept over your own. The qualification for helping another person with their fault is a thorough, painful, ongoing honesty about your own, the kind that takes the log seriously, that knows the worst about itself, that approaches the brother not from above as a judge but from beside as a fellow patient who has been through the same surgery and bears the same scars.

This is the difference between condemnation and correction, and the church has confused them for so long that we can barely tell them apart. Condemnation looks down. Correction comes alongside. Condemnation is about the satisfaction of the one who judges. Correction is about the healing of the one who is judged. Condemnation needs the other person to stay wrong so that the judge can keep feeling right. Correction wants the other person to be made whole, even at the cost of the helper's own exposure, because you cannot pull a speck from someone's eye without getting close enough that they can see the marks on your face. The whole posture is different. And a community that learned this, that became a people who dealt savagely with their own logs and gently with their brothers' specks, who refused the pleasures of denunciation and took up the costly work of restoration, would be a startling thing in a world that has organized its entire common life around the opposite. We are quick to judge and slow to repent, and Jesus tells us to reverse it, to become slow to judge and quick to repent, and that reversal alone, if we ever made it, would mark us as citizens of a

different kingdom more clearly than almost anything else we could do.

I have to make the confession here, because this is the chapter where the writer must climb down from the height he has been tempted to occupy. I have spent a great deal of this book naming the failures of the church, and there is a way of doing that which is itself the very sin Jesus condemns, a way of denouncing the speck-hunters that is just one more speck-hunt, a log-blind critique of everyone else's log-blindness. I know that temptation because I have given in to it. It is possible to write a whole book about the church's hypocrisy in a spirit of perfect hypocrisy, pointing at everyone from a position of assumed innocence, and if I have done that anywhere in these pages I have failed the very sermon I am trying to honor. So let me say it plainly. The log is mine. The contempt I described, I have felt. The performance I condemned, I have performed. The self-righteous judgment Jesus names here is not the disease of other Christians I can see from a safe distance. It is my disease, diagnosed in my own chest, and the only honest way to read this chapter is on my knees, asking to have my own eye cleared before I presume to touch anyone else's. That is where the sermon always lands the writer. Inside the indictment. Holding the log.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

# Dogs, Pearls, and Holy Discernment

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**DO NOT GIVE DOGS** what is holy, and do not throw your pearls before pigs, lest they trample them underfoot and turn to attack you. Right after telling us not to judge, Jesus says something that sounds, at first hearing, like the opposite, a saying so sharp and so strange that many readers simply skip it, unsure what to do with a sentence that seems to call certain people dogs and pigs. But the placement is deliberate, and the tension is the teaching, because the two sayings are not opposites at all. They are the two halves of a single wisdom, and a community that holds only one of them will go wrong.

Start with the shock of the words, because we are not meant to soften them. Dogs and pigs were both unclean animals in that world, and to call a person a dog or a pig was a serious insult. We recoil, and we are right to recoil, but we have to hold the recoil together with the fact that Jesus said it, and ask what he is doing. He is not, I think, naming a class of people to be despised, which would contradict everything he

has just taught about love of enemies and the log in our own eye. He is using a vivid and uncomfortable image to name a reality that the previous verses, taken alone, might cause us to forget, which is that not everyone is in a posture to receive what is holy, that there are people and moments where the most sacred thing you could offer would be torn apart and turned against you, and that love is not the same as indiscriminate disclosure. There is such a thing as wisdom about what to entrust to whom.

This matters because the command not to judge, left by itself, can curdle into a foolishness that the world will happily exploit. If judge not means we must never discern anything about anyone, never recognize that a particular person in a particular moment is not safe, never notice that what we are about to offer will be trampled and that we ourselves will be attacked for offering it, then we have turned the gospel into a kind of suicidal naivety, a refusal to see what is plainly there. Jesus is not asking for that. He spent his own ministry exercising exactly this discernment. He did not entrust himself to the crowds because he knew what was in them. He fell silent before Herod. He told some people to go and tell everyone and told others to say nothing. He gave different things to different people because he saw clearly what each could receive, and that seeing was not a violation of love but an expression of it. The holy is precious, and to fling it carelessly at those who will only desecrate it is not generosity. It is a failure to honor the gift.

So how do we hold these two sayings together, the one that forbids judgment and the one that demands discernment, and the answer is the answer the whole sermon keeps giving, which is that the difference lies in the heart and its direction. The judgment Jesus forbids is the self-righteous

condemnation that looks down on others to elevate the self, that hunts the speck for the pleasure of the hunt. The discernment Jesus commands is the clear-eyed wisdom that loves people enough to see them truly, that recognizes danger without contempt, that protects what is holy without despising those who are not yet ready for it. The first is about feeling superior. The second is about being faithful. The first writes people off. The second keeps loving them while being honest about where they are. You can refuse to condemn a person and still be wise about what you place in their hands, and in fact the refusal to condemn is what keeps the discernment from becoming contempt, while the discernment is what keeps the refusal to condemn from becoming foolishness.

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*Love is not the same as indiscriminate disclosure. You can refuse to condemn a person and still be wise about what you place in their hands.*

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**THE POLITICAL REACH OF** this is real, though quieter than in some other chapters. A community of the kingdom is called to a strange combination of openness and discernment that the world finds almost impossible to achieve, because the world tends to collapse into one error or the other. It is either the harsh community that judges and excludes, that decides who is a dog and treats them accordingly, that uses discernment as a weapon to keep people out, or it is the naive community that has no discernment at all, that pretends

every situation is safe and every person is ready, that flings the pearl and is then shocked when it is trampled. The kingdom community refuses both. It does not condemn, and it is not naive. It holds the door open as wide as the love of God, which is very wide, and it remains clear-eyed about reality, which is sometimes very hard. It can love a dangerous person without pretending the danger is not there. It can keep its heart soft toward someone it must, for now, protect itself from. That combination, soft heart and clear eye, is one of the rarest things in the world, and it is exactly what this pair of sayings, held together, is meant to produce.

I want to be careful, because this verse has been abused, twisted into a license for exactly the contempt the previous chapter condemned, used by people to justify dismissing whole categories of human beings as dogs and pigs not worth their gospel. That is a desecration of the text. Jesus, who ate with the people his society called dogs, who touched the unclean and welcomed the outcast and gave his most precious truths to a Samaritan woman at a well that everyone else would have walked past, is not handing the self-righteous a way to write off the people they already wanted to write off. The wisdom he commands is hard precisely because it must be exercised by people who have first taken the log out of their own eye, who have surrendered every right to feel superior, and who only then, from a place of genuine humility and genuine love, make the painful and prayerful judgment about what can be entrusted to whom. In the hands of the proud this verse is poison. In the hands of the humble it is wisdom. And the whole burden of the sermon is to make us the kind of people in whose hands it could be safely held.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

# Ask, Seek, Knock

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**ASK, AND IT WILL** be given to you. Seek, and you will find. Knock, and it will be opened to you. After the hard sayings about logs and specks and dogs and pearls, Jesus turns to prayer, and the turn is not a change of subject. It is the disclosure of the engine. Everything the sermon has demanded is impossible by human effort, and Jesus knows it, and here he points to the only power that can produce the life he has been describing, which is the Father who gives good gifts to those who ask.

Notice the structure, because it builds. Ask, seek, knock, three verbs of increasing intensity, and three promises to match, it will be given, you will find, it will be opened. Then Jesus repeats it, hammering it home, for everyone who asks receives, and the one who seeks finds, and to the one who knocks it will be opened. He is doing something deliberate with this repetition. He is trying to break down a particular kind of unbelief, the quiet conviction that lives in most of us that God is reluctant, that he must be persuaded, that the gifts of heaven have to be pried out of a tight-fisted deity who would rather not give. The whole passage is an assault on that picture of God. The doors of heaven are not locked against the

people who knock. They open. The treasures of heaven are not hidden from the people who seek. They are found. Prayer is not the wearing down of a divine resistance. It is the asking of a Father who has been waiting to give.

And then comes the argument that grounds it all, the argument from fatherhood, and I have to slow down here because of where I am writing from. Which one of you, if his son asks him for bread, will give him a stone, or if he asks for a fish, will give him a serpent. The logic is from the lesser to the greater, the same move Jesus made with the birds and the lilies. Even ordinary human fathers, with all their faults, do not answer their children's hunger with cruelty, do not hand a hungry boy a rock when he asks for bread. And then the line that opens the whole thing up. If you then, who are evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your Father who is in heaven give good things to those who ask him. How much more. That is the heart of it. Whatever you know of a decent father's care, multiply it past the limits of your imagination, and you begin to approach the disposition of God toward the people who ask him.

I came to faith without a father, and I am raising five sons, and so this passage is not an abstraction to me, it is the ground I have had to learn to stand on. I did not have the picture Jesus assumes. When he says which one of you, if his son asks for bread, will give him a stone, he is appealing to an experience of fatherly goodness that many of us did not receive, and for those of us who grew up without it, this verse can land like an accusation or a wound rather than a comfort, because we have no warm memory to multiply. But I have come to think the verse is for us most of all. Because Jesus is not saying God is like your father. He is saying God is the Father your father was always supposed to be and may have

failed to be, the original of which every human father is a broken copy, the one whose goodness is not multiplied from our experience but is the source our fathers were meant to draw from and so often did not. For the fatherless, this is not a reminder of what we had. It is the offer of what we never had, held out at last by the only One who can actually give it.

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*Prayer is not the wearing down of a  
divine resistance. It is the asking of a  
Father who has been waiting to give.*

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**BUT I HAVE TO** keep the politics of the sermon in view, because even prayer, in this address, is not a private retreat from the public demands of the kingdom. Look at what surrounds this passage. Before it, the call to a righteousness that exceeds anything human effort can produce. After it, the Golden Rule and the two ways and the warning about false prophets and the call to do the will of the Father. Prayer sits in the middle of all of that, not as an escape from it but as the power for it. The life the sermon describes, the loving of enemies and the refusal of Mammon and the hunger for justice and the making of peace, cannot be lived by gritted teeth. It can only be lived by people who ask, who seek, who knock, who draw continually on a power outside themselves because they have given up the illusion that they have what it takes. Prayer is how the impossible ethic of the kingdom becomes possible. It is the daily admission that we cannot do this, joined to the daily reception of the One who can do it in us. A community that prayed like this, that actually believed

the Father gives good gifts and asked him for the strength to love its enemies and open its hands, would be a community capable of things no amount of moral effort could ever achieve.

And here is why this matters for everything else. The reason the church has so spectacularly failed the sermon is not, finally, that the sermon is too hard, though it is hard. It is that we have tried to live it, or pretended to live it, in our own strength, by willpower and program and resolution, and willpower cannot love an enemy, cannot loosen the grip of fear, cannot pull the log from its own eye. Those things come only as gifts, asked for and received. The whole sermon hangs on this passage, because without the Father who gives, the sermon is a beautiful impossibility, a portrait of a life no one can live, a standard that only crushes. With the Father who gives, it becomes a description of what grace produces in people who keep asking. Ask, and it will be given. The entire kingdom turns on whether we believe that, and whether, believing it, we actually ask. Most of us, if we are honest, have stopped asking, having concluded somewhere along the way that the door is locked. Jesus says knock. The door opens. He has staked his whole sermon on it.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

# The Golden Rule

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**SO WHATEVER YOU WISH** that others would do to you, do also to them, for this is the Law and the Prophets. We call it the Golden Rule, and like the Lord's Prayer it has been worn so smooth by repetition that we no longer feel its edges, but stop and look at where Jesus places it and what he claims for it, because the placement and the claim together tell you he means it to carry enormous weight. This single sentence, he says, is the Law and the Prophets. The whole of Israel's scripture, the entire moral revelation given through Moses and the prophets, gathered up and summarized in one rule of action. That is a staggering thing to say about any sentence, and Jesus says it about this one.

First we should notice that Jesus did not invent the form of the rule, and that he knew it, and that the difference matters. There were versions of this principle circulating in the ancient world, and the most famous was negative. The great rabbi Hillel, a generation before Jesus, when challenged to summarize the law while standing on one foot, said what is hateful to you, do not do to your neighbor, that is the whole law and the rest is commentary. It is a fine principle, and it has a long and honorable history in many cultures, but notice

that it is a rule of restraint. Do not do harm. Leave people alone. Refrain from the cruelty you would not want done to yourself. Jesus takes the same principle and turns it from negative to positive, from restraint to initiative, and that turn changes everything. He does not say refrain from doing to others what you would not want. He says do to others what you would want. The negative version is satisfied by leaving your neighbor alone. The positive version is never satisfied, because there is no end to the good you might do, no point at which you have done enough, no way to fulfill it by simply minding your own business.

This is the difference between a rule that permits you to ignore your neighbor and a rule that compels you to engage him. Under the negative version, you can be a perfectly moral person while passing by on the other side, while never lifting a finger to help, while keeping your hands clean by keeping them in your pockets, because you have done no harm. Under the positive version, the man who passes by on the other side has already broken the rule, because you would not want others to pass you by in your need, and so you may not pass them by in theirs. The Golden Rule, as Jesus frames it, abolishes the morality of non-interference, the clean-handed innocence of the person who simply does no harm, and replaces it with a morality of active, imaginative, costly love that is forever asking what the other person needs and forever required to provide it. It is not a low bar. It is a bar with no top.

And here is the imaginative move at its center, the thing that makes it work, which is that it requires you to put yourself in the place of the other. Whatever you wish that others would do to you. You have to imagine yourself into the situation of the neighbor, the stranger, the enemy, to ask what

you would want if you were standing where they are standing, in their poverty, in their fear, in their need, and then to do that. It is an act of moral imagination, a deliberate crossing of the gap between self and other, a refusal to remain locked inside your own perspective. And that crossing is exactly what every form of injustice depends on us not doing. The powerful are able to oppress the weak precisely because they do not imagine themselves into the place of the weak. The comfortable are able to ignore the suffering precisely because they do not picture themselves suffering. Cruelty runs on the failure of imagination, on the inability or the refusal to feel what it would be like to be the other person, and the Golden Rule attacks cruelty at exactly that root, by commanding the imaginative leap that makes cruelty impossible.

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*Cruelty runs on the failure to imagine  
ourselves into the place of the other,  
and the Golden Rule commands  
exactly that leap, the one thing every  
injustice depends on us refusing to  
make.*

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**THE POLITICAL REACH OF** this is immense, and it is why I will not let it stay a private maxim about being nice to the people in front of you. Apply the imaginative leap to the structures we live inside, and the rule becomes a furnace. Whatever you wish that others would do to you. Do I wish to be paid a wage I cannot live on. Then I may not build a

business on the labor of those I pay that way. Do I wish to be locked out, turned away, treated as a problem, stepped over. Then I may not support the arrangements that do those things to others. The Golden Rule, taken to its full reach, will not let me hide behind the abstraction of systems and policies and the way things are, because behind every system are people, and the rule demands that I imagine myself into their place and ask whether I would accept for myself what I am willing to accept for them. The honest application of this one sentence would overturn most of how we have arranged our common life, because we have arranged it, very largely, so as not to have to imagine ourselves into the place of the people it costs. The Golden Rule forbids that comfortable failure of imagination, and a community that practiced it would be a standing rebuke to every order built on the refusal to feel what the other person feels.

I notice that Jesus calls this the summary of the Law and the Prophets, and that he has used almost the same words before, when he said he came not to abolish the Law and the Prophets but to fulfill them. The frame closes here. What began in chapter five as the promise to fulfill the law arrives, in chapter seven, at the summary of it, and the summary is not a doctrine to believe or a feeling to have but a thing to do, do to others, a rule of action aimed straight at how we treat the people around us. The whole law, the entire moral weight of the scriptures, comes down at last to this, to whether I will do for my neighbor what I would want done for me. It is so simple a child can understand it and so demanding that no one has ever fully obeyed it. And it is the kind of summary only Jesus would give, because it refuses to let religion become a matter of correct belief or proper ritual or right feeling, and insists, with the prophets behind him, that the

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whole thing was always about love made concrete, about the good actually done to the actual neighbor, about a life turned outward toward the need of the other. That is the Law and the Prophets. Everything else is commentary, and the commentary has often been a way of avoiding the rule.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

# The Two Gates and the Hard Road

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**ENTER BY THE NARROW** gate. For the gate is wide and the way is easy that leads to destruction, and those who enter by it are many. For the gate is narrow and the way is hard that leads to life, and those who find it are few. With these words Jesus begins the conclusion of the sermon, the series of stark either-or choices that bring the whole address to its point, and the first of them is an image of two roads, and it is an image our age finds almost unbearable, because it insists on the one thing we have decided to deny, which is that the choices we make actually matter, that they lead somewhere, that not all roads arrive at the same place.

We do not like the narrow gate. Everything in the spirit of the time resists it. We have been taught that all paths are equally valid, that sincerity is what counts and the destination takes care of itself, that to suggest one way is right and another wrong is the height of arrogance. And into that mood Jesus says there are two gates, a wide one and a narrow one, two roads, an easy one and a hard one, and they do not

lead to the same place. One leads to life and one leads to destruction, and the difference between them is not trivial and not a matter of taste. He is not being cruel. He is being honest about something the whole sermon has assumed from the start, that the life he describes is a genuine alternative to the life everyone else is living, that you cannot have both, that to take up the kingdom is to leave something behind, and that the leaving is real and costly and not everyone will do it. The two ways are not a threat. They are the truth about a fork in the road, told by someone who loves us too much to pretend the road does not fork.

Look at what marks each way, because Jesus is precise. The wide gate and the easy road are traveled by many. The narrow gate and the hard road are found by few. He attaches the crowd to the wide road and the small number to the narrow one, and this is a warning aimed directly at one of our deepest instincts, the instinct to trust the crowd, to assume that the direction everyone is going must be the right direction, that safety lies in numbers, that if most people are doing a thing it cannot be too far wrong. The sermon has been undermining that instinct from the beginning, blessing the people the crowd despises, commanding the love the crowd finds foolish, and here it makes the warning explicit. The majority is on the wide road. The fact that a way is crowded, that everyone is taking it, that it feels normal and easy and unremarkable, is not evidence that it leads to life. It may be evidence of the opposite. The road to destruction is not marked with warnings. It is marked with company, with the reassuring presence of the multitude, all of them going the same comfortable direction together.

This cuts against the whole project of a popular, crowd-pleasing, easy religion, and that project is exactly what much

of the church has become. We have worked very hard to widen the gate, to smooth the road, to make the faith as undemanding and as crowded as possible, to remove every hard saying and every steep cost, because we measured success by numbers and a narrow gate does not draw a crowd. We built a Christianity engineered for the wide road, a faith that asks little and promises much, that fits comfortably inside the life everyone was already living, that requires no enemies loved and no Mammon renounced and no cheek turned, and we filled our buildings with it and called it a movement of God. Jesus stands at the narrow gate and watches us herd people through the wide one in his name. The easy religion we have built, the one designed to offend no one and cost nothing and accommodate the crowd, is precisely the wide road he warned us about, and we have been recruiting for it with his words.

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*The road to destruction is not marked  
with warnings. It is marked with  
company, with the reassuring presence  
of the multitude all going the same  
comfortable direction together.*

---

**BUT I HAVE TO** be careful with the word narrow, because we have abused it too, in the opposite direction. There is a kind of person who hears narrow gate and is delighted, who loves the idea that few will find it, who wears the narrowness as a badge of superiority, who is glad the road is hard because it

keeps out the riffraff, who has turned the few into an elite club of the truly righteous of which he is naturally a member. That is not what Jesus means, and that spirit is its own wide road, the broad and crowded highway of religious pride that has destroyed as many as any other. The narrowness Jesus describes is not the narrowness of exclusion but the narrowness of cost. The gate is narrow because you cannot carry your baggage through it, cannot bring your hatred and your Mammon and your self-righteousness and your need to dominate, must leave all of it at the entrance and go through stripped. It is narrow the way the eye of a needle is narrow to a camel, narrow to everything we are carrying, and the few who find it are not the proud few who kept others out but the humbled few who were willing to put down what the gate would not admit. The narrow gate is not for the elite. It is for the empty-handed, and it is found by few not because God restricts it but because few are willing to drop what they would have to drop to fit through.

I think the deepest thing in this image is the word hard, the way that leads to life is hard, because it refuses the lie at the center of so much of what we have sold. We have promised people that following Jesus would make their lives easier, would solve their problems, would deliver the comfort and security and success the wide road also promises, only with God's blessing on it. Jesus promises the opposite. He promises a hard road. He says the way to life is difficult, costly, steep, traveled by few, and he says it not to discourage us but to prepare us, so that when the road turns out to be hard we will not conclude that we have made a wrong turn. The hardness is not a sign that you have left the path. The hardness is the path. The whole sermon has been describing a life that runs against every current, that loves what is hard

to love and renounces what is hard to renounce and tells the truth when lying would be easier and makes peace when war would be sweeter, and a life like that is hard by its very nature. Jesus tells us this plainly, at the end, so that we choose with our eyes open, knowing that we are choosing the harder of two roads, and choosing it anyway, because it is the one that leads to life.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

# Wolves in Sheep's Clothing

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**BEWARE OF FALSE PROPHETS**, who come to you in sheep's clothing but inwardly are ravenous wolves. You will recognize them by their fruits. Right after the two roads, Jesus issues a warning about the people who will try to send us down the wrong one while wearing the clothing of the right one, and it is a warning the church has desperately needed in every generation and has heeded in almost none, because the false prophet is, by definition, the one we do not see coming.

Notice the disguise, because the disguise is the whole danger. The wolf comes in sheep's clothing. He does not announce himself as a wolf. He does not arrive looking like a threat, snarling, obviously hostile, easy to identify and resist. He arrives looking exactly like one of the flock, sounding like a shepherd, speaking the language of the sheep, indistinguishable on the surface from the genuine article. That is what makes him a false prophet rather than an open enemy. The open enemy we can see and guard against. The false prophet has gotten inside, has put on the wool, has

learned the words, and the destruction he does is the worse for being done from within, by someone the sheep trusted, someone who looked and sounded right. Jesus is warning us that the gravest danger to the people of God has never been the obvious opponent outside the gate. It has been the convincing counterfeit inside it, the teacher who uses all the right language to lead the flock to the wrong place.

And then the test, the one test Jesus gives, and it is worth everything because it cuts through the disguise. You will recognize them by their fruits. Not by their words, because the false prophet has mastered the words. Not by their appearance, because the disguise is perfect. Not by their popularity or their eloquence or their confidence or the size of their following, because all of those can be counterfeited and frequently are. By their fruits. By what their lives and their teaching actually produce over time, the harvest of their ministry, the kind of people they make and the kind of community they build and the direction in which they actually lead. Are grapes gathered from thornbushes, Jesus asks, or figs from thistles. A healthy tree bears good fruit, and a diseased tree bears bad fruit, and you cannot finally hide the disease, because eventually the tree produces what it is, and the fruit tells the truth that the leaves concealed. The test is patient and it is empirical. Watch the fruit. Give it time. See what actually grows.

This is a profoundly practical and a profoundly political instruction, because it tells us how to evaluate the teachers and leaders who claim authority over us, and it tells us to do it by a standard that cannot be faked over the long run. We are forever being asked to follow people on the basis of the wrong things, on the basis of how compelling they are, how large their platform, how confidently they speak, how well they tell

us what we want to hear, and Jesus says none of that is the test. The test is the fruit. What does this teaching actually produce in the people who receive it. Does it produce the life of the Beatitudes, the mercy and the peacemaking and the hunger for justice and the love of enemies, or does it produce their opposite, the contempt and the tribalism and the grasping and the fear. Does the tree bear figs or thistles. A teacher who is leading people into hatred is a false prophet no matter how orthodox his words, because the fruit is bad. A movement that is making people more arrogant, more frightened, more contemptuous of their neighbors, more in love with power, is a diseased tree no matter what it claims about itself, because you know the tree by what it grows.

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*The gravest danger to the people of God  
has never been the obvious enemy  
outside the gate but the convincing  
counterfeit inside it, and the only test  
that cannot be faked is the fruit.*

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**I HAVE TO APPLY** this where it will cost something, which means applying it to the teachers our own side trusts, not just the ones we already distrust. It is easy to use the fruit test as a weapon against the false prophets of the other camp, the ones we were already suspicious of, and to exempt our own favorites from any scrutiny at all. That is not what Jesus is asking. The fruit test is meant to be turned on everyone we follow, especially the ones we are most inclined to trust, the

ones whose words we love, the ones who tell us what we already believe. Look at the fruit they are producing in you and in the people around you. Is it making you more like the person the Beatitudes describe, or less. Is the harvest of this teacher's influence on your life a deeper love of your enemies or a more refined hatred of them, a looser grip on your money or a more anxious one, a humbler heart or a prouder one. The fruit does not lie, and it does not care which side the tree is on. A teacher who is making his followers into ravenous wolves is a wolf, whatever clothing he wears and whatever team he plays for, and the willingness to apply that test to our own leaders, to the prophets we like, is one of the hardest forms of faithfulness there is.

And then, because the sermon never lets the writer stand outside the indictment, I have to turn the fruit test on myself, on every person who presumes to teach, on this very book. Because if I am a teacher in the church, and I am, then Jesus has just handed my readers the standard by which to judge me, and the standard is not whether my sentences are well made or my arguments persuasive but what my teaching actually produces in the people who receive it. If this book makes its readers more contemptuous, more self-righteous, more certain of their superiority over the failing church I keep describing, then it is bad fruit, and I am, in that measure, a false prophet, however true the things I have said. The fruit test does not exempt the one who teaches it. It binds him most of all. So I have to ask, of every page, whether it grows figs or thistles, whether it sends the reader toward the narrow gate of love or down the wide road of self-righteous denunciation, and I have to submit my own tree to the same patient, empirical, merciless examination I am asking you to give to everyone else. By their fruits. Mine included. There is

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no other honest way to read this chapter.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

# Not Everyone Who Says Lord, Lord

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**NOT EVERYONE WHO SAYS** to me, Lord, Lord, will enter the kingdom of heaven, but the one who does the will of my Father who is in heaven. We have come to the most frightening passage in the entire sermon, the one that has kept honest believers awake at night for two thousand years, and it ought to frighten us, because it tells us that it is possible to say all the right words, to call Jesus Lord with apparent sincerity, to do impressive things in his name, and to arrive at the end having never known him at all.

Read the whole terrible scene, because Jesus draws it out. On that day many will say to me, Lord, Lord, did we not prophesy in your name, and cast out demons in your name, and do many mighty works in your name. And then will I declare to them, I never knew you, depart from me, you workers of lawlessness. Look at who these people are. They are not atheists. They are not pagans. They are not the obviously wicked. They are people who called Jesus Lord, who prophesied in his name, who cast out demons in his

name, who did mighty works in his name, religious people, active people, people with a ministry and a track record and miracles to show for it. By every external measure they were the spiritual heavyweights, the ones with the gifts and the results, and they come to the last day fully confident, reciting their resume, certain of their welcome. And Jesus says he never knew them. The most chilling words in the New Testament are spoken not to the irreligious but to the intensely religious, and they are spoken to people who were sure, right up to the final moment, that they were on the inside.

What separates them from those who enter, then, since it is plainly not their words and not even their works. Jesus tells us in the same breath. The one who enters is the one who does the will of my Father who is in heaven. It is doing the Father's will against doing mighty works, and we have to feel how strange that distinction is, because casting out a demon sounds like doing God's will, prophesying in his name sounds like doing God's will. But Jesus draws a line between the spectacular religious activity and the actual obedience, between the works done in his name and the will of the Father done in the heart and the life, and he says that the first can exist entirely without the second. You can build a whole ministry, perform genuine wonders, fill rooms and cast out demons and never once have submitted your actual life to the actual will of God, never loved your enemy, never let go of your Mammon, never made peace, never done the hard, unspectacular, daily will of the Father that the whole sermon has been describing. The will of the Father is not the impressive thing done in public in his name. It is the costly thing the sermon commands, lived out in private where no one is watching and no demon is being cast out, just the slow

obedience of a life actually surrendered.

This is the verdict that the whole sermon has been building toward, and it is a verdict against a religion of words and works without obedience, which is to say it is a verdict against most of what we have built. Because we have constructed a Christianity that runs almost entirely on the things Jesus says will not save us. We say Lord, Lord, with great feeling. We do mighty works, or things we count as mighty, programs and platforms and influence. We are intensely active in his name. And we have largely detached all of that from the one thing he says actually matters, the doing of the Father's will as the sermon defines it, the loving and the renouncing and the peacemaking and the truth-telling. We have a religion of saying and doing-in-his-name that has almost nothing to do with obeying, and Jesus is telling us, as plainly as he ever tells us anything, that such a religion does not lead where we think it leads, that we can be its most successful practitioners and hear, at the last, the words I never knew you.

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*The most chilling words in the New  
Testament are spoken not to the  
irreligious but to the intensely  
religious, by a Lord they were sure they  
served.*

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**I DO NOT WRITE** this to torment the anxious believer, and I want to say that carefully, because this passage can be

wielded as a weapon against tender consciences, can drive the sincere into despair, can be used to make people doubt a salvation that rests not on their performance but on grace. That is not its purpose, and the cure for that despair is in the word Jesus uses, *knew*. I never knew you. The issue is not whether you have done enough mighty works to qualify, which would throw us all back on the treadmill of performance the sermon spent two chapters dismantling. The issue is relationship, knowing and being known, and the doing of the Father's will is the fruit and the evidence of that relationship, not its purchase price. The people Jesus turns away are not turned away for doing too few works. They are turned away because for all their works they never actually knew him, never let him be Lord of the life and not just the lips, and their busy religious activity was a substitute for the relationship rather than the expression of it. The question this passage asks is not have you done enough. It is do you know him, and does he know you, and is your life, in its hidden and daily reality, the kind of life that flows from actually knowing the Lord you keep naming.

So the verdict lands, finally, on the gap between our words and our lives, which is the gap the whole sermon has been exposing from the first beatitude. We say Lord, Lord. The real question is whether the saying has ever cost us anything, whether calling him Lord has translated into the one thing that proves it is true, obedience, the actual doing of the actual will of the Father in the actual circumstances of our lives. It is possible to spend a lifetime in the church, fluent in the language, busy in the work, confident in the welcome, and to have never made that translation, to have a Christianity entirely of the mouth and the platform and never of the obedient heart. And the sermon, which began by blessing the

poor in spirit, ends by warning the rich in religious accomplishment, because the danger to the people of God has always been less that we will say too little than that we will say everything and do nothing, that we will call him Lord with such conviction that we never notice we have not obeyed him. Lord, Lord, is not enough. It was never enough. Only the doing of the Father's will, the whole sermon lived and not merely admired, finally proves that the Lord we name is the Lord we serve.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

# Two Houses, One Storm

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**EVERYONE THEN WHO HEARS** these words of mine and does them will be like a wise man who built his house on the rock. And everyone who hears these words of mine and does not do them will be like a foolish man who built his house on the sand. Jesus ends his sermon with a story, a parable of two builders, and it is the perfect ending, because it gathers up everything he has said and presses it down onto a single hinge, the hinge the whole sermon has been turning on, which is the difference between hearing and doing.

Notice first what the two builders have in common, because the common ground is the point. Both of them hear these words. Jesus does not contrast the person who heard the sermon with the person who did not. He contrasts two people who both heard it, both sat on the hillside, both took it in, both could repeat it back. The difference between them is not knowledge. They know the same things. The difference is that one did what he heard and the other did not, and on that single difference, doing or not doing, the entire outcome turns. This is the verdict on every form of Christianity that consists in hearing, in agreeing, in admiring, in studying, in being moved, without ever crossing over into doing. Both

houses were built by people who heard the sermon. Only one was built by a person who obeyed it, and when the test came, the hearing that had not become doing counted for nothing.

Then notice what the two builders also have in common, which is the storm. The rain fell, and the floods came, and the winds blew and beat on that house. And then again, the rain fell, and the floods came, and the winds blew and beat against that house. The same storm hits both houses. Jesus does not promise the wise builder a calm life and the foolish builder a hard one. He sends the identical weather against both, the same rain, the same floods, the same wind, because the storm is not the point of difference, the foundation is. This is honest in a way our preaching often is not, because we have implied that obedience to Jesus buys exemption from the storms, that the faithful life is the protected life, that if you build on the rock the weather will spare you. The parable says no such thing. It says the storm comes for everyone, the wise and the foolish alike, that no foundation keeps the rain away, and that the only question the storm answers is what you built on, not whether you would be tested. Everyone gets the storm. Not everyone survives it.

And the storm is the test that reveals the foundation, which was invisible until the weather came. On a clear day the two houses look the same. You cannot see a foundation. The house on sand and the house on rock present identical faces to the world, both standing, both finished, both apparently secure, and you could walk past them for years and never know which was which. It is only the storm that exposes the difference, that strips away the appearance and reveals what each house was actually resting on all along. The rock was always rock and the sand was always sand, but the truth of it was hidden until the flood came and one house

stood and the other fell, and great was the fall of it. Jesus is telling us that the foundation we are building on right now, in the fair weather, is a hidden fact that will not stay hidden, that the day is coming when the storm will reveal what we actually built our lives upon, and that on that day it will be far too late to dig down and pour a different foundation. The time to build on rock is before the rain. The storm does not let you choose your foundation. It only reveals the one you already chose.

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*The same storm beats on both houses.  
Obedience does not buy exemption  
from the weather. It only determines  
whether you are still standing when  
the weather has done its worst.*

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**WHAT IS THE ROCK**, then, and Jesus has just told us, though we are tempted to look elsewhere for a more comfortable answer. The rock is not, in this parable, a doctrine to believe or a feeling to have or even faith in the abstract. The rock is these words of mine, heard and done. The one who built on rock is the one who does them, who took the sermon and obeyed it, who loved his enemies and renounced his Mammon and made his peace and told his truth and pulled the log from his own eye, who did not merely admire the kingdom but lived in it. And the sand is the same words heard and not done, the sermon received and applauded and studied and never obeyed, the most dangerous foundation of

all because it looks so much like the real thing. The person on the sand is not a pagan. He is a churchgoer. He heard the whole sermon and nodded along and built his house and never noticed that he was building on the hearing alone, on the agreement, on the admiration, and that none of it had ever become obedience. He has a religion of hearing, and when the storm comes it will not hold, because hearing was never a foundation. Only doing is rock.

This is where the whole sermon has been driving, and I feel the weight of it land on this book, because a book about the Sermon on the Mount is, in the end, just more words to hear. I have spent these chapters trying to make you hear the sermon truly, to feel its political force, to see through the spiritualizing that has defanged it, and all of that is hearing, and Jesus has just told me that hearing is sand. If you put this book down moved, persuaded, even convicted, and your life does not change, then I have helped you build a more sophisticated house on the same sand, a house with a better view of the rock you never stepped onto. The sermon does not end with a doctrine to affirm. It ends with a command to obey and a storm that is coming, and the only faithful response to it is not agreement but obedience, not admiration but action, the slow and costly business of actually doing these words in the actual circumstances of an actual life. Hear and do. That is the whole ending. The hearing without the doing is the house on the sand, and the storm is already on the horizon, and great will be the fall of it.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

# They Were Astonished

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**AND WHEN JESUS FINISHED** these sayings, the crowds were astonished at his teaching, for he was teaching them as one who had authority, and not as their scribes. Matthew closes the sermon with the crowd's reaction, and it is the right place to end the address, because the reaction names the thing that has been hovering over every line, the question we have been circling for twenty-eight chapters without quite asking it directly. Who is this. By what right does he say all this. Where does a carpenter from Nazareth get the standing to revise the law of Moses, to bless and to curse, to describe the kingdom of God as though he were its King, to warn the religious experts that they will hear depart from me. The crowd felt the question before they could articulate it, and the word Matthew gives us for what they felt is astonishment.

They were astonished, and the cause of the astonishment was authority. He taught as one who had authority, and not as their scribes. We have to understand what that contrast meant to register what the crowd registered. The scribes were the trained teachers, the scholars, the experts in the law, and they taught in a particular way, by citation, by appeal to precedent, by stacking up the opinions of the great rabbis

who had gone before. A scribe would say Rabbi So-and-so taught this, and Rabbi Such-and-such taught that, and the weight of his teaching came entirely from the authorities he could quote. He had no authority of his own. He was a conduit for the tradition, a transmitter of what others had said, and that was the only legitimate way to teach. And then Jesus stood up and did something no scribe would ever dare. He said you have heard that it was said, and then he said but I say to you, setting his own bare word against the received tradition, against even the law itself, claiming an authority that came from no citation, that rested on no precedent, that stood entirely on the I of the one speaking. But I say to you. No prophet had spoken that way. The prophets said thus says the Lord, placing the authority outside themselves in the God who sent them. Jesus said but I say to you, placing the authority in himself, and the crowd was astonished because they had never heard anyone claim that, and there were only two possibilities for what it meant.

Because that is the corner this teaching backs us into, and it has backed every honest hearer into it for two thousand years. A man who teaches like this, who revises the law of God on his own authority, who describes the final judgment as the one who will pronounce the verdict, who says that everything turns on whether you do his words, is making a claim that is either monstrous or true, and there is no comfortable middle. If he is merely a wise teacher, a good moral instructor, an inspiring rabbi, then this is the speech of a megalomaniac, a man who has placed himself where only God belongs, who asks for an allegiance no mere teacher has any right to ask. The content of the sermon is beautiful, but the authority claimed in delivering it is total, and you cannot keep the beauty while discarding the claim, because the claim is

woven through the beauty. The one who tells you to love your enemies is the same one who tells you he will judge you at the last day, and they are the same sentence, the same I, the same astonishing authority. You cannot have the ethics of the sermon as a detachable wisdom while declining its Christology. The teacher will not let you. He has made himself the center of his own teaching, the rock you build on, the Lord you call, the one whose words decide the storm.

I felt this as an unbeliever, and it was, in the end, what undid my unbelief. I had wanted to keep the Sermon on the Mount as a piece of human wisdom, to admire the ethics and set aside the man, to take the love of enemies and the care for the poor and the hunger for justice as a noble philosophy I could affirm without affirming anything about Jesus himself. And I could not do it, because the sermon would not let me. The same voice that said blessed are the meek said but I say to you, claimed to fulfill the law, promised to judge the nations, made everything hang on himself. The authority was inseparable from the ethics. And I was left with the choice the crowd was left with, the choice every reader is finally left with, between concluding that this man was deluded or wicked, which the manifest goodness and sanity of the sermon makes nearly impossible, and concluding that he was who he spoke as though he was, the King describing his own kingdom, God giving the law a second time, not from the cloud now but from the grass, at eye level, among us. The sermon is a door, and it opens only one way, onto the person of the one who preached it.

*The same voice that said blessed are the  
meek said but I say to you, and you  
cannot keep the beauty of the one while  
discarding the claim of the other,  
because they are the same sentence.*

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**AND THIS IS WHY** the politics of the sermon, the whole argument of this book, finally rests not on a program but on a person. I have spent these chapters insisting that the Sermon on the Mount is political, that it is the constitution of a kingdom, that it describes a visible alternative community ordering its life around love of enemies and renunciation of Mammon and hunger for justice. All of that is true. But a constitution implies a king, and a kingdom implies a sovereign, and the authority that makes the sermon binding is not the persuasiveness of its ethics but the identity of the one who gave it. We do not love our enemies because it is a good policy that produces better social outcomes, though it may. We love our enemies because the King who has all authority commands it, and because he is the King, and because to belong to his kingdom is to obey its constitution. The astonishment of the crowd is the right response, and it is the response the church has too often lost, having reduced Jesus to a teacher whose advice we weigh rather than a King whose authority we are under. He did not teach like the scribes, offering opinions for our consideration. He taught as one who had authority, issuing the constitution of a kingdom, and the only fitting response to authority like that is not to

admire it but to bow to it and obey.

The sermon is over now. Matthew will go on, and Jesus will come down the mountain, and the rest of the gospel will show us this same authority healing and forgiving and finally dying and rising, proving by his life and his death that the authority he claimed was real. But the address itself ends here, with a stunned crowd and an unavoidable question, and the question is the one this whole book has been pressing toward. Not merely what does the sermon mean, but who is the one who preached it, because everything depends on the answer. If he is only a teacher, the sermon is an impossible ideal we are free to admire and ignore. If he is the King, it is the law of the land we are now living in, the constitution we are bound to, the standard by which we will be judged and the life we are summoned to live. The crowd was astonished. They were right to be. The only question left is whether the astonishment will turn into the one thing the sermon has been asking for all along, which is not applause, and not even agreement, but the bent knee and the obedient life of a citizen who has recognized the King.

## CHAPTER THIRTY

# The Sermon and the Cross

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**WE HAVE WALKED THE** whole sermon now, from the mountain to the astonished crowd, and there is a question that has been waiting at the bottom of every chapter, the question that decides whether any of this can actually be trusted, and it is this. Can the one who commands this life also live it. Because a teacher who demands the impossible and never attempts it himself is a fraud, a man laying burdens on others that he would not touch with his finger, and the world is full of such teachers. The thing that sets Jesus apart, the thing that turns the sermon from a beautiful cruelty into a livable gospel, is that he does not merely command this life. He lives it, all the way to the end, and the end is a cross.

Read the gospel forward from the mountain and watch the sermon become flesh. He said blessed are the poor, and he had nowhere to lay his head. He said blessed are the meek, and when they came for him with swords and clubs he told Peter to put the sword away and healed the ear that Peter had

cut. He said blessed are the peacemakers, and he made peace by his own blood between God and a hostile humanity. He said love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you, and from the cross, with the nails in him, he prayed Father forgive them for they know not what they do, loving his executioners in the act of being executed by them. He said do not resist the evil one, turn the other cheek, and he stood silent before his accusers, gave his back to those who beat him, did not open his mouth, refused every shortcut to the power that could have saved him. He said whoever would save his life will lose it, and he lost his, deliberately, refusing the legions of angels, choosing the nails. Every line of the sermon that we have called impossible, he did. The whole address is a self-portrait, and the portrait is finished on Golgotha.

This changes everything about how we hear the commands, because it means they do not come down to us from a safe height. We have a deep and reasonable suspicion of anyone who tells us to suffer, to sacrifice, to lay down our power and our security and our right to retaliate, because such commands are usually issued by people who have arranged to be exempt from them, who preach the cross from a comfortable distance and let others carry it. The sermon could be heard that way, as the demand of a teacher who will never have to love an enemy the way he is asking us to, never have to turn a cheek that is actually being struck, never have to lose anything real. And then the cross answers the suspicion completely, because Jesus goes first, goes all the way, asks nothing of us he has not already done in his own body, and does the hardest of it, the loving of enemies unto death, in the very act of being murdered by the enemies he loves. He has no exemption. He took the lowest place on the

hardest road and went through the narrow gate himself, stripped of everything, and only then does he turn and say follow me. The one who commands the cross is the one who carried it.

And the cross is not only the proof that he means it. It is the sermon's deepest political statement, made not in words but in an event. Because the cross is what happens when the kingdom of the sermon collides with the kingdoms of this world, and it shows us exactly how that collision goes. The powers of the age, the empire and the religious establishment, the very systems the sermon indicts, took the one who lived the sermon perfectly and they killed him, because a life like that is intolerable to them, exposes them, threatens them, cannot be allowed to stand. The cross is the world's verdict on the Sermon on the Mount, the answer of every principality and power to the question of what they will do with a man who actually loves his enemies and will not take up the sword and will not bow to Mammon and will not stop telling the truth. They crucify him. The sermon leads to the cross not by accident but by the iron logic of a world that cannot bear the kingdom, and Jesus knew it, and went anyway, which means that when he tells us to take up our cross and follow, he is telling us the truth about where this life leads in a world like ours. The city on the hill is also the target on the hill. He told us that in the Beatitudes, and then he showed us, in his own flesh, exactly what it costs.

*The cross is the world's verdict on the  
Sermon on the Mount, the answer of  
every power to the question of what  
they will do with a man who actually  
lives it.*

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**BUT HERE IS THE** turn, the thing that keeps the cross from being merely a tragedy, the proof that the powers' verdict was not the final word. God raised him. The stone rolled away and the tomb was empty and the one the world condemned for living the sermon was vindicated by the only authority that finally matters, and the resurrection is the Father's reversal of the world's verdict, the announcement that the meek really will inherit the earth, that the way of the cross really is the way to life, that the kingdom the sermon describes is not a beautiful loser's creed but the actual future of the world, secured and guaranteed by the empty grave. The Beatitudes are not wishful thinking. They are eyewitness reporting from the far side of the resurrection. The meek will inherit the earth because the meekest man who ever lived was raised from the dead and given all authority in heaven and on earth. The hunger for justice will be satisfied because the just one who was murdered is alive and is coming to judge. The whole sermon stands or falls on the resurrection, and the resurrection makes it stand, turns every impossible promise into a certainty, and tells us that to live this life now, at cost, in a hostile world, is not to throw our lives away but to invest them in the one kingdom the grave could not hold.

So we can trust the one who commands this life, and that trust is the only thing that makes the commands bearable, because we are not being asked to follow a teacher into a sacrifice he avoided but to follow a King through a death he has already conquered. He went down the mountain to the cross to establish the kingdom he had described from its summit, and he rose to guarantee it, and now he turns to us, his scarred hands open, and asks us to follow him down the same road, loving the same enemies, refusing the same sword, carrying the same cross, trusting the same Father who raised him to raise us too. The sermon was never a set of detached ethical demands. It was always the description of his life, the life he lived and died and rose to give us, and to obey it is not to attempt an impossible self-improvement but to be conformed to the one we follow, to take the shape of the King who went first. We can do this, not because it is easy and not because it is safe, but because he did it, and lives, and has promised to do in us what he has already done in himself. The cross is why we can trust him. The empty tomb is why we can follow him. And the sermon is the map of the road, drawn by the one who has already walked every step of it ahead of us.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

# Why the Church Stopped Believing It

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**IF THE SERMON IS** what I have said it is, the constitution of a visible kingdom, lived and proven by the King himself, then a hard question presses in and will not leave, the question that haunted me as an unbeliever and haunts me still. Why does the church so obviously not live it. Why is the gap between the sermon and the people who claim it so wide that the gap itself has become an argument against the faith. The answer is a long and painful story, and I am inside it, and the honest telling of it has to begin not with the failures of others but with a recognition that I belong to the institution that made the trade.

For the first three centuries, the church mostly believed the sermon and mostly tried to live it, and it lived it as a persecuted minority with no access to power, which turns out to be the condition in which the sermon is easiest to take seriously. The early Christians would not serve in the legions, would not return violence for violence, shared their goods with the poor, cared for the plague-stricken when the pagans

fled, refused the oaths and the idolatries of the empire, and were killed for it, and they understood their dying as a participation in the cross, the city on the hill paying the price the sermon had promised it would pay. They had no power to compromise, no thrones to be tempted by, no empire to defend, and so the sermon remained for them what it had been on the mountain, the dangerous and beautiful law of a kingdom at odds with the world. They were salt and light precisely because they were a powerless, peculiar, visible alternative, and the watching empire could not account for them, and the church grew under the blood like a seed in the dark.

And then came the turn, the great hinge of the whole story, and it has a name and a date. In the year 312 the emperor Constantine, on the eve of a battle, claimed a vision and made the cross his standard, and within a generation the faith that the empire had been crucifying became the faith the empire endorsed, and by the end of that century it was the official religion of Rome. We have been taught to see this as a triumph, the victory of the church, the moment the gospel conquered the empire, and there is a way to tell it as a gift, the end of persecution, the freedom to worship. But there is another way to tell it, the truer way I think, which is that this was the moment the church was handed the very thing the sermon had told it to refuse, which was power, coercive worldly power, the sword of Caesar, and the church took it. It took the throne the meek were supposed to inherit only at the end and decided to inherit it now, by the world's means. It picked up the sword Jesus had told Peter to put down. And in taking the power, it had to quietly set the sermon aside, because you cannot run an empire on the Sermon on the Mount, cannot wield the sword while loving your enemies,

cannot tax and conquer and execute while turning the other cheek, and so the sermon, which had been the church's constitution, became its embarrassment, the impossible ideal that had to be explained away so that the new arrangement could stand.

And explain it away we did, with great theological ingenuity, over the centuries that followed, and these are the strategies we are still using. We said the sermon was an interim ethic, meant only for the short time before the kingdom came, not for the long haul of running a Christian society. We said it was meant for a spiritual elite, for monks and clergy who took the hard counsels, while ordinary Christians lived by a lower standard out in the real world. We said it described an inner attitude only, that you could love your enemy in your heart while killing him with your hand, turn the other cheek in your disposition while wielding the sword in your office. We said it was meant to drive us to despair of our own righteousness so that we would rest on grace, and therefore was never actually meant to be obeyed at all, a strange reading that turns the most detailed ethical instruction in the New Testament into a deliberate impossibility. Every one of these strategies has its sophisticated defenders, and every one of them performs the same function, which is to release the church from having to live the sermon while keeping it on the books, to neutralize the constitution without repealing it, to let us go on calling Jesus Lord while declining to do what he said.

*The church did not lose the sermon by forgetting it. We lost it by gaining the one thing it told us to refuse, and then explaining, with great care, why we did not have to obey it anymore.*

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**THIS IS THE LONG** accommodation, the marriage of the church to power that began at Milvian Bridge and has never really ended, and its fruit is the church we have, a church that in its actual political behavior is largely indistinguishable from the powers around it, that fights and hoards and fears and hates with the same fluency as everyone else, that has the sermon in its scriptures and the world's logic in its bones. Augustine, writing as the empire crumbled, gave us the two cities, the city of God and the city of man, and he meant something profound and true about the difference between the kingdom and the world. But the two cities became, in lesser hands, a permission, a way of saying that the church could live by one ethic in its spiritual life and by the world's ethic in its public life, that the Sermon on the Mount governed the city of God while the sword governed the city of man and the same Christians could be citizens of both at once, loving enemies on Sunday and killing them on Tuesday with an untroubled conscience. The genius of the accommodation is that it let us keep everything, the cross and the sword, the sermon and the empire, the name of Jesus and the means of Caesar, and the cost of keeping everything was that we lost the one thing that made us salt, our difference, our

peculiarity, the visible alternative that was supposed to be our witness.

I cannot tell this story as an outsider, and this is where the chapter has to turn on me and on the church I love and serve. I am a pastor in a church that has made this trade and is making it still, and I have benefited from the trade, have enjoyed the comfort and the respectability and the safety that came when the church stopped being a dangerous alternative and became a chaplain to the existing order. The accommodation is not a sin of the distant past committed by people I can safely judge. It is the water I swim in, the assumptions I inherited, the reflexes I have to fight in my own ministry every week, the constant temptation to preach a sermon that will not cost my people anything, that will let them keep their power and their Mammon and their enemies, that will spiritualize the constitution one more time so that no one has to actually live it. The reason the church stopped believing the sermon is not finally a historical puzzle about Constantine. It is a present reality about us, about me, about the daily preference for power over faithfulness, comfort over cost, the wide road over the narrow gate. We stopped believing it because believing it is expensive, and we found we would rather have the empire. And the only way back is the way the sermon always demanded, repentance, the surrender of the power we were never supposed to take, the return to the dangerous and beautiful life of a people who have nothing to defend but the truth and no king but the one on the mountain.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

# Can This Actually Be Lived

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**AFTER A CHAPTER LIKE** the last one, the despair is reasonable. If the church has spent seventeen centuries explaining away the sermon and accommodating itself to power, if even the writer of this book confesses he is caught in the same trade, then perhaps the honest conclusion is that the Sermon on the Mount simply cannot be lived, that it is a beautiful impossibility after all, a standard suited only to the sinless Christ and forever out of reach for the rest of us. I want to answer that despair, and I want to answer it not with a theory but with witnesses, with the names and dates of people and communities who took the sermon literally and proved, at cost, that it can be lived. The accommodation is the main story of the church, but it is not the only story. There has always been a remnant who refused the trade, and they are our evidence.

Begin with the monastics, because they are the church's oldest answer to the question. When Constantine made the faith comfortable, some Christians fled to the deserts of Egypt

precisely because they sensed that comfort was killing the gospel, and they went to live the sermon in earnest, in poverty and prayer and the renunciation of power, and from them grew the whole monastic tradition, the communities that held goods in common and welcomed the stranger and refused the sword and made the Sermon on the Mount their actual rule of life. We can fault the monastic solution for conceding too much, for accepting the idea that the sermon was only for a spiritual elite while the rest of the church lived by a lower standard, and that concession was a real loss. But we cannot deny what the monasteries proved, which is that communities of ordinary, fallen human beings can in fact order their common life around the renunciation of property and violence and self-will, can do it for centuries, can build a visible alternative society that actually runs on the principles the sermon lays down. The witness is real even where the theology was incomplete. It can be done.

Then come the radical reformers, the ones the history books call the Anabaptists, and here the witness sharpens, because they took the sermon out of the monastery and tried to make it the rule for the whole church again. In the sixteenth century, while the great Reformers were rebuilding the church in alliance with the princes and the magistrates, these radicals read the Sermon on the Mount and concluded that the whole Constantinian arrangement was a betrayal, that the church was never meant to wield the sword or marry the state, that Christians were called to refuse violence, to take no oaths, to hold no offices that required killing, to live as a free and visible community of the baptized under no king but Christ. And they were slaughtered for it, by Catholics and Protestants alike, drowned and burned in their thousands, because a community that actually refuses to take up the

sword is intolerable to the powers, just as the sermon promised. They paid the price the city on the hill always pays, and their descendants, the Mennonites and the Amish and the Brethren, have gone on for five hundred years living without violence, holding the sermon as a literal rule, proving across the centuries that a community can refuse the sword and survive, can love its enemies and endure, can take Jesus at his word and not collapse. We may find their separatism too complete, but we cannot say they failed to live the thing. They lived it. They are living it now.

And then, in our own time, the witnesses I find I cannot get past, the ones whose names carry dates I keep returning to. In 1935 a young German pastor named Dietrich Bonhoeffer, watching his church capitulate to Hitler, gathered a community of seminarians at Finkenwalde and built their common life directly on the Sermon on the Mount, and out of that community came the book that has shaped me more than any other on this text, *The Cost of Discipleship*, published in 1937, which is finally one long argument that the sermon means exactly what it says and that the church's whole effort to soften it is the betrayal Bonhoeffer named cheap grace, the grace that costs nothing and changes nothing and lets us keep everything. Bonhoeffer wrote that when Christ calls a man, he bids him come and die, and then he proved he meant it, returning to Germany when he could have stayed safe, joining the resistance, and being hanged by the Nazis in April of 1945, weeks before the war ended, a martyr who had built his life on this sermon and paid its full price. He is the answer to the question of whether it can be lived, and the answer is yes, and the answer is a gallows.

*The sermon has always had its witnesses, the remnant who refused the trade, and they are scattered across the centuries like lamps, proving at the cost of their lives that the impossible can be lived.*

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**AND THEN THE MOVEMENT** that took these very texts and shook a nation, the American civil rights movement, where in the 1950s and 1960s Martin Luther King Junior and the people he led read the Sermon on the Mount and the example of Gandhi, who had himself drawn on these chapters, and built a campaign of nonviolent resistance directly on the command to love enemies and turn the other cheek and refuse to answer violence with violence. They did not spiritualize the sermon into private inner peace. They took it into the streets, into Birmingham and Selma and Montgomery, and they faced the dogs and the fire hoses and the clubs and the bombs, and they refused to strike back, and they prayed for the people beating them, and they loved their enemies in public, on camera, in front of a watching nation, and the moral force of that obedience did what no amount of returned violence could ever have done. King understood, as he wrote from the Birmingham jail in 1963, that this was the most powerful weapon available to an oppressed people, and he was right, and he proved it, and he paid for it with his life in 1968, one more name in the long line of those who lived the sermon and were killed for it. The civil rights movement

is, to my mind, one of the most faithful readings of the Sermon on the Mount in the entire history of the church, more faithful than most of what happened in our pulpits, and it stands as overwhelming evidence that these texts are not a beautiful impossibility but a livable, world-shaking power in the hands of people willing to pay their cost.

So I will not let the despair stand, and I will not let myself or my readers hide behind the comfortable lie that the sermon cannot be lived. It can be lived. It has been lived, by the desert monks and the drowned Anabaptists and the hanged pastor and the murdered preacher and ten thousand others whose names we do not know, ordinary people who took Jesus at his word and ordered their common life around it and accepted the cost. The thing they all have in common is the cost. None of them lived the sermon cheaply, none of them found a way to obey it that left their comfort and their safety and their power intact, because there is no such way, and the whole accommodation has been one long search for the obedience that costs nothing, which does not exist. The witnesses prove that it can be lived, and they prove in the same breath what it costs to live it, and the two facts are one fact. It can be lived, at the price of a cross. That is the only way it has ever been lived, and the only way it ever will be, and the cloud of witnesses who have already paid the price are not standing at a distance judging us. They are cheering us on, calling us to lay aside the weight and run the race they have already finished, into the same costly, beautiful, possible obedience that cost them everything and proved that the sermon is true.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

# The Politics of the Poor in Practice

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**I HAVE SAID THROUGHOUT** this book that the sermon takes the side of the poor, that it enters the world from the bottom and works its way up, that the first beatitude is the doorway and that a community shaped by it cannot adopt the world's contempt for need. But I have said it mostly as a principle, and principles are cheap, and the sermon is relentlessly concrete, so I want to stop and ask what it would actually mean, in the ordinary economic life of a real community, to take the side of the poor the way the whole arc of the mountain demands. Because this is where the spiritualizing has done its quietest and most expensive work, turning a hard economic teaching into a warm inner disposition that costs the comfortable nothing.

Start with what the sermon assumes about poverty, which is that it is real, present, and an evil to be relieved rather than a metaphor to be admired. The crowd on the hillside was poor in the literal sense, hungry, indebted, one bad season from ruin, and Jesus addressed their poverty as a fact, not a

figure of speech. He blessed them, and then he spent his ministry feeding them, healing them, touching the ones the system had thrown away. When he taught his disciples to pray, he taught them to ask for bread, daily bread, the concrete provision of the body, not merely the bread of heaven but the actual loaf the hungry need. And when he described the Father's care, he described it in the most material terms, clothing and food and the basic securities of the body, the very things the poor lack and the comfortable take for granted. The sermon never floats free of the body and its hungers. It is rooted in them, addressed to people who knew hunger in their flesh, and any reading that turns its concern for the poor into a purely spiritual abstraction has cut it loose from the ground it grew in.

So a community formed by this sermon would be, before anything else, a community in which the poor are at home, and I mean that with full literalness. Not a community that runs programs for the poor from a comfortable distance, that does charity to the poor while remaining a fundamentally middle-class institution organized around middle-class needs, but a community in which the poor are members, present, visible, belonging, in which the line between the helpers and the helped has been erased because all are equally dependent on the same grace. The early church did this. They held goods in common, sold their possessions and distributed to any who had need, made sure there was no needy person among them, and the result was a community in which a person's poverty did not exclude them and a person's wealth did not elevate them, in which the social hierarchy of the surrounding world was overturned inside the walls of the church. We have mostly lost this. Our churches tend to sort themselves by income, comfortable

congregations for the comfortable and struggling ones for the struggling, and the radical economic mixing the early church practiced, the actual sharing across the line of wealth and poverty, has become so rare that we hardly imagine it as an option.

What would it cost us to recover it, and the answer is the answer the sermon always gives, which is that it would cost us our security, the very thing Jesus spent a whole passage telling us to stop clutching. Because you cannot take the side of the poor in any real way while organizing your life around the protection and accumulation of your own wealth, cannot hold your possessions loosely while building your existence on having more of them, cannot make the poor at home in your community while structuring that community around the comfort of the prosperous. The thing the sermon asks is not a tithe, a manageable percentage that leaves the basic arrangement intact, but a fundamental reorientation, a holding of everything with open hands, a readiness to give that does not first secure our own future, a treatment of our possessions as belonging finally to the kingdom and held by us only in trust for the relief of need. That is a frightening thing to write, because I do not live it, not fully, not the way the early church lived it, and I feel the gap between the principle I can articulate and the life I actually arrange, the gap between admiring the sermon and obeying it.

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*A community formed by this sermon  
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*be a community in which the poor are  
members, present, belonging, at home.*

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**AND THERE IS A** public dimension to this that I will not let us escape, because the sermon will not let us confine our concern for the poor to private charity while supporting every arrangement that produces their poverty. The Golden Rule, do to others what you would have them do to you, reaches into the structures, asks whether I would accept for myself the conditions I am content to let others endure, and it indicts not only my failure to give but my participation in systems that take. The prophets, whom Jesus came to fulfill, were not content with private almsgiving. They thundered against the structures of injustice, the rigged scales and the seized fields and the courts that ruled for the powerful, the whole machinery by which the strong made the poor poorer, and they named it as the thing God hated most. A community that took the sermon seriously could not love the poor in private while supporting in public the arrangements that crush them, could not feed a hungry man on Sunday and vote on Tuesday for the structures that made him hungry, could not separate its charity from its complicity. The politics of the poor in the sermon is not only generosity. It is justice, the setting right of the arrangements themselves, and that is a far more costly and a far more public thing than writing a check.

I have to end this chapter where the sermon ends every chapter, inside the indictment, because I am a comfortable man writing about poverty, and there is an obscenity in that which I cannot fully escape and will not pretend to. I have arranged my life for security. I have more than my daily

bread, stored against tomorrow in exactly the way Jesus warned against. I love the poor more easily in principle than in the costly particulars of an actual shared life, and the gap between my words and my arrangements is the same gap I have spent this whole book naming in the church, present in me, unresolved. I do not write this from above the problem but from inside it, and the only honest thing I can do is name it and ask, with the rich young ruler whose face I recognize in the mirror, what I still lack, knowing the answer, knowing it is the one thing I have been least willing to give. The sermon takes the side of the poor. The hard question, the one I have not finished answering in my own life, is whether I am willing to stand where the sermon stands, or whether I will go away sorrowful, because I have great possessions.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

# The Politics of the Enemy

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**OF ALL THE LINES** in the sermon, love your enemies is the one I keep returning to, because it is the one the church is most obviously failing in our moment and the one whose failure does the most damage to our witness. I gave it a chapter when we walked through chapter five, but it deserves a second look here, near the end, as a question of practical politics, because the command to love enemies is not a private feeling we can manage in our hearts while continuing to treat actual enemies exactly as the world treats them. It is a public, costly, visible reordering of how we relate to the people we are most certain we are entitled to oppose, and the gap between the command and our practice has become a scandal that I believe is driving people away from Christ in numbers we have not begun to reckon with.

Consider what an enemy actually is, because we soften the word and Jesus did not. An enemy is not someone who mildly annoys you. An enemy is someone who threatens you, who opposes you, who would harm you or your people if they

could, who stands on the other side of a real conflict with real stakes. Jesus was not commanding his hearers to be pleasant to people they found tiresome. He was commanding occupied people to love the occupier, oppressed people to love the oppressor, people whose neighbors had been crucified by Rome to love the Romans, and he was doing it not as a sentimental gesture but as a hard command with the full weight of his authority behind it. The love he commanded was not a warm feeling, which cannot be commanded anyway, but a settled disposition of the will toward the enemy's good, expressed in concrete action, prayer for them, blessing of them, the refusal to return their hostility in kind. He was asking the hardest thing a human being can be asked, to will the good of the person who wills your harm, and he was asking it of everyone, not just the spiritually advanced.

Now set that against how the church in my country actually behaves toward its enemies, and feel the distance, because I cannot pretend it away. We have enemies, or we have decided we do, the people on the other side of our political and cultural divides, and we treat them with a contempt that has become not just tolerated among us but expected, even celebrated, a mark of seriousness and faithfulness. We do not pray for them. We pray against them. We do not bless them. We mock them, share the cruelest characterizations of them, delight in their defeats, want not just to disagree with them but to humiliate them, to see them lose, to see them suffer for being wrong. We have learned to hate with the same fluency as the godless world around us, and we have learned to do it while quoting scripture, to dress our tribalism in the language of righteousness, to call our contempt a defense of the truth. And the watching world, which is not stupid, sees perfectly well that we hate exactly

the people everyone else hates, that our religion has not made us love our enemies but has only given us holier reasons to despise them, and it concludes, reasonably, that the gospel is a fraud, because it can see that it has not changed the one thing Jesus said it must change.

This is, I am convinced, the single most damaging thing the church is currently doing to its own witness, more damaging than any doctrinal error or moral failure, because it is the public, visible, daily contradiction of the one command Jesus said would prove we are his Father's children. He told us that loving the people who love us is nothing, that the tax collectors and the pagans do that much, that the only love that marks us as his is love for the enemy. And we have built a Christianity that loves its own with great passion and hates its enemies with great fluency, which is to say we have built exactly the religion of the tax collectors and the pagans, the tribal love that every gang and faction and nation already has, and we have stamped the name of Jesus on it. We have nothing the world does not already have. We have become, in our actual political behavior, just another tribe scrambling for power and despising the other tribe, and the only thing that distinguishes us is the volume of our claim to be different, which makes the contradiction louder, not quieter.

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**WHAT WOULD IT LOOK** like to actually obey this, and I want to be concrete because the command is concrete. It would mean praying, really praying, for the good of the people we have been treating as enemies, by name, regularly, until the praying began to change the way we see them. It would mean refusing to share the cruel characterization, the dehumanizing meme, the contemptuous dismissal, even when it is aimed at people who are genuinely wrong, even when it would win us approval from our own side, because the contempt is itself the sin and we may not traffic in it. It would mean wanting the good of our opponents, their flourishing and not their destruction, being unable to delight in their suffering even when they are our adversaries, because they are our Father's children and he sends rain on them and we are called to bear his likeness. It would mean being, in a culture organized around the sorting of people into friends and enemies and the hatred of the enemies, a community that stubbornly refuses to hate, that keeps loving across the line everyone else is policing, that prays for the people it is supposed to despise. That would be salt. That would be light. That would be a thing the world could not explain or produce on its own, and it would be a more powerful argument for the gospel than every culture-war victory we have ever chased.

And I have to say plainly that I am not asking this of others from a position of having achieved it, because I have felt the hatred in my own heart, have shared the contemptuous dismissal, have delighted in the defeat of people I had decided were the enemy, have prayed against rather than for.

The command convicts me first. When I say the church is failing this, I mean I am failing it, that the tribal hatred Jesus condemned is alive in my own chest, that I have to fight it every day and lose more often than I win. The love of enemies is not a high standard I have reached and am calling others up to. It is a cliff I am clinging to, slipping, hauling myself back, asking the Father for the strength to do the one thing I cannot do on my own, which is to love the people I most want to hate. That is the politics of the enemy in the sermon, and it begins not with the enemies out there but with the hatred in here, and there is no version of faithfulness to Jesus that does not start with repenting of it, mine first.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

# The Politics of Truth

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**WE LIVE IN THE** wreckage of truth, and the sermon speaks directly into that wreckage, though we have not often heard it as a word about our public crisis because we filed the relevant passage under personal honesty and moved on. Let your yes be yes and your no be no. I gave that command its chapter when we walked through chapter five, but I want to return to it here because the collapse of public truth in our moment is so total, and the church's complicity in that collapse so deep, that the sermon's vision of a community that simply does not lie has become not a quaint personal ethic but a startling and urgent political possibility.

Recall what the command actually does. It abolishes the whole apparatus of oaths and graded honesty by raising ordinary speech to a standard so high that the apparatus becomes unnecessary, and in doing so it envisions a community whose plain word can be trusted absolutely, where there is no special category of extra-true speech because all speech is true. The existence of oaths, Jesus understood, is an admission that ordinary speech is assumed to be unreliable, that we expect people to shade and spin and deceive until forced to swear, and he calls his people out of

that whole arrangement into a radical, simple, dangerous truthfulness, a life in which yes means yes because the person saying it does not lie. That is a vision of a community defined by the trustworthiness of its word, and every social order, as I said earlier, runs on some level of trust, and the level of trust determines almost everything about how a society can function.

Now look at the world we actually inhabit, where public truth has not merely declined but in places nearly collapsed, where lying has become a normal and accepted tool of public life, where the powerful lie as a matter of course and are not expected to do otherwise, where the very idea that there is a truth to be told has been eroded into the idea that there are only competing narratives, only perspectives, only the spin of whichever side you are on. We have entered a condition in which no one expects to be told the truth by anyone with power, in which the question asked of a public statement is not is it true but whose side does it serve, in which the deliberate, strategic, shameless lie has become an ordinary instrument of public life. This is a profound social catastrophe, because a society in which truth has collapsed cannot trust, and a society that cannot trust cannot function, and we are watching, in real time, the slow seizing-up of a common life that has lost its grip on the shared truth that made cooperation possible. The wreckage of truth is the wreckage of trust, and the wreckage of trust is the wreckage of the polity itself.

And here is the grief I cannot avoid. The church, which was supposed to be the one community on earth where yes means yes, has too often joined the lying rather than resisted it. We have learned to spin, to shade, to traffic in the convenient falsehood and the strategic exaggeration, to

defend our side with the same disregard for truth as everyone else, to prefer the lie that serves our cause to the truth that complicates it. We have, in some quarters, become enthusiastic consumers and spreaders of falsehood, sharing what confirms our fears without asking whether it is true, repeating what damages our enemies without checking whether it happened, because the lie was useful and the truth was inconvenient. The people commanded to let their yes be yes have become, in our public behavior, indistinguishable from a culture of liars, and we have done it while claiming to serve the One who called himself the truth. There is no clearer betrayal of the sermon, and few that do more damage, because a church that lies has forfeited the one thing that might have made it a refuge in a world drowning in deception.

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*A society in which truth has collapsed  
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**WHAT WOULD IT MEAN** for the church to take up the sermon's command in this moment, and the answer is almost dizzying in its simplicity and its difficulty. It would mean becoming, again, a community that simply does not lie, that tells the truth even when the truth is costly, even when the truth helps our enemies and hurts our cause, even when the

lie would be useful and no one would catch it. It would mean refusing to spread what we have not verified, refusing to repeat the convenient falsehood, refusing to shade and spin and strategically mislead, holding ourselves to a truthfulness so complete that our plain word could be trusted in a world where no one's word can. It would mean being an island of high trust in a sea of low-trust deception, a people whose simple yes carries the full weight that others can only fake by swearing, and that witness, in our moment of collapsed public truth, would be almost as startling as a miracle. The world has nearly forgotten what it is like to be told the truth by people who could profit from a lie. A church that simply did not lie would be a wonder, a light, a city on a hill that the watching world could not help but see, and the cost of it would be only this, that we would have to give up the lies that serve us, which turns out to be a great deal to give up.

The politics of truth in the sermon is finally this, that a community of people who do not lie is a community the powers cannot fully control, because the great instrument of every illegitimate power is the lie, the manipulation of the truth, the manufacture of the convenient narrative, and a people who simply will not participate, who insist on the plain truth even at cost, who cannot be enlisted in the lie, are a standing resistance to every regime that runs on deception. Bonhoeffer understood this in a Germany drowning in lies, understood that telling the truth was itself an act of resistance, that the refusal to repeat the official falsehood was a kind of warfare against a regime built on the lie, and he paid for his truthfulness with his life. The command to let our yes be yes is not a minor matter of personal honesty. It is the foundation of a community that the lie cannot capture, and in a moment when the lie has captured almost everything, the

## THE SERMON ON THE MOUNT AS POLITICS

recovery of that simple truthfulness might be one of the most powerful and most political things the church could do. Yes means yes. It sounds small. In a world of liars, it is a revolution.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

# The Politics of Power

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**THE SERMON IS, FROM** beginning to end, a teaching about power, about who holds it and how it is used and what happens to it in the kingdom of God, and yet we have managed to read it as though power were the one subject it never addressed. We made it private, interior, a matter of the individual soul, and in doing so we removed from it the very thing that made it dangerous, which was its frontal assault on the way power works in the world. So I want to gather up what the sermon says about power and lay it out plainly, because I think the church's relationship to power is the deepest of all its betrayals of the mountain, the root from which the others grow.

Begin with the Beatitudes, which are a teaching about power before they are anything else. Blessed are the poor, the mourners, the meek, the hungry, the persecuted, which is to say blessed are the powerless, the people the existing arrangement of power has crushed or excluded, and the blessing is precisely a reversal of the power order, a promise that the kingdom belongs to the ones the world has placed at the bottom. The meek shall inherit the earth is a statement about who ends up holding power, and the answer is the

opposite of every answer the world has ever given, because the world says power goes to the strong who seize it and Jesus says the earth goes to the meek who refuse to. The whole opening of the sermon is an inversion of the power hierarchy, a declaration that when God is king the rankings are turned over, the first become last and the last first, and the people with the chariots discover they bet on the losing side. You cannot read the Beatitudes as anything but political once you see that they are about power, about its reversal, about the overthrow of the arrangement that gives the world to the strong.

Then trace power through the rest of the sermon and watch how consistently Jesus tells his people to refuse the world's way of holding it. Turn the other cheek, which is the refusal to answer power with power, the rejection of the escalating violence that is power's basic language. Love your enemies, which is the refusal to treat power as the sorting of the world into those we serve and those we crush. Do not lay up treasure, you cannot serve God and Mammon, which is the refusal of the economic power that the world organizes itself around. Do not practice your righteousness to be seen, which is the refusal of the power of reputation and status. Judge not, which is the refusal of the power to condemn. Again and again the sermon takes a form of power that the world treats as the whole point of life, the power of violence, of wealth, of status, of condemnation, and it tells the citizens of the kingdom to lay it down, to refuse it, to find their security and their identity somewhere other than in the holding of it. The sermon is a sustained renunciation of the world's power, and the King who preached it proved he meant it by refusing the legions and going to the cross, taking the lowest place rather than seizing the highest.

This is why the church's seizure of power, beginning with Constantine and continuing to this day, is the deepest betrayal of the sermon, deeper than any single moral failure, because it is the rejection of the sermon's whole logic about power at the root. We were given a constitution that tells us to refuse the world's power and to find our strength in weakness, in service, in the cross, and we decided instead that we would have the power after all, that we would hold the throne and wield the sword and command the culture, that the kingdom would advance not by the slow weakness of love but by the fast efficiency of control. And every time the church reaches for that power, it abandons the sermon, because the two are incompatible. You cannot love your enemies and hold the sword over them. You cannot refuse to serve Mammon and build your strategy on wealth. You cannot decline to condemn and run a regime of religious condemnation. The power the world offers comes at the price of the sermon, every time, and the church has paid that price again and again, choosing the power and losing the constitution, and calling the trade a victory for the kingdom when it was the kingdom's defeat.

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*We were given a constitution that tells  
us to refuse the world's power and find  
our strength in the cross, and we  
decided instead that we would have the  
power after all.*

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**THE TEMPTATION IS LAID** out for us in the gospel itself, before the ministry even begins, in the wilderness. The devil takes Jesus to a high place and shows him all the kingdoms of the world and their glory and offers them to him, all the power, all the dominion, the whole world handed over, on one condition, that Jesus would worship him, would take the power by the world's means and on the world's terms. And Jesus refuses, because he has come to inherit those same kingdoms by another road entirely, the road of the cross, the long weakness of love, the way down rather than the way up. The temptation in the wilderness is precisely the temptation to seize the right end by the wrong means, to gain the kingdoms of the world through the worship of power rather than through the cross, and Jesus says no. And the church, offered the same bargain by the same tempter, all the kingdoms of the world and their glory if we will only take the power on the world's terms, has too often said yes, has bowed to the power it was offered and called it stewardship, has taken the shortcut Jesus refused and told itself it was advancing the kingdom of the one who refused it.

So the politics of power in the sermon comes down to a choice the church faces in every generation and is facing now, the choice between two ways of trying to change the world, the way of power and the way of the cross. The way of power is fast, efficient, visible, and it works, in the sense that it can compel behavior and win arguments and hold territory, and it is the way the world has always operated and the way the church is perpetually tempted to adopt. The way of the cross is slow, weak, costly, often invisible, and it does not compel anything, it can only love and serve and suffer and witness, and it is the way Jesus chose and the way he commands. The church has spent most of its history trying to

have it both ways, to hold the cross in its theology and the sword in its hand, and it does not work, because the sword always wins the argument and the cross always loses the territory, and a church that holds both ends up serving the sword while talking about the cross. The sermon asks us to let go of the sword entirely, to stake everything on the slow weak power of love, to trust that the meek really will inherit the earth and that we do not have to seize it ourselves. That is the hardest thing the sermon asks, harder even than loving enemies, because it asks us to give up the very thing that feels like the only way to get anything done, and to trust instead the crucified King who got everything done by being nailed to a tree.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

# The Hidden Life of the Citizen

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**MUCH OF THE SERMON** happens in secret. Give in secret, so your left hand does not know what your right hand is doing. Pray in secret, in your room with the door shut. Fast in secret, so no one knows. The Father who sees in secret will reward you. I have written about these commands as a war on performance, the rejection of the religion that does its righteousness to be seen, and that is right. But there is something deeper in the call to secrecy that I want to draw out here, near the end, because it touches the strange truth that the most political life is also the most hidden one, that the citizen of the kingdom does most of the real work where no one can see.

We have a deep instinct that to be political is to be public, loud, visible, that the way to change the world is to be seen changing it, to make our righteousness conspicuous, to perform our convictions before an audience. And the sermon both affirms and contradicts this. It affirms the visibility, you are the light of the world, a city on a hill that cannot be

hidden, let your light shine. But it locates the visibility in the works themselves, the just and merciful and peacemaking life of the community, and not in the performance of them, and it insists with equal force on the hiddenness of the heart's devotion, the secret giving and the closed-door prayer and the unannounced fasting. The two are not in tension once you see what each is for. The works are to be visible so that God gets the glory. The devotion is to be hidden so that the self does not. And the citizen of the kingdom lives in that strange combination, a visible life of good works flowing out of a hidden life of secret devotion, the public fruit growing from the private root, and the root is where the real life is.

This matters because we are perpetually tempted to invert it, to make the devotion public and the works private, to perform our piety where it can be seen and to do our actual loving and giving and serving rarely or not at all. We broadcast our prayers and our convictions and our righteous anger to an audience, performing the inner life as content, while the concrete works the sermon commands, the enemy actually loved, the poor actually helped, the truth actually told at cost, happen seldom and quietly if at all. We have a loud devotion and a thin practice, exactly the reverse of what Jesus describes, and the loudness of the devotion serves to hide the thinness of the practice, even from ourselves. The hidden life Jesus commands is the cure for this, because when the devotion goes into the secret place, when the prayer happens behind a closed door with no audience, the only reason left to do it is God, and a devotion that has only God for its audience is a devotion that will actually change the one who practices it, will actually produce the works, will actually grow the fruit, because it is real and not a performance.

There is a political genius in this hiddenness that I do not

think we have appreciated, because it makes the citizen of the kingdom incorruptible by the very thing that corrupts most public actors, which is the audience. The person whose righteousness is performed for a crowd is owned by the crowd, must give the crowd what it wants, must shape his convictions and his actions to the applause he is fishing for, and is therefore not free, is a slave to the reception of his performance. The person whose righteousness is hidden, done in secret before God alone, is free of the crowd entirely, owes it nothing, needs nothing from it, can act rightly whether the crowd approves or not, because the crowd was never the audience. That freedom is profoundly political. It produces a person who cannot be bought with approval or silenced with disapproval, who does the right thing in the secret place and lets the public chips fall where they may, who is not performing for any human audience and is therefore not controllable by any human audience. The hidden life produces the free citizen, and the free citizen, unowned by the crowd, is the only kind of person who can actually live the sermon in public, because the sermon in public will not win you applause, it will win you a cross, and only the person who stopped needing the applause can pay that price.

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*The person whose righteousness is  
performed for a crowd is owned by the  
crowd, but the one whose devotion is  
hidden before God alone is free, and  
the free citizen is the only one who can*

*actually live the sermon in public.*

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**I THINK THIS IS** why the great witnesses to the sermon, the ones I named a few chapters ago, were so often people of deep hidden devotion, people whose public courage grew out of a long secret life with God. Bonhoeffer's resistance grew out of the hidden disciplines of Finkenwalde, the daily prayer and meditation and the secret formation of the heart. King's public nonviolence grew out of a private life of prayer that the cameras never saw, a hidden wrestling with God in the small hours that produced the man who could stand unflinching before the dogs. The visible courage was real, and it was political, and it changed the world, but it grew from a root that was hidden, from the secret place where the heart was formed before the body was tested. You cannot live the sermon in public on willpower. The public obedience is too costly, too contrary to every instinct, and it will collapse under pressure unless it is fed from a hidden source. The secret life is not an escape from the political demands of the kingdom. It is the engine of them, the place where the citizen is formed who can actually pay the public price, and a church that has lost the hidden life will never manage the public obedience, because it has cut the fruit off from the root.

So the most political thing a citizen of the kingdom does may be the most hidden, the secret prayer in the closed room, the unannounced fasting, the giving the left hand does not know about, the long formation of the heart before God where no audience can see. We want the public victory without the private discipline, the visible courage without the hidden devotion, and it cannot be had, because the one grows only from the other. The sermon sends us into the secret

place not to escape the world but to be made into the kind of people who can finally face it, who can love the enemy and tell the truth and refuse the power because we have been formed, in secret, by the Father who sees in secret, into citizens free enough and strong enough to live the constitution in the open, at cost. Come into the room. Shut the door. That is where the revolution begins, in the hidden place, in the formation of the heart, long before it ever reaches the street.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

# A Community, Not a Collection of Individuals

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**I HAVE USED THE** word community throughout this book, almost reflexively, and I want to stop and defend it, because there is a deep and stubborn individualism in the way we have read the sermon, and I have probably reinforced it even while arguing against it, and the individualism is one more way the spiritualizing has done its work. We hear the sermon as a set of instructions to me, the individual believer, a private program of self-improvement that I undertake alone in the privacy of my own discipleship, and almost everything about that framing is wrong, because the sermon is addressed to a people and describes a common life, and it cannot be lived by individuals in isolation at all.

Start with the obvious thing we read past, which is that Jesus is addressing a crowd and forming a community, not coaching individuals one at a time. The you in the sermon is plural far more often than singular. You are the salt of the earth, you are the light of the world, addressed to a people, a community, a city on a hill, which is by definition a collective

and not an individual. One person cannot be a city on a hill. A city is a society, a polis, a community with a shared life, and the light that the world is supposed to see is the light of that shared life, the visible difference of a people who live together in a way the world cannot match. The whole image collapses if you individualize it. There is no such thing as a one-person city, a solitary light on a hill, a private salt. The metaphors require a community, a body of people whose common life is the thing the world sees, and the moment we read the sermon as a program for individuals we have lost the city and kept only scattered, isolated believers each trying to be a little better on their own.

And the commands themselves cannot be obeyed alone, which is the deeper point. Consider what they actually require. Love your enemies, which requires a community to hold you to it when every instinct says to retaliate, a body of people who will not let you sink back into the tribal hatred everyone else is swimming in. Do not lay up treasure, which requires a community that shares its goods, that makes a different economic life possible, that catches you when you let go of your security, because no individual can sustain the renunciation of Mammon while embedded in a society organized entirely around its worship, but a community can become a different economy, a place where the open hand is normal because everyone holds the same open hand. Be reconciled to your brother before you offer your gift, which requires a brother, requires a community of relationships within which reconciliation happens, makes no sense at all for an isolated individual. Again and again the commands assume a people, a shared life, a body within which the impossible becomes possible because it is being attempted together, and they become genuinely impossible the moment

you try to live them alone, which is exactly how we have tried to live them.

This is why the recovery of the sermon and the recovery of the church are finally the same project, and cannot be separated. The sermon describes a community, and only a community can live it, and so the question of whether the sermon can be obeyed is inseparable from the question of whether we will become the kind of community it describes. The witnesses I have named were all communities, not heroic individuals, the desert monasteries, the Anabaptist congregations, Bonhoeffer's seminary at Finkenwalde, the churches that fueled the civil rights movement. They lived the sermon because they lived it together, held one another to it, made a different common life possible, became small cities on hills whose shared life the watching world could see. The individual believer trying to love his enemies alone, in isolation, embedded in a tribal culture with no community to sustain him, will fail, and should not be surprised to fail, because the sermon was never given to be lived that way. It was given to a people, to be lived as a people, and the privatization of it into a solitary spiritual discipline is one more way we have made it unlivable while keeping it on the books.

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*One person cannot be a city on a hill.  
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**THE POLITICAL WEIGHT OF** this is enormous, because it means the church's primary political act is not to lobby or to vote or to campaign but simply to be the community the sermon describes, to exist as a visible alternative, a city on a hill whose common life is the witness. We keep thinking our political faithfulness lies in influencing the structures of the world, in getting our people into power, in winning the levers of the state, and the sermon points somewhere else entirely, to the formation of a people whose shared life is so different from the surrounding order that it constitutes, by its mere existence, a challenge to that order and a sign of another one. The early church changed the world not by seizing the empire's machinery but by being a community so unlike the empire that the empire could not account for it, a people who shared their goods and welcomed the outcast and refused the sword and forgave their enemies and cared for the sick the world abandoned, and the watching pagans said, see how they love one another, and were drawn in. That was the politics of the early church, the politics of being a different kind of community, and it is the politics the sermon describes, and we have largely abandoned it for the politics of influence and control, which is the politics of the world.

So when I say the sermon is political, I do not finally mean that it gives us positions on the issues of the day, though its principles bear on those issues. I mean that it calls into being a polis, a community, a city, an alternative society ordered by the constitution of the kingdom, and that the existence of that community is itself the most political thing in the world, a living demonstration that another way of ordering human life is possible, that the world's arrangement of power and money and violence and fear is not the only one, that there is a city on a hill where the meek inherit and the enemies are loved

and the poor are at home and the truth is told and the powerful serve. We do not have that community, mostly, not really, not yet. We have collections of individuals pursuing private spiritualities while behaving, in our common political life, exactly like everyone else. But the sermon holds out the possibility, calls us toward it, describes the city we could be, and the recovery of it would be the most powerful witness the church could offer, more powerful than any program or platform, the simple, visible, unaccountable fact of a community actually living the impossible life of the kingdom, together, in the open, where the world can see.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-NINE

# Cheap Grace and the Defanging of the Mountain

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**BONHOEFFER GAVE US** A phrase that names, better than any other, what the church has done to the Sermon on the Mount, and I have used it in passing and now want to give it a chapter, because it is the key that unlocks the whole pattern of betrayal I have been describing. Cheap grace. He coined it in 1937, in the opening pages of the very book built on this sermon, and he meant by it the grace we bestow on ourselves, the grace that costs nothing, the forgiveness without repentance, the discipleship without the cross, the grace that justifies the sin without transforming the sinner. Cheap grace, he wrote, is the deadly enemy of our church, and he was right, and the place you can see it most clearly is in what we have done with the mountain.

Here is the move, and once you see it you will see it everywhere. We take the costly commands of the sermon, the love of enemies, the renunciation of Mammon, the turning of

the cheek, the narrow gate, and we acknowledge that they are too hard for us, that we cannot actually live them, and then, instead of letting that impossibility drive us to the costly grace that would actually transform us, we use it as a permission. We say, since we cannot live the sermon perfectly, since we are saved by grace and not by works, the sermon must not really require us to live it at all, must be meant only to humble us, to show us our need, to drive us to grace, after which we may go on living more or less as we did before, comforted by a forgiveness that has cost us nothing and changed nothing. We turn the impossibility of the sermon into an excuse for not attempting it, and we call the excuse grace. That is cheap grace, the grace that uses the cross of Christ as a reason to avoid the cross of discipleship, the grace that hears come and die and answers with come and be comfortable.

Bonhoeffer saw that this was a perversion of the gospel so complete that it had become the gospel's opposite while wearing its clothes. Costly grace, he wrote, is the gospel which must be sought again and again, the gift which must be asked for, the door at which a man must knock. Cheap grace is grace without discipleship, grace without the cross, grace without Jesus Christ living and incarnate. The difference is everything. Costly grace is grace that actually grips a life and changes it, that produces the obedience the sermon describes, that takes the impossible commands not as occasions for despair but as the shape of the life that grace is even now producing in the one who keeps asking for it. Cheap grace is grace that leaves the life exactly as it was, that forgives the sin without disturbing the sinner, that lets us keep our enemies and our Mammon and our comfortable accommodation while assuring us that it is all covered, all

forgiven, all fine. And the church in the wealthy world has run, for generations, on cheap grace, has built its whole appeal on it, has offered people a forgiveness that asks nothing and a salvation that changes nothing and a Jesus who makes no claim on the actual conduct of an actual life.

This is the theological engine of the defanging, the mechanism by which the most demanding ethical teaching in the New Testament was rendered harmless. We did not have to repeal the sermon. We only had to surround it with cheap grace, to wrap it in a doctrine of forgiveness so undemanding that the commands became optional, ideals to admire rather than orders to obey, a portrait of a perfection we are not actually expected to attain because grace has covered our failure to attain it before we even tried. And the genius of the move is that it sounds like the gospel, sounds like an exaltation of grace over works, sounds like the very heart of the Reformation's insight that we are saved by faith and not by our own righteousness. But it is a counterfeit of that insight, a corruption of it, because the grace that saves is the grace that transforms, the grace that produces the obedience, and a grace that leaves the life unchanged is not the grace of the gospel at all but the cheap imitation Bonhoeffer named as the deadly enemy of the church. The Reformers never meant that grace excuses us from discipleship. They meant that grace alone makes discipleship possible. We have twisted the first into the second, and called the twist the gospel.

*Cheap grace is the grace we use the  
cross of Christ to avoid the cross of  
discipleship, the grace that hears come  
and die and answers with come and be  
comfortable.*

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**THE CURE IS THE** recovery of costly grace, and it is costly, that is the whole point, it cannot be had cheaply, cannot be received without the receiving changing everything. Costly grace takes the sermon seriously as the actual shape of the redeemed life, not a standard we are excused from but the very thing grace is producing in us, and it takes the commands not as crushing demands we meet by our own effort, which would be works-righteousness, nor as ideals we are excused from, which is cheap grace, but as the description of the life that the Father will work in us if we keep asking, seeking, knocking. The impossible commands drive us not to despair and not to permission but to the costly grace that actually changes the heart, that does in us what we cannot do in ourselves, that produces over time the love of enemies and the open hand and the truthful tongue that no amount of self-effort could ever produce. The sermon and grace are not enemies. The sermon is the portrait of what costly grace produces, and only the person who has received that grace can begin to live it, and the receiving is the most expensive thing in the world, because it costs us the self we were and gives us back a self we are still learning to recognize.

I have to confess that I have preached cheap grace, that I

have stood in the pulpit and offered people the comfortable forgiveness that asks nothing, that I have softened the sermon's demands out of a pastoral kindness that was really a failure of nerve, that I have let my people, and myself, off the hook the sermon was meant to leave us hanging on. It is the easiest thing in the world to preach, cheap grace, because everyone wants it, the forgiveness without the change, the salvation without the cross, and a preacher who offers it will be loved, and a preacher who offers costly grace will be resisted, because costly grace asks for everything. Bonhoeffer paid for costly grace with his life, and I have too often settled for the cheap version that costs nothing and saves no one, and the recovery of the sermon in my own ministry has had to begin with repenting of that, with the hard turn from the grace that comforts to the grace that transforms, from the gospel that leaves people as they are to the gospel that bids them come and die and so, finally, come and live. The mountain was defanged by cheap grace. It can only be recovered by the costly kind, and the costly kind is the only kind that was ever real.

## CHAPTER FORTY

# The Sermon and the Anxious Heart

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**I WANT TO RETURN** to anxiety, because I named it earlier as the engine that drives the worship of Mammon, and because I think it is, in our particular moment, the deepest obstacle to living the sermon, the inner condition that makes the whole costly life seem impossible. Do not be anxious, Jesus said, more than once, at length, with a tenderness he does not always show, and I have come to think that this command, which looks like the gentlest in the sermon, is actually the hinge on which our obedience to all the others turns, because almost everything the sermon asks us to give up, we cling to out of fear.

Look at what anxiety does to the commands. Why do we lay up treasure on earth, hoard our security, refuse to hold our possessions with an open hand. Because we are afraid there will not be enough, afraid of the future, afraid of need, and the anxiety drives the accumulation. Why do we hate our enemies, treat them as threats to be destroyed rather than people to be loved. Because we are afraid of them, afraid of

what they might do to us, afraid of losing the conflict, and the fear curdles into hatred. Why do we lie, spin, shade the truth to serve our side. Because we are afraid the truth will cost us, afraid of losing the argument, afraid of what honesty might surrender. Why do we grasp for power, reach for the sword, refuse the weakness of the cross. Because we are afraid of being vulnerable, afraid of what will happen if we let go of control. Underneath almost every command we disobey is a fear, and the fear is the thing Jesus addresses when he says do not be anxious, do not let the dread of insufficiency and loss and vulnerability run your life. The conquest of anxiety is the precondition of the whole obedience, because a frightened person cannot live the sermon, and we are all, mostly, frightened.

And our moment is frightened in a particular and intensified way, because we have built a civilization that runs on the manufacture and exploitation of anxiety. The whole machinery of our economy and our media is engineered to make us afraid, because frightened people consume, frightened people click, frightened people can be sold the security they have been taught to crave and rallied against the enemies they have been taught to dread. We are bathed, every day, in a deliberate cultivation of fear, fear of scarcity, fear of the future, fear of the other, fear of falling behind, fear of being unsafe, and the fear is profitable, the fear is useful, the fear keeps the whole anxious machine running. And into that engineered anxiety Jesus speaks the most countercultural words in the sermon, do not be anxious, look at the birds, consider the lilies, your Father knows what you need, seek first the kingdom and trust the rest to him. He is asking us to step off the machine, to refuse the fear that the whole order is manufacturing, to live as people who are not

afraid in a civilization organized around being afraid, and that refusal is, in its quiet way, as radical as anything else in the sermon.

Because a person who is genuinely free of anxiety is free of the system's primary means of control, and that freedom is profoundly political. The frightened person can be manipulated, can be sold things, can be rallied to hatred, can be made to grasp and hoard and lie and reach for power, because all of those are responses to fear and the fear can be turned up at will by anyone who knows how. The person who is not afraid, who has placed their security somewhere the machine cannot reach, who genuinely trusts the Father for tomorrow and is therefore not driven by the dread of insufficiency, is free in a way the frightened are not, cannot be controlled by the manufactured fear, cannot be sold the false security or rallied to the convenient hatred, because the lever that moves everyone else does not move them. This is why the conquest of anxiety is not a private matter of personal peace but a political act of liberation, a stepping out of the fear that the powers depend on, and a community of people genuinely free of the engineered anxiety would be ungovernable by the means that govern everyone else, a free people in a frightened world.

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*Almost everything the sermon asks us  
to give up, we cling to out of fear, and  
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**BUT I HAVE TO** be honest about how hard this is, because it is the teaching I have found hardest to live, harder even than loving my enemies, and I said so when we walked through it the first time. The anxiety runs deep, deeper than reasoning can reach, wired into me by a childhood without a father and a culture that taught me to measure my safety in dollars, and the command do not be anxious can feel, to a genuinely anxious person, like one more burden, one more thing I am failing at, the addition of guilt to fear. So I want to say carefully what Jesus is and is not doing, because the command is not a rebuke. He is not scolding the anxious, not adding shame to their fear, not telling them simply to stop, as though anxiety were a choice they were stubbornly making. He is doing something gentler and deeper. He is pointing the anxious heart away from itself, away from the futile attempt to secure tomorrow, toward a Father who already knows and already cares and already provides, and he is inviting us to transfer our trust, slowly, painfully, against the grain of our fear, from the barn to the Father, from the accumulation to the providence, from the control we cannot actually have to the care we have been promised. It is not a command to feel calm. It is an invitation to trust, and the trust is built slowly, in the hidden place, in the daily practice of handing tomorrow back to God.

And I have seen, in glimpses, what it looks like when a person actually makes that transfer, when the anxiety loosens its grip and a human being becomes genuinely free of the fear that runs the world, and I said before that it is one of the most powerful witnesses there is, and I will say it again here because it is the thing I most want to be true of me and most often am not. A life that does not run on fear. A person who gives without calculating, who holds the future open-handed,

who loves the enemy because they are not afraid of the enemy, who tells the truth because they are not afraid of what it costs, who refuses the power because they are not afraid of being weak, who has placed their whole security in a Father the moth and rust cannot reach and is therefore free, in a frightened world, to live the impossible life of the kingdom. That freedom is the fruit of the conquest of anxiety, and the conquest of anxiety is the fruit of trust, and the trust is the gift of the Father to those who keep asking for it, and so we are back where the sermon always sends us, to the hidden place, to the asking, to the slow reception of a grace that casts out fear, and with the fear, casts out the chains.

## CHAPTER FORTY-ONE

# The City on the Hill Now

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**I HAVE SPENT THIS** book describing a community that mostly does not exist, holding up a constitution mostly unobeyed, and that is a hard place to leave a reader, in the gap between the vision and the reality, so I want to do something more concrete in this chapter. I want to describe, as plainly as I can, what a community actually shaped by the whole sermon would look like in our moment, not in the abstract but in the particulars, in money and enemies and truth and the poor and power, because I think we have lost the ability even to imagine it, and the imagining is the first step toward the becoming.

Picture it, then. A community, an actual congregation, that has decided to take the sermon as its constitution and to live it together, and start with money, because money is where most of us are least free. This community holds its possessions loosely, genuinely loosely, not as a slogan but as a practice. Its members know one another's finances well enough to share them, and they do share them, so that there is no one among them in real need while others have abundance, the way the early church arranged it. They have, in some real measure, stepped off the treadmill of

accumulation, do not measure their lives by the size of their barns, give in a way that actually reduces their own security rather than in a way that costs them nothing, and they are therefore free of the anxiety that drives everyone around them, free to take risks, free to be generous past the point of prudence, free because their security is in the Father and in one another and not in the barn. The watching world cannot account for their freedom with money, because the world knows of no security but accumulation, and here is a people who seem genuinely unafraid of need.

Now the enemies. This community does not hate. In a culture organized around the sorting of people into friends and enemies and the energetic hatred of the enemies, this congregation stubbornly refuses to participate, prays for the people it is supposed to despise, will not traffic in the contemptuous dismissal even of those who are genuinely wrong, wants the good of its opponents and not their destruction, cannot be recruited into the tribal hatred that everyone else takes for granted. When the world expects them to despise the other side, they confound the expectation by loving them, blessing them, refusing the contempt, and the refusal is visible, public, costly, because it wins them no approval from their own tribe and is met with suspicion from both. They are, in a polarized world, a people who will not be polarized, who keep loving across the line everyone else is policing, and the watching world cannot account for that either, because the world knows of no politics but the politics of friends and enemies, and here is a people who seem to have enemies they actually love.

*We have lost the ability even to imagine  
the community the sermon describes,  
and the imagining is the first step  
toward the becoming.*

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**NOW THE TRUTH. THIS** community does not lie. Its word can be trusted absolutely, its yes is yes, it refuses to spread what it has not verified, refuses the convenient falsehood even when the falsehood would serve its cause, holds itself to a truthfulness so complete that in a world of spin and manipulation its plain word is a kind of wonder. People come to it precisely because it does not lie, because it is an island of trustworthy speech in a sea of deception, because here, at last, is somewhere you can believe what you are told. And the poor. This community is not a middle-class institution that does charity to the poor from a distance but a place where the poor are members, present, belonging, where the line between helper and helped has been erased because all are equally dependent on the same grace, where a person's poverty does not exclude them and a person's wealth does not elevate them, where the social hierarchy of the surrounding world has been overturned inside the walls. And power. This community does not grasp for power, does not reach for the sword, does not try to win by the world's means, but holds to the slow weak power of love and service and witness, refuses the coercion the world relies on, trusts that the meek inherit the earth and does not try to seize it, and is therefore free of the corruption that power brings, free to serve rather than to rule.

I am describing, of course, the early church, more or less, and I am describing the communities of the great witnesses, the monasteries and the Anabaptists and Finkenwalde and the churches of the movement, and I am describing something that has existed, in fragments and seasons, throughout the history of the people of God, never perfectly, always at cost, but really, actually, in the world, visible. So this is not a fantasy. It is not a utopia that could never be. It is a description of communities that have existed and do exist, here and there, in pockets, wherever a body of people has decided to take the sermon seriously and to live it together and to pay the price. The reason it sounds like a fantasy is that it is so rare, so far from the normal experience of church in the comfortable world, that we have lost the memory of it, have come to assume that church means a collection of individuals managing their private spiritualities while behaving in their public lives exactly like everyone else. But it does not have to mean that, has not always meant that, and the sermon holds out the other possibility, the city on the hill, and asks whether we will become it.

And I have to be honest, finally, that the community I have just described is not the community I lead, not yet, not fully, and that the gap between the vision and the reality is present in my own congregation and in my own life, and that I have written this chapter as much to convict myself as to inspire anyone else. It is easy to describe the city on the hill. It is hard, costly, slow, and dangerous to build it, and the building requires exactly the death the sermon has been describing all along, the death of our security and our hatred and our lies and our comfort and our power, the long obedience of a people willing to lose the life they had in order to find the life the kingdom offers. I cannot tell you that my church is that

city. I can tell you that I have seen the city in glimpses, in moments, in particular acts of love and generosity and truth and courage that broke through the ordinary accommodation and showed me what we could be, and that those glimpses are enough to convince me that it is real, that it is possible, that the sermon is not a beautiful impossibility but a livable, world-changing reality for any community willing to pay its cost. The city on the hill is not a memory and not a fantasy. It is a possibility standing in front of us, and the only question is whether we will climb down the mountain and build it.

## CHAPTER FORTY-TWO

# The Sermon and the Family

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**I HAVE FIVE SONS**, and I came to faith without a father, and so when I read the sermon I cannot help but read it as a man who has spent his whole life thinking about what fathers are for and what their absence does, and I want to give a chapter to the family, because the sermon has more to say about it than we usually notice, and because the family is where most of us first learn, or fail to learn, the things the sermon commands. The kingdom is a household before it is a nation, and the sermon's politics begin at the kitchen table.

Notice how saturated the sermon is with the language of fatherhood. Your Father who is in heaven, Jesus says, again and again, more than a dozen times across the three chapters, until the phrase becomes the atmosphere of the whole address. Love your enemies, so that you may be sons of your Father in heaven. Give in secret, and your Father who sees in secret will reward you. Pray to your Father. Your Father knows what you need. Do not be anxious, your heavenly Father feeds the birds and clothes the lilies and will

much more care for you. The entire sermon is held within the relationship of a Father and his children, and the ethics of it flow directly from the character of that Father, because the children are called to bear the family likeness, to do what their Father does, to be perfect as he is perfect, which means to love as he loves. The sermon is not a list of rules issued by a distant lawgiver. It is the description of a family resemblance, the way the children of a particular Father naturally come to live because they have his nature in them, and the whole thing falls apart if you remove the Father at its center.

This is why the passage about asking and seeking and knocking lands where it does, on the argument from fatherhood, which one of you if his son asks for bread will give him a stone, and I said before that this passage is the ground I have had to learn to stand on, because I did not have the father it assumes. And I want to say more about that here, because I think the wound of the absent or failing father is one of the deepest wounds in our world, and the sermon speaks directly into it in a way we have not heard. Because Jesus is not finally appealing to our experience of human fathers, many of whom failed us, but to the Father who is the original of which every human father is a copy, the one whose goodness our fathers were meant to reflect and so often did not. For those of us who grew up fatherless, or with fathers who wounded rather than blessed, the sermon does not rub salt in the wound by holding up a fatherly goodness we never knew. It offers, at last, the Father we needed and never had, the one whose care is not multiplied from our experience but is the source our fathers failed to draw from, held out now by the only One who can actually give it.

And then there is what the sermon does to the family as we

usually understand it, which is to relativize it, to set it within something larger, and this is harder for us to hear in a culture that has made the family almost an idol. The prayer Jesus teaches begins with our Father, not my Father, and the our is wider than any household, includes the poor and the stranger and the enemy, all of them children of the same Father, all of them brothers and sisters whether we chose them or not. The kingdom creates a family larger than the family, a household of faith that cuts across the bonds of blood, and Jesus elsewhere says this with a sharpness that scandalizes us, that his mother and brothers are whoever does the will of his Father, that the bonds of the kingdom run deeper than the bonds of biology. This does not abolish the natural family, but it relativizes it, sets it within the larger family of the kingdom, refuses to let it become an ultimate loyalty, a tribe we love at the expense of the wider household of God. The sermon will not let me love my own children while despising my neighbor's, will not let the family become one more tribe whose love stops at its own boundary, because the Father of my children is the Father of all children, and the family resemblance I am to teach my sons is a love that does not stop at the family.

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*The sermon offers, at last, the Father we  
needed and never had, the one whose  
goodness our fathers were meant to  
reflect and so often did not.*

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**SO WHAT DOES IT** mean to raise children in the light of this

sermon, and I ask it as a father still in the middle of the work, not as one who has finished it. It means, I think, that the first political act of a Christian family is the formation of children who will be citizens of the kingdom, who will love their enemies and tell the truth and hold their possessions loosely and refuse the power that the world worships, and that this formation happens not primarily through instruction but through the shared life of the household, through what the children see their parents actually do with money and enemies and truth and power. My sons are learning the sermon, or failing to learn it, less from what I preach than from what I practice, from whether they see me love the people I am supposed to hate, hold my possessions with an open hand, tell the truth when it costs me, refuse the contempt the culture trades in. The household is the first city on the hill, the first community where the kingdom is either visible or invisible, and the formation of children in it is among the most political things a parent does, because it is the slow making of the citizens who will either build the city or abandon it.

And I have to confess that I feel the weight of this more than I can say, because I know that my sons are watching, and that what they see is not the sermon perfectly lived but a father struggling to live it, failing often, succeeding sometimes, caught in the same accommodation I have spent this book naming. They will learn the sermon partly from my obedience and partly from my repentance, partly from the times I get it right and partly from the times I get it wrong and turn around and name the failure and ask forgiveness, which may be the most important thing they see, because a father who admits his failure and turns from it is teaching the very thing the sermon teaches, that the kingdom is for the poor in

spirit, for the ones who know their need, for the people honest enough to repent. I cannot give my sons a perfect father, having never had one and not being one. But I can give them a father who is trying to live the sermon and is honest about how far short he falls, and who keeps pointing them past himself to the Father in heaven who never falls short, and perhaps that, the broken father pointing to the perfect one, is the most faithful fathering a fallen man can do.

## CHAPTER FORTY-THREE

# The Long Obedience and the Slow Work

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**IF I HAVE MADE** the sermon sound like a single heroic decision, a dramatic crossing from the wide road to the narrow gate accomplished in a moment of resolve, then I have misled you, and I want to correct it before we come to the end, because the living of the sermon is not finally a heroic leap but a long, slow, unglamorous obedience, the work of a lifetime, mostly hidden, mostly undramatic, a matter of ten thousand small faithfulnesses far more than a few large ones. Eugene Peterson borrowed a phrase to describe the Christian life, a long obedience in the same direction, and it is the truest thing anyone has said about what it actually takes to live this sermon.

We are drawn to the dramatic version because it is easier to admire and, in a strange way, easier to attempt, because a single heroic act has a beginning and an end, a clear cost paid in a clear moment, after which you can rest. The witnesses I have named tempt us this way, because we remember them for their dramatic ends, Bonhoeffer's gallows, King's

assassination, the martyrs' fires, and we imagine that living the sermon means being ready for some great climactic sacrifice. But that is not mostly what it means, and it is not even mostly how those witnesses lived. Bonhoeffer's gallows was the end of years of ordinary, daily, hidden obedience, the long slow formation at Finkenwalde, the daily prayer, the small faithfulnesses that built the man who could finally face the large one. King's courage in Birmingham grew out of years of unglamorous organizing and daily prayer and the slow disciplines of a life formed for the moment of crisis. The dramatic acts we remember were the fruit of long obediences we do not see, and the long obedience is the real thing, the daily, repetitive, unspectacular faithfulness that builds, over years, the kind of person who can do the dramatic thing when the dramatic thing is finally required.

And the love of enemies, which I keep returning to as the hardest command, is not mostly a matter of dramatic forgiveness of great wrongs but of daily refusal of small contempts, the thousand little moments when the contemptuous thought rises and must be put down, the temptation to share the cruel dismissal that must be resisted, the prayer for the opponent that must be prayed again because yesterday's prayer did not finish the work. You do not learn to love your enemies in a single heroic act of forgiveness. You learn it in the long, slow, daily discipline of refusing the contempt, over and over, for years, until the refusing begins, very gradually, to change the heart that does it. The same is true of the renunciation of Mammon, which is not one grand act of giving everything away but a daily, repeated loosening of the grip, a thousand small decisions to hold the open hand, a long obedience in the direction of generosity that slowly remakes a fearful, grasping heart into a

free and open one. The sermon is lived in the small and the daily and the repeated, far more than in the large and the singular and the dramatic, and a great deal of our failure to live it comes from waiting for the heroic moment while neglecting the daily discipline that is the actual substance of the thing.

This is why the spiritual disciplines matter so much, the hidden practices Jesus commands, the secret prayer and the fasting and the giving, because they are the daily, repeated, unspectacular means by which the long obedience is sustained and the heart is slowly formed. You cannot love your enemies on willpower in the moment of provocation, but you can be slowly formed, through years of praying for them in the secret place, into a person whose first response to the enemy is no longer hatred. You cannot renounce Mammon by a single act of will, but you can be slowly formed, through years of the discipline of generosity, into a person whose grip on possessions has genuinely loosened. The disciplines are the slow work, the long obedience made daily and practical, the means by which grace does its patient transformation of a heart over years and decades rather than in a moment, and a church that has lost the disciplines has lost the means by which the sermon is actually lived, has been left with only the heroic version it cannot sustain and the cheap version that costs nothing.

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*The dramatic acts we remember were  
the fruit of long obediences we do not  
see, and the long obedience is the real*

*thing.*

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**I FIND THIS BOTH** humbling and freeing, and I want to say why, because I think it matters for anyone who has read this book and felt crushed by the distance between the sermon and their own life. It is humbling because it means there is no shortcut, no single decision that accomplishes the whole thing, no heroic leap that lets me skip the long, slow, daily work of being formed into a citizen of the kingdom over a lifetime. But it is freeing for exactly the same reason, because it means I do not have to live the whole sermon perfectly today, do not have to leap the entire distance in a single bound, do not have to be crushed by the gap between where I am and where the sermon calls me. I only have to take the next step in the same direction, to refuse the next contempt, to loosen my grip a little more, to tell the truth in the next small thing, to pray for the enemy one more time, and to trust that the long obedience in the same direction will, over years, by grace, carry me further than I can see from here. The sermon is not a cliff to be scaled in a single desperate climb. It is a road to be walked, a long obedience, one faithful step after another, in the same direction, for a lifetime, with the grace of the Father meeting us at every step.

And this is the answer, finally, to the despair that an honest reading of the sermon produces, the despair I have felt and probably provoked, the sense that the standard is so high and my life so far below it that the whole thing is hopeless. It is not hopeless, but the hope is not in a sudden dramatic transformation, it is in the long obedience, in the slow work of grace over a lifetime, in the patient daily faithfulness that does not see its own progress but is being changed

nonetheless, the way a child grows without ever feeling himself grow. I am not the man the sermon describes. But I am, by grace, slowly, with many failures and many returns, becoming more like him than I was, and the becoming is real even when it is invisible, and it will not be finished in this life, and that is all right, because the One who began the work has promised to complete it, and my part is only to keep walking, one obedient step after another, in the same direction, toward the city on the hill, trusting the grace that carries me there.

## CHAPTER FORTY-FOUR

# What the Watching World Is Waiting For

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**I CAME TO FAITH** as an atheist who read this sermon cold and thought no one actually lives like this, and concluded that the absence of such a community was an argument against the church. I have circled back to that experience again and again in this book, because I think it holds the key to where we are and what is at stake, and I want to give it one final chapter before the end, because I have come to believe that the watching world is waiting for exactly the community the sermon describes, and that the church's failure to be it is the greatest obstacle to faith in our time.

Here is what I mean. When I was an unbeliever, my objection to Christianity was not primarily intellectual, though I dressed it in intellectual arguments. My deepest objection was that the church did not seem to be anything. It did not seem to be a community living a life the world could not produce on its own. It seemed, in its actual behavior, indistinguishable from every other interest group, fighting the same fights by the same means, loving the same friends

and hating the same enemies, hoarding the same security and fearing the same future, just with a different vocabulary stapled on top. And I reasoned, not unreasonably, that if the gospel were true, if it really were the power of God to remake human beings, then surely it would show, surely there would be somewhere a community visibly different, visibly free of the hatred and the fear and the greed, a city on a hill I could point to and say, there, that cannot be explained by ordinary human causes, that requires a different explanation. And I could not find it, and the not finding was, for me, a powerful argument that the church did not actually believe what it claimed, because believing it would have changed them, and they were not changed.

I was wrong about my conclusion, as I said in the introduction, but I was right about my observation, and I have come to think that my observation was, in a strange way, an act of faith in the sermon, a refusal to accept that the church's actual life was good enough, an insistence that if the gospel were true it would produce the community the sermon describes. The world makes this demand of us, often without knowing it is making it, and the demand is exactly right. The world is waiting to see the sermon lived, waiting for the city on the hill, waiting for a community whose life requires the explanation of grace because it cannot be explained any other way, and when the world looks at the church and sees only a tribe behaving like every other tribe, it concludes, as I concluded, that there is nothing here that needs explaining, nothing the gospel has produced that ordinary human causes could not produce on their own. Our failure to be the city on the hill is not a private failure of personal piety. It is the removal of the very evidence the world is looking for, the hiding of the light, the salt that has lost its savor, and it is, I

am convinced, driving more people away from Christ than all the intellectual objections combined.

Because the intellectual objections, in my experience, are mostly downstream of this. People say they cannot believe because of the problem of evil or the reliability of the scriptures or the conflict with science, and those are real questions deserving real answers, but underneath them, very often, is the deeper thing, the observation that the people who claim this faith do not seem to be transformed by it, that the gospel they preach has not made them visibly different, that the tree is not bearing the fruit. And no intellectual answer reaches that objection, because it is not finally an intellectual objection. It is a demand for evidence, the evidence of a transformed community, and the only thing that can meet it is the thing the sermon describes, a city on a hill, a people whose life cannot be explained without grace. The watching world is not waiting for better arguments. It is waiting for a community it cannot explain, and we have given it arguments instead, because arguments are cheaper than the city on the hill, cost us nothing of our security and our hatred and our power, and the world has rightly found the arguments unpersuasive in the absence of the life.

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*The world is waiting to see the sermon  
lived, a community whose life requires  
the explanation of grace because it  
cannot be explained any other way.*

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**THIS PUTS THE WHOLE** argument of this book in its final

light, because it means that the recovery of the sermon is not finally about our own faithfulness, important as that is, but about the world, about the watching world that is waiting for the evidence only a transformed community can provide. When we spiritualize the sermon, defang it, reduce it to private inner life, we are not only disobeying our King. We are withholding from the world the one thing it most needs to see, the visible demonstration that the gospel is true because it has produced a community the world cannot account for. The salt that has lost its savor is not merely useless to itself. It is useless to the earth it was supposed to preserve. The light hidden under the basket does not merely fail itself. It fails the people who were sitting in the darkness waiting for a light. Our failure to live the sermon is a failure of love toward the watching world, a withholding of the witness it is waiting for, and the recovery of the sermon would be, before it was anything else, an act of love toward the very world that is watching us fail.

So I want to end this chapter by addressing the people who are where I was, the watchers, the skeptics, the ones who have looked at the church and found it wanting and concluded that the gospel cannot be true because it has not transformed the people who claim it. I want to say that your observation is right and your conclusion is wrong, the same thing I said about my own younger self. You are right that the church should be a community the world cannot explain, right that its failure to be one is a scandal, right to demand the evidence of a transformed life and right to find much of what calls itself Christianity unpersuasive in the absence of that evidence. But the failure of the church to live the sermon is not evidence that the sermon is false. It is evidence that the church has not believed it, has chosen the wide road and the

cheap grace and the accommodation to power, and your own insistence that it should be otherwise is, though you may not know it, a witness to the truth of the very sermon the church has betrayed. The standard by which you judge us is the sermon's own standard, and your judgment is just, and the answer to it is not a better argument but a better church, the city on the hill the sermon describes, which by the grace of God we might yet, at cost, become.

## CHAPTER FORTY-FIVE

# The Beatitudes as a Political Program

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**I HAVE WALKED THROUGH** the Beatitudes one at a time, near the beginning of this book, and I want to return to them now, near the end, and read them together, as a whole, because I have come to think that the eight blessings are not merely a description of kingdom character but something closer to a political program, a set of commitments that, taken together, would reorder the common life of any community that adopted them. We have read them as a portrait of an individual soul. I want to read them as the platform of a polis.

Take them in order and feel them as commitments rather than as moods. Blessed are the poor in spirit is the commitment to need, to dependence, to the empty hands that can receive the kingdom, and politically it is the commitment to be a community where need is admitted rather than hidden, where the poor are at home, where no one has to perform self-sufficiency to belong. Blessed are those who mourn is the commitment to honesty about the world's

brokenness, the refusal of the mandatory cheerfulness that pretends everything is fine, and politically it is the commitment to stay awake to suffering in a culture committed to sleep, to be a people who feel the wrongness of the world and refuse the anesthesia. Blessed are the meek is the commitment to the refusal of domination, to power held in check and bent toward service, and politically it is the commitment to renounce the world's way of holding power, to lay down the sword, to wait for the inheritance rather than seizing it. These three alone, need admitted, suffering felt, power renounced, would already constitute a community radically unlike any nation that has ever existed.

Continue. Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness is the commitment to justice, to the aching desire for the world to be set right, and politically it is the commitment to be a people who cannot make peace with injustice, who want the world put right the way a starving man wants bread, who labor for the setting-right while trusting God to complete it. Blessed are the merciful is the commitment to forgiveness, to the refusal to insist on the last ounce of what we are owed, and politically it is the commitment to be a community that does not run on the satisfaction of grievance and the exaction of debts but on the costly extension of mercy. Blessed are the pure in heart is the commitment to integrity, to the undivided life, to being what we appear to be, and politically it is the commitment to be a community without the rot of hidden corruption, without the gap between the public face and the private deal. And blessed are the peacemakers is the commitment to active reconciliation, to the dangerous work of standing between enemies, and politically it is the commitment to be a people who make peace at cost rather than war for advantage, who

do the family business of the God who reconciles.

And then the eighth, which is not a separate commitment but the consequence of the other seven, blessed are the persecuted, the recognition that a community committed to all of this, to admitted need and felt suffering and renounced power and hungered justice and extended mercy and undivided integrity and made peace, will be intolerable to a world organized around the opposite, and will be attacked for it, and should understand the attack not as a sign of failure but as a sign of faithfulness. The eight blessings, read together, are the platform of a community so unlike every existing political order that its very existence would be a standing challenge to all of them, and the persecution is simply the world's predictable response to being challenged. This is why I say the Beatitudes are a political program. They are not eight private virtues to cultivate in the soul. They are eight public commitments that, taken together, would constitute a new kind of polity, a city on a hill ordered by an entirely different set of priorities than any nation has ever attempted.

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*The eight blessings are not eight private virtues to cultivate in the soul. They are the platform of a new kind of polity, a city on a hill ordered by entirely different priorities.*

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**AND THE GENIUS OF** reading them this way is that it

exposes how thoroughly we have privatized them, and what we have lost in the privatizing. When the poor in spirit becomes merely a recommended humility, we lose the commitment to be a community where the poor are at home. When mourning becomes merely personal sadness, we lose the commitment to stay awake to the world's suffering. When meekness becomes merely personal gentleness, we lose the commitment to renounce the world's power. Every privatization of a beatitude is the loss of a political commitment, the shrinking of a public platform into a private mood, and the sum of all those shrinkings is the church we have, a collection of individuals cultivating private virtues while their common political life looks exactly like everyone else's. The recovery of the Beatitudes as a program would be the recovery of the church as a polis, a community with an actual platform, an actual alternative way of ordering its common life, and that recovery is, I am convinced, the most urgent political task before us, more urgent than any position on any issue, because it is the recovery of the very thing that was supposed to make us a city on a hill.

I want to be careful, as always, not to turn this into a partisan platform, a set of positions to be sorted onto the left or the right of our current arguments, because the Beatitudes will not be sorted that way, and the moment we try to sort them we have lost them again, in the other direction this time, by turning the constitution of the kingdom into a campaign brochure for one of the world's factions. The program of the Beatitudes indicts every existing political order, left and right alike, because every existing order is built on the accumulation of power and security and the sorting of the world into friends and enemies, and the Beatitudes renounce all of that. They are not a more righteous version of

the world's politics. They are a different kind of politics altogether, the politics of a community that has stopped playing the world's game of power and security and grievance and has begun, at cost, to live by the priorities of the kingdom, and that different politics belongs to no party and can be captured by no faction, because it stands in judgment over all of them. The Beatitudes are a program, but the program is the kingdom's, not Caesar's, and the church's calling is to live it, visibly, as a city on a hill, and to let the watching world, including all of its warring factions, see what a community looks like when it is governed by the constitution of the mountain rather than the constitutions of the earth.

## CHAPTER FORTY-SIX

# The Sermon and the End of the World

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**THERE IS A DIMENSION** of the sermon I have touched but not yet named directly, and it runs underneath everything, and I want to bring it into the open before the end, because without it the whole sermon hangs in the air with nothing to support it. The sermon is eschatological. It is oriented toward the end, toward the coming of the kingdom in fullness, toward the day when God will set the world right once and for all, and every command in it makes sense only in the light of that coming day. Remove the end, and the sermon becomes a beautiful impossibility. Keep the end in view, and it becomes the only sensible way to live.

Consider how the promises attached to the Beatitudes all point forward, to a satisfaction that has not yet arrived. The meek shall inherit the earth, but they have not inherited it yet, the inheritance is future, promised, certain but not yet possessed. Those who hunger for justice shall be satisfied, but they are not satisfied yet, the satisfaction belongs to the day when God sets the world right. Those who mourn shall be

comforted, but the comfort is not complete, is still being waited for. The Beatitudes live in the gap between the already and the not yet, between a kingdom that has truly come in the person of Jesus and a kingdom that has not yet been consummated, and the citizens of the kingdom are people who live now by the certainty of what is coming then, who order their present lives by the future they have been promised, who can renounce the world's power because they know who finally inherits the earth, who can refuse the world's security because they know how the story ends. The sermon is a way of living in the present in the light of a guaranteed future, and without that future it is groundless.

This is why the sermon can ask what it asks, can command the love of enemies and the renunciation of Mammon and the turning of the cheek, because it is not asking us to live as though the world's present arrangement were the final word but as though the coming kingdom were. If the world as it is, the world of power and violence and accumulation, is the final reality, then the sermon is madness, a recipe for being crushed, a strategy for losing every contest the world cares about. But if the world as it is is passing away, if the kingdom is coming, if the meek really will inherit the earth and the proud really will be brought low and the justice we hunger for really will be done, then the sermon is not madness but wisdom, the only sane way to live, the alignment of our present lives with the future that is actually coming rather than with the present that is actually passing. The whole sermon is a wager on the end, a bet that God's coming kingdom is more real than the world's present arrangement, and that those who live now by the kingdom's priorities are on the right side of a history whose ending is already secured.

And the ending is secured, that is the heart of it, secured by the resurrection of the one who preached the sermon, which I named a few chapters ago as the vindication of everything he taught. The resurrection is the firstfruits of the end, the breaking-in of the coming kingdom into the middle of history, the proof that the future the sermon promises is not wishful thinking but guaranteed reality, because the meekest man who ever lived has already been raised and vindicated and given all authority, and what happened to him is the promise of what will happen to the world. The sermon is anchored not in a vague hope but in an event, the empty tomb, which turns the future from a possibility into a certainty, and on the strength of that certainty the citizens of the kingdom can live now by the priorities of the end, can renounce the power and the security and the grievance, can love the enemy and tell the truth and hold the open hand, because they know, on the evidence of the resurrection, exactly how the story ends.

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*The whole sermon is a wager on the end, a bet that God's coming kingdom is more real than the world's present arrangement, and those who live by it are on the right side of a secured history.*

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**THIS ESCHATOLOGICAL DIMENSION IS** also the answer to the charge that the sermon is impractical, that it cannot work

in the real world, that a community living by it would simply be destroyed by the powers that do not. The charge assumes that the present world is the real world, the final reality, the only game in town, and that anything which does not succeed by its rules is foolishness. But the sermon denies exactly that assumption. It insists that the present world is not the final reality, that it is passing away, that the real world, the lasting one, is the kingdom that is coming, and that to live by the kingdom's rules now, even at the cost of losing by the present world's rules, is not impractical but supremely practical, an investment in the only reality that will finally endure. The community that lives the sermon may indeed lose by the world's measures, may be crushed by the powers, may end up on a cross, as its King did. But the cross was not the end of the story, and the resurrection is the proof, and the community that takes up its cross in the light of the empty tomb is not throwing its life away but investing it in the kingdom that the grave could not hold. The sermon is impractical only if death is the end, and the resurrection has settled the question of whether death is the end.

So the sermon comes down, finally, to a question of what we believe about the future, and that is the most political question of all, because our politics always flows from our eschatology, from what we believe the world is finally coming to. If we believe the world is coming to nothing, to a final triumph of power and death and the strong over the weak, then we will live by the logic of power, will grasp and hoard and fear and hate, will try to win the world's game because the world's game is the only one there is. But if we believe the world is coming to the kingdom of God, to the vindication of the meek and the satisfaction of the just and the wiping away of every tear, then we will live by the logic of that kingdom,

will renounce and give and trust and love, will play a different game entirely because we know which game finally counts. The sermon asks us to believe the second thing and to live accordingly, to stake our lives on the coming of the kingdom, to be people of the end living in the middle, citizens of a future that is breaking in. And the resurrection is why we can, the firstfruits of the harvest, the down payment on the promise, the proof that the end the sermon points toward is not a dream but a destination, already secured, already coming, already, in the risen King, begun.

## CHAPTER FORTY-SEVEN

# Counting the Cost

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**BEFORE THE DESCENT, BEFORE** the conclusion, I have to do the thing the sermon itself does at its end, which is to count the cost honestly, to make sure that no one closes this book with a romantic notion of what the kingdom life involves, a sense that they have understood something beautiful without grasping what it would actually demand. Jesus never recruited under false pretenses. He told people plainly that the road was hard and the gate was narrow and the cost was a cross, and any book that has made the sermon sound inspiring without making it sound costly has betrayed the very thing it described. So let me count the cost, plainly, as the end approaches.

The cost of the sermon is, first, your security. The renunciation of Mammon, the refusal to lay up treasure, the holding of possessions with an open hand, the seeking of the kingdom first and the trusting of the Father for the rest, all of it costs you the security you have arranged your life around, the barn you were counting on, the cushion against the future you have worked to build. To live the sermon is to give up the deep human project of making yourself safe, of accumulating enough that you no longer have to depend on anyone, of

buying with money the protection against need that the whole anxious world is buying. It is to choose, deliberately, to be less safe by the world's measures, to hold your future open-handed, to depend on a Father you cannot see rather than on a barn you can. That is a real cost, paid in real dollars and real anxiety, and I will not pretend it is anything less, because I feel the weight of it in my own grasping heart every day.

The cost of the sermon is, second, your tribe. The love of enemies, the refusal of contempt, the prayer for those who persecute you, the stubborn loving across the line everyone else is policing, all of it costs you your standing in your tribe, because the tribe is held together by its shared enemies and its shared contempt, and the person who refuses to hate the tribe's enemies will be suspected and resented and finally rejected by the tribe. To love your enemies is to be a traitor to your own side, to forfeit the approval that comes from hating the right people, to stand alone in the no-man's-land between the warring camps where the peacemaker always gets struck by both. That is a real cost, paid in real relationships and real belonging, the loss of the warm solidarity of the tribe that hates together, and anyone who tells you that loving your enemies will make you popular has not tried it, because it makes you, in a polarized world, an enemy to everyone.

The cost of the sermon is, third, your power. The renunciation of domination, the laying down of the sword, the refusal to win by the world's means, the trust that the meek inherit the earth so that you do not have to seize it, all of it costs you the power you might have had, the control you might have exercised, the victories you might have won by playing the world's game. To live the sermon is to give up the sword, and giving up the sword means giving up the ability to compel, to force, to make people do what you want, to protect

yourself and your cause by the means that actually work in the world. It means choosing the slow weak power of love over the fast efficient power of coercion, and choosing it knowing that you will often lose, that the people who keep the sword will beat you, that the cross is where this road leads. That is a real cost, the cost of refusing the only kind of power the world respects, and it is perhaps the hardest cost of all, because it feels like choosing to lose.

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*Jesus never recruited under false pretenses. He told people plainly that the road was hard and the gate was narrow and the cost was a cross.*

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**AND THE COST OF** the sermon is, finally and comprehensively, yourself, the self you have built, the self that is invested in its security and its tribe and its power, the self that has arranged its whole life around the very things the sermon asks you to renounce. When Christ calls a man, Bonhoeffer wrote, he bids him come and die, and that is the final accounting of the cost, that the sermon asks for your death, the death of the self that grasps and hates and dominates and fears, so that a new self can be raised in its place, the self the Beatitudes describe, the citizen of the kingdom. It is not a partial cost, not a tithe of your life that leaves the rest intact. It is everything, the whole self, laid down so that it can be taken up again transformed. And that is why the gate is narrow and the road is hard and the travelers are few, because the cost is total, is a death, and

most of us, myself included on most days, would rather keep the self we have than die into the self the kingdom offers.

So I will not let you close this book thinking the sermon is merely beautiful, because it is not merely beautiful, it is costly, it asks for your death, and the only honest invitation is one that names the cost. But I will say, in the same breath, the thing that makes the cost bearable, which is that the one who asks it paid it first, went through the narrow gate and down the hard road and onto the cross ahead of us, lost his security and his tribe and his power and his very life, died the death he asks us to die, and was raised, so that the cost he names is not a road into oblivion but a road into resurrection, a dying that leads to life. The cost is real, and total, and a cross. But the cross is not the end of the story, and the one who asks us to take it up has already carried it through death and out the other side, and stands now on the far side of it, scarred and alive, calling us to follow him through the same death into the same life. Count the cost. It is everything. And then count what it purchases, which is everything also, the life of the kingdom, the city on the hill, the inheritance of the earth, the satisfaction of every hunger, and a Father who will wipe away every tear. The cost is a cross. The purchase is the kingdom. Jesus, who paid the first and offers the second, asks only that we follow him down the mountain and into both.

## CHAPTER FORTY-EIGHT

# The Sermon Against the Church and For It

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**I HAVE SPENT** A great deal of this book indicting the church, and I have tried throughout to stand inside the indictment rather than above it, but I am aware that a reader could close these pages with a kind of despair about the church itself, a sense that the institution is so compromised, so accommodated to power, so far from the sermon, that it should perhaps be abandoned altogether. I want to resist that conclusion, near the end, because it is wrong, and because the sermon itself, rightly read, is both a judgment on the church and a hope for it, and to hear only the judgment is to misread it as badly as to hear only the comfort.

The sermon is against the church, yes, in the sense that it stands in judgment over everything we have made the church into, every accommodation, every defanging, every trade of faithfulness for power. I have named those judgments at length, and they are real, and the church that has made the trades deserves them, and I deserve them, and there is no honest reading of the sermon that does not begin with the

church under its judgment. But the sermon is against the church the way a prophet is against the people, which is to say from within the covenant, out of love, for the sake of a restoration, not the way an enemy is against an enemy, from outside, for the sake of destruction. The prophets thundered against Israel, named her sins without mercy, mourned over her failures, but they never stopped loving her, never abandoned her, never concluded that she should be discarded, because their judgment was the judgment of a love that wanted her restored, not the judgment of a contempt that wanted her gone. And the sermon's judgment on the church is of the same kind, a prophetic judgment, a wounding for the sake of healing, a naming of the failure for the sake of the repentance that could lead back to faithfulness.

I have to say this because the spirit of our age makes it very easy to stand outside the church and despise it, to catalog its failures with relish, to use its real and grievous sins as a justification for abandoning it altogether, and that spirit is itself the very contempt the sermon condemns, the speck-hunting, the judgment from above, the writing-off of a whole community as beyond hope. I feel the pull of it myself, the temptation to distance myself from the failing church, to position myself as the enlightened critic who sees its sins clearly and is therefore not implicated in them, and that temptation is a trap, because the moment I stand outside the church to judge it, I have left the only place from which the sermon can be faithfully read, which is inside, among the people, under the same judgment, holding the same log. The sermon does not give me a platform from which to despise the church. It gives me a mirror in which to see myself, and the church is not some other body I can condemn from a distance, it is my body, my people, my failure, and the only

faithful response to its sins is not abandonment but repentance, my own first.

And the sermon is for the church, profoundly for it, because the sermon is the church's own constitution, the description of what we are called to be, the portrait of the city on the hill we could yet become. The judgment is real, but the judgment exists for the sake of the restoration, and the restoration is possible, because the sermon is not only a standard we have failed but a promise of what grace can produce in a people willing to return to it. I have named the witnesses, the communities across the centuries that took the sermon seriously and lived it at cost, and they are the proof that the church can be the church, that the city on the hill is not a lost cause but a recurring reality, that wherever a body of people returns to the constitution and pays its price, the kingdom becomes visible again. The same church that has betrayed the sermon has also, again and again, recovered it, and the history of the church is not only the history of accommodation but also the history of renewal, of the remnant who returned, of the communities who took the mountain seriously and shamed the rest of us by actually living it. The church is not beyond hope. It is, in every generation, one repentance away from renewal.

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*The sermon's judgment on the church  
is the judgment of a prophet, a  
wounding for the sake of healing, a  
naming of the failure for the sake of  
the repentance that leads back.*

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**SO I WANT TO** say plainly, to anyone tempted to abandon the church over its failures, that the answer to a church that has betrayed the sermon is not to leave it but to call it back, not to stand outside and condemn but to stand inside and repent, not to abandon the city on the hill but to help rebuild it. The failures are real, and they are grievous, and I have not minimized them. But the church is the community to whom the sermon was given, the body called to live it, the people among whom the kingdom is meant to become visible, and to abandon the church is to abandon the only community on earth that has even been entrusted with the constitution of the kingdom, however badly we have kept it. The sermon does not call us out of the church but deeper into it, into the costly work of recovering its true life, of becoming, with our brothers and sisters, the city on the hill we were always meant to be. That work is hard, and slow, and full of failure, and it is the work the sermon calls us to, and there is no shortcut around it, no purer community waiting elsewhere, no escape from the long obedience of helping a failing church return to its own constitution.

And there is a mercy in this for me, and for anyone who has felt crushed by the distance between the sermon and the church, because it means I do not have to be the city on the hill alone, do not have to achieve the whole kingdom by my own faithfulness, do not have to despair when I see how far my church and I fall short. I have only to take my place among the people, under the judgment and within the hope, and to do the slow work of repentance and return alongside my brothers and sisters, trusting that the same grace that has renewed the church in every generation can renew it again, can renew me, can take a failing community and a failing pastor and make of us, slowly, at cost, by grace, something

more like the city the sermon describes. The sermon is against the church and for it, judgment and hope, mirror and promise, and the only faithful place to stand is inside it, holding the log, doing the work, trusting the grace, helping the people I belong to climb back toward the constitution we were given and have so often betrayed and might yet, together, begin again to live.

## CHAPTER FORTY-NINE

# The Mountain and the Plain

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**MATTHEW SETS THE SERMON** on a mountain, and I have made much of that, the new Sinai, the new Moses, the lawgiver on the height. But there is another account of what may be the same sermon, in Luke, and Luke does something different with the geography that I want to attend to before the descent, because it completes the picture. Luke says Jesus came down and stood on a level place, a plain, and there he taught. The mountain and the plain. And I have come to think that the two settings are not a contradiction to be resolved but a truth to be held, that the sermon belongs both on the mountain and on the plain, and that the church has tended to keep it on the mountain precisely so as not to have to bring it down to the plain.

The mountain is the place of vision, of the height from which the whole landscape can be seen, of the law given from above with all the authority of the heights. And there is something right about putting the sermon there, because the sermon is a vision, a height, a constitution handed down with

divine authority, and to read it on the mountain is to feel its grandeur, its scope, its claim to govern the whole of life. But the danger of the mountain is that we leave the sermon there, admire it from the valley as a distant and beautiful height, a vision too elevated for the ordinary plain where we actually live, and the keeping of the sermon on the mountain becomes a way of keeping it out of our lives, a way of honoring it precisely by not bringing it down. The mountain can become an excuse, a height so high that no one is expected to climb it, a vision so grand that no one is expected to live it, and the church has often kept the sermon on the mountain in exactly this way, as a glorious and impractical ideal admired from the comfortable plain below.

Luke's level place corrects this, brings the sermon down to where the people actually live, to the plain, the ordinary ground, the place of the everyday. Because the sermon was never meant to stay on the mountain. It was meant to be lived on the plain, in the valley, in the ordinary places where people work and trade and quarrel and raise their children and bury their dead, the level ground of actual life. The love of enemies is not a mountain vision to be admired but a plain reality to be practiced, in the actual conflicts of the actual neighbor. The renunciation of Mammon is not a height to be contemplated but a daily decision on the level ground of an actual budget. The truth-telling is not an ideal to be honored but a practice to be lived in the ordinary speech of an ordinary day. The sermon comes down from the mountain to the plain, and the bringing of it down is the whole point, and a sermon that stays on the mountain, however reverently we admire it, has not yet done the thing it was given to do.

This is finally what the descent means, the thing I have been pointing toward and will name fully in the conclusion,

that Jesus goes up the mountain to give the sermon and then comes down to live it, and that we are called to follow him in both directions, up to receive the vision and down to live it on the plain. The mountain without the plain is a vision we admire and disobey. The plain without the mountain is a life with no vision, no constitution, no height to live toward. The two together are the whole sermon, the vision received on the height and lived on the level ground, the constitution given from above and embodied below, and the Christian life is the constant movement between them, up to the mountain to be formed by the vision and down to the plain to live it, and back up again, and down again, the rhythm of a people who keep climbing to receive the sermon and keep descending to obey it.

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*The sermon was never meant to stay on  
the mountain. It was meant to be lived  
on the plain, in the ordinary places  
where people work and quarrel and  
raise their children and bury their  
dead.*

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**I THINK THE DEEPEST** temptation of the religious life is to prefer the mountain to the plain, to love the vision more than the obedience, to find on the heights a spiritual experience so satisfying that we never want to come down to the hard ground where the vision must be lived. Peter felt this on a different mountain, the mount of transfiguration, where he

saw Jesus in glory and wanted to build shelters and stay, to remain on the height in the presence of the vision, and Jesus led him back down, down to the plain, down to the crowd and the need and the conflict and the cross that waited in the valley. The vision is not the destination. The plain is the destination, the ordinary ground where the vision becomes flesh, and the religious soul that prefers the mountain to the plain has mistaken the means for the end, has fallen in love with the experience of the height and forgotten that the height exists for the sake of the obedience below. The sermon is given on the mountain and lived on the plain, and the living on the plain is the point, and the mountain exists to send us down to it.

So as this book approaches its end, I want to turn us toward the descent, toward the plain, toward the ordinary ground where the sermon must finally be lived or not lived at all. We have spent these chapters on the mountain, receiving the vision, tracing the constitution, feeling the height and the grandeur and the claim of it. And the danger of a book like this is the danger of the mountain itself, that we will close it having had a vision, having been moved by the height, having admired the sermon from the comfortable plain, and will never make the descent, never bring the vision down to the level ground of an actual life, never let the sermon touch the budget and the enemy and the speech and the power of an ordinary day. The mountain was always meant to lead to the plain. The vision was always meant to become flesh. And so the only fitting way to end is to come down, to descend from the mountain of vision to the plain of obedience, to take the sermon off the page and into the life, which is the one thing the sermon has been asking for from its first word, and the one thing we have spent two thousand years finding ways to

avoid.

## CHAPTER FIFTY

# The Sermon and the Stranger

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**THERE IS A WORD** that runs quietly underneath the whole sermon, never stated as a command but present in every line, and it is the word stranger, the outsider, the one who does not belong, the one outside the circle, and I want to give it a chapter before the descent because the treatment of the stranger is the test the sermon keeps applying without naming it, and it is the test our moment is failing as badly as any test the church has ever faced. The kingdom is a kingdom that takes in the stranger, and a community that closes its doors against the outsider has failed the sermon at its root, whatever else it gets right.

Look at who is on the hillside. Matthew told us, at the end of chapter four, that the crowd came from Galilee and the Decapolis and Jerusalem and Judea and beyond the Jordan, which is to say from inside Israel and from outside it, from the Jewish heartland and from the Gentile territories, a mixed crowd of insiders and outsiders, the chosen people and the strangers, all gathered on the same hillside to hear the same

sermon. The sermon is addressed, from the first, to a mixed multitude, to a crowd that already crosses the great boundary between insider and outsider, and the kingdom it describes is one in which that boundary is dissolved, in which the stranger is welcomed, in which the circle of belonging is drawn as wide as the love of the Father who sends his rain on the just and the unjust alike. The God of the sermon does not restrict his good gifts to the insiders, does not reserve his sun and his rain for the chosen, but pours them out on everyone, the stranger included, and the children of that God are called to bear the family likeness, to welcome the stranger as their Father welcomes the stranger, to draw the circle of belonging as wide as he draws it.

This is woven through the commands even where the word is not spoken. Love your enemies, which means love the ones outside the circle, the ones who do not belong, the strangers and the others and the foreigners who have been placed on the far side of the boundary. If you greet only your brothers, Jesus says, what more are you doing than others, naming the narrow love that stays inside the circle and refuses the stranger, and calling his people to a wider love that crosses the boundary. The Golden Rule, do to others what you would have them do to you, requires the imaginative leap into the place of the other, the stranger included, the refusal to remain locked inside our own circle and our own kind. The whole sermon presses against the boundary between insider and outsider, between us and them, between the belonging and the stranger, and it presses in one direction only, toward the dissolving of the boundary, toward the widening of the circle, toward the welcome of the one who does not belong.

And our moment is failing this test, failing it in the church as badly as anywhere, because we live in a time of walls and

fears and the energetic policing of the boundary between us and them, the insider and the stranger, and the church, instead of standing against that fear as the sermon demands, has too often joined it, has baptized the closing of the doors, has found scriptural cover for the very exclusion the sermon condemns. We have learned to fear the stranger, to see the outsider as a threat rather than a guest, to draw the circle of our belonging tight and to defend it against the very people the sermon tells us to welcome, and we have done it while claiming to follow the One who was himself a stranger, born outside the inn, fled into Egypt as a refugee, with nowhere to lay his head, who identified himself so completely with the stranger that he said whatever you did to the least of these, the hungry and the naked and the imprisoned and the stranger, you did to me. We have closed our doors against the very face of Christ, who comes to us in the stranger, and we have called the closing prudence, and the sermon stands over us in judgment.

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**I HAVE TO BE** careful here, because the welcome of the stranger raises real and hard questions that I do not want to wave away with a slogan, questions about how a community

holds its identity while opening its doors, how it welcomes the outsider without dissolving into nothing, and I named some of that tension in the chapter about the dogs and the pearls, the wisdom about what to entrust to whom. The welcome of the stranger is not the abolition of all discernment, not a naive pretense that there are no dangers, not a refusal to be wise. But the discernment must never become the excuse, the wisdom must never curdle into the fear that closes the door, and that is precisely what it has become for much of the church, a sophisticated justification for the very exclusion the sermon condemns, a way of dressing our fear of the stranger in the language of prudence. The sermon allows for wisdom. It does not allow for the closed door, the policed boundary, the circle drawn tight against the outsider, the treatment of the stranger as a threat rather than a guest, and a church that has made its peace with those things has failed the test the sermon keeps applying.

So a community shaped by the whole sermon would be, before almost anything else, a community of welcome, a place where the stranger finds a door open rather than a wall raised, where the outsider is received as a guest who might be an angel unaware, where the circle of belonging is drawn as wide as the love of the Father. It would stand against the fear of its age, against the walls and the policing and the energetic exclusion of the other, not because it is naive about danger but because it has decided to risk the welcome rather than the wall, to err on the side of the open door, to receive the stranger as it would receive Christ, who comes to it precisely in the stranger. That community would be a wonder in a frightened, wall-building age, a city on a hill whose open door the watching world could not explain, and the explanation, if

anyone asked, would be the simplest in the world, that we welcome the stranger because our Father welcomes the stranger, because his rain falls on everyone, because the kingdom has no walls, because the King himself was a stranger, and because we have learned, slowly, at cost, against the fear of our age, to see in every outsider the face of the One who comes to us as a guest and asks to be let in.

## CHAPTER FIFTY-ONE

# Reading the Sermon Together

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**I WANT TO END** the body of this book, before the descent, with a word about how the sermon is to be read, because I have been doing a particular kind of reading throughout these pages, and I think the way we read the sermon is itself part of whether we will obey it, and the church has read it wrongly in a way that has helped us avoid it, and I want to name the better way before we come down the mountain. The sermon is to be read together, in community, on our knees, as people under its authority rather than over its meaning, and almost everything about how we usually read it gets this wrong.

We read the sermon, mostly, as individuals, alone, in private, as a text to be studied and understood and applied to our own personal lives, and I have argued throughout that this individualizing is a distortion, that the sermon was given to a people and can only be lived by a people. But it is also true that the sermon can only be rightly read by a people, that the individual reading it alone is at the mercy of his own

blindness, his own self-justification, his own capacity to bend the text away from the places it would touch him, and that it is only in community, only when we read it together and let one another see what we have hidden from ourselves, that the sermon can do its full work. I read love your enemies and quietly exempt the enemies I most want to keep hating, and I would never notice the exemption on my own, but in community, where others can see my hatred more clearly than I can, the text gets a chance to reach the place I had walled off. The sermon read alone is the sermon at the mercy of the reader's self-deception. The sermon read together is the sermon given a chance to overcome it.

And we read the sermon, mostly, as masters of the text, as people who stand over it to determine its meaning, to decide what it does and does not require, to soften its hard sayings and qualify its absolute commands and find the interpretations that let us off the hook. I have spent this book naming those softenings, the interim ethic and the counsel for the elite and the inner-attitude-only and the cheap grace, and every one of them is a way of standing over the sermon rather than under it, of making ourselves the masters of its meaning rather than the servants of its command. The better way is to read it on our knees, under its authority, as people who have surrendered in advance the right to soften it, who come to it not asking how little it might require but how much, not looking for the escape but for the obedience, not standing over the text to master it but kneeling under it to be mastered. That is a different posture entirely, and it produces a different reading, because the text that you have surrendered to in advance will say things to you that the text you stand over will never say.

This is what I have tried to do in this book, however

imperfectly, to read the sermon under its authority rather than over its meaning, to refuse the softenings, to let the hard sayings be hard, to ask not how little but how much, and I am aware that I have often failed, that I have my own softenings I cannot see, my own exemptions I have quietly preserved, my own places where I have stood over the text rather than under it. That is exactly why the sermon must be read in community, because I cannot see my own blindness, cannot catch my own self-justification, cannot notice the places where I have bent the text away from myself, and I need the others, the brothers and sisters who can see what I have hidden, who can hold me to the sermon where I have let myself off, who can read it with me and for me and against me until it reaches the places I had sealed against it. The reading of the sermon is itself a communal act, a work of the body, a thing we do together under the text's authority, and the individual reading it alone, standing over it, softening it to his own comfort, is the reading that has helped us avoid it for two thousand years.

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*The sermon read alone is the sermon at  
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it.*

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**THERE IS ONE MORE** thing about reading the sermon, and it is the most important, which is that it must be read in the

light of the cross and the empty tomb, read as the words of the one who lived it and died it and was raised, because read any other way it is either a crushing burden or a beautiful impossibility. Read as the commands of a distant lawgiver, the sermon crushes, because no one can keep it and it offers no help to the one who cannot. Read as the inspiring ideals of a wise teacher, the sermon floats, a beautiful vision with no power to produce what it describes. But read as the words of the crucified and risen King, the one who paid the cost he names and conquered the death he asks us to die and pours out the grace that produces the obedience he commands, the sermon becomes neither a crushing burden nor a floating ideal but a livable gospel, the description of the life that grace is even now producing in the people who keep asking for it. The sermon must be read at the foot of the cross, by people who know that the one who commands this life has lived it and died it and risen, and who therefore read his hardest commands not as impossible demands but as the shape of the life he is giving them, the family likeness he is forming in them, the kingdom he is bringing and has already, in himself, begun.

So before we come down the mountain, this is how I would have us read what is written there, together and on our knees and at the foot of the cross, in community under the text's authority in the light of the risen King. Not alone, where our blindness is safe. Not over the text, where our softenings are easy. Not apart from the cross, where the commands only crush. But together, where we can see one another's logs, and under the authority of the King, where we have surrendered the right to soften, and at the foot of the cross, where the grace that produces the obedience is poured out on the people who keep asking. That is how the sermon was meant

to be read, and reading it that way is the beginning of obeying it, and obeying it is the whole point, and obeying it happens on the plain, at the bottom of the mountain, in the ordinary ground of an actual life, which is where we are going now, because the reading is finished and the descent begins.

## CHAPTER FIFTY-TWO

# The Sermon and the Body Politic

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**I HAVE INSISTED FROM** the first page that the sermon is political and not partisan, that it indicts both sides of every argument we are having, that it belongs to no party and can be captured by no faction, and I want to make that claim one last time, with full force, before the descent, because it is the claim most likely to be misheard and most important to get right. The sermon is the most political text in the New Testament, and it is the least partisan, and the two facts are one fact, and the church's inability to hold them together is the source of much of its current ruin.

Here is the confusion that destroys us. When people hear that the sermon is political, they assume it means the sermon takes a side in our current political conflicts, that it endorses one party or one program, that to be faithful to it is to vote a certain way and oppose a certain enemy. And so the moment a preacher says the sermon is political, half the congregation braces to be told they are on the wrong side, and the other half waits to be confirmed in being on the right one, and

either way the sermon has already been captured, sorted into the world's categories, enlisted in the world's fights. But the sermon refuses the sorting. It is political in a deeper and older sense, the sense of how a community orders its common life, how power is held, how the poor are treated, how enemies are dealt with, how truth is told, and in that sense it stands over all our partisan fights, judging them all, belonging to none of them, calling into being a community whose politics is so far outside our current categories that it cannot be placed on the map we are fighting over.

Consider how thoroughly it indicts every side. It indicts the love of power, which every faction shares. It indicts the hatred of enemies, which every faction practices. It indicts the worship of Mammon and the trafficking in falsehood and the contempt for the other, which are the common currency of all our politics, left and right, every party and every program. There is no faction in our current conflicts that the sermon does not judge, because every faction is playing the world's game of power and security and grievance, and the sermon stands against the game itself, not against one team in it. To read the sermon as the endorsement of any party is to miss the whole thing, because the sermon is not a better player in the world's game, it is the announcement of a different game entirely, a different politics, the politics of a kingdom that has stopped playing for power and security and grievance and has begun to live by the priorities of the cross.

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**THIS IS WHY THE** church's partisan capture is such a catastrophe, because it takes the one text that could have made us a genuine alternative to the world's politics and enlists it in the world's politics, turns the constitution of the kingdom into a campaign brochure for one of the world's factions, and in doing so destroys the very thing that made it the constitution of the kingdom. A church that has been captured by a party has nothing the world does not already have, is just another faction quoting scripture, just one more interest group scrambling for power by the world's means with the world's contempt for the world's enemies. The watching world sees it perfectly, sees that we have become indistinguishable from the partisans around us, and concludes, rightly, that our religion is a cover for our politics rather than a judgment on it. And the cure is not to swing to the other party, which would be the same captivity in the other direction, but to recover the sermon's own politics, the politics of the kingdom, which belongs to no party and judges them all, and to become again the genuine alternative the world is waiting for.

So I will say it one final time, as plainly as I can. The sermon is political. It is not partisan. It calls into being a community whose common life is so different from every existing political order that it stands as a challenge to all of them, a city on a hill that no faction can claim, a polis ordered by the constitution of the kingdom rather than the platforms of the earth. To live it is not to win the world's political fights but to stop fighting them on the world's terms, to step off the field of power and security and grievance and onto the different ground of the kingdom, to become a people the world cannot place because we are playing a different game. That is the politics of the sermon, and it is the most radical politics there is, more radical than any party, because it does not seek to win the world's game but to end it, to displace it with the reign of God, to pray your kingdom come and to mean it, which is the daily sedition of people who serve a different King and refuse, finally, to be enlisted in the kingdoms that are passing away.

## CONCLUSION

# Come Down the Mountain

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**AND SO WE HAVE** to come down.

The sermon ends, and the crowds are astonished, and Matthew tells us in the very next verse what happened next, and it is the most important sentence for understanding everything we have said. When he came down from the mountain, great crowds followed him, and behold, a leper came to him. He came down from the mountain. The sermon was not the end. It was the beginning. Jesus did not stay on the height, did not remain in the realm of vision and constitution and beautiful impossible commands. He came down, immediately, to the plain, to the crowd, to the leper, to the ordinary ground where the kingdom he had described would now have to be lived, and the first thing he did when he came down was to touch a man no one was allowed to touch, to reach out his hand and lay it on the unclean flesh of an outcast, and the sermon became flesh in that touch before the dust of the mountain had even settled. The descent is the point. The sermon was always pointing down, off the page, off

the height, into the touch, into the life, into the plain.

I have spent this whole book on the mountain with you, and I am aware of the danger of it, the danger I named in the last chapter, that we will have had a vision and never made the descent, that the book will have moved you and changed nothing, that you will close it with the sermon more beautiful in your mind and no more present in your life, one more house built on the sand of hearing without doing. I do not want that. I would rather you forgot every sentence I have written and remembered only the one thing the sermon itself keeps saying, which is not admire this but do this, not understand the kingdom but enter it, not be moved by the vision but come down the mountain and live it on the plain. The whole sermon ends with two builders, and the only difference between them is that one did what he heard and the other did not, and the storm is coming for both, and the doing is the only thing that will hold. Everything I have written is hearing. The doing is yours, and it is on the plain, and it is now.

What does the descent look like, concretely, for you, and I cannot answer that for you because I do not know your plain, your valley, your ordinary ground, the particular budget and the particular enemy and the particular conflict and the particular fear that the sermon must touch in your actual life. But I know it has a shape, and the shape is the cross, because the descent always leads there, down from the mountain to the plain and on down to the hill outside the city where the empire nails up the ones who actually live the kingdom. To come down the mountain is to begin the long obedience, the slow daily faithfulness, the refusing of the next contempt and the loosening of the grip on the next dollar and the telling of the next hard truth and the laying down of the next bid for

power, and it is to do all of that knowing where it leads, knowing the road is hard and the gate is narrow and the cost is a cross, and to walk it anyway, because the one who walked it first was raised, and the tomb is empty, and the meek really will inherit the earth.

I came to faith because of this sermon, read cold by an atheist who thought no one lived like this and that the absence of such a community was an argument against the church. I have spent these pages trying to say that I was right about the observation and wrong about the conclusion, that the sermon really does describe a life almost no one is living, and that this is not because it cannot be lived but because we decided it was not meant to be, defanged it, spiritualized it, kept it on the mountain so we would never have to bring it down to the plain. And I have tried to take it back, to read it as the marching orders it is, the constitution of a kingdom, the platform of a city on a hill, a public and visible and costly alternative to the way the world arranges its power and money and enemies and truth. I do not know if I have succeeded. I know that I have not lived it, not fully, that I write as a man still on the mountain looking down at the plain I have not yet fully descended to, still grasping my security and fighting my contempt and reaching for my small powers, still inside the indictment I have spent the whole book naming.

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*The descent is the point. The sermon  
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page, off the height, into the touch, into  
the life, into the plain.*

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**BUT I HAVE SEEN** the city, in glimpses, in moments, in the desert monks and the drowned Anabaptists and the hanged pastor and the murdered preacher and the ordinary saints in my own congregation whose acts of love and truth and courage broke through the accommodation and showed me what we could be. And the glimpses are enough. They are enough to convince me that the sermon is true, that it can be lived, that the city on the hill is not a fantasy or a memory but a possibility standing in front of us, waiting only for a people willing to come down the mountain and pay its cost. The watching world is waiting for that city, waiting for a community it cannot explain, waiting, though it does not know it is waiting, for the gospel to become visible in a life it cannot account for by any ordinary cause. And we have it in our hands to give them that, or to withhold it, to come down the mountain and build the city or to stay on the height admiring the vision while the world below concludes, rightly, that we never believed it.

So come down the mountain. That is the whole invitation, and it is the whole cost, and I cannot make it sound easy because it is not, and I will not resolve it for you because the sermon does not resolve, it leaves weight, it sends you down the hard road toward the narrow gate carrying the cross you are each told to take up. The mountain was never the destination. The plain is the destination, the ordinary ground of your actual life, the budget and the enemy and the conflict and the fear, and the leper waiting at the bottom whom no one will touch. Jesus came down and touched him, and the sermon became flesh, and now he turns to us, scarred hands open, and says follow me, down the mountain, into the touch, into the cost, into the kingdom that is coming and has already, in him, begun. The sermon is over. The descent is

yours. And somewhere at the bottom of the mountain, on the plain, in the valley, in the ordinary ground where you actually live, there is a leper waiting, and a cross, and a kingdom, and a King who went first.

Come down the mountain.